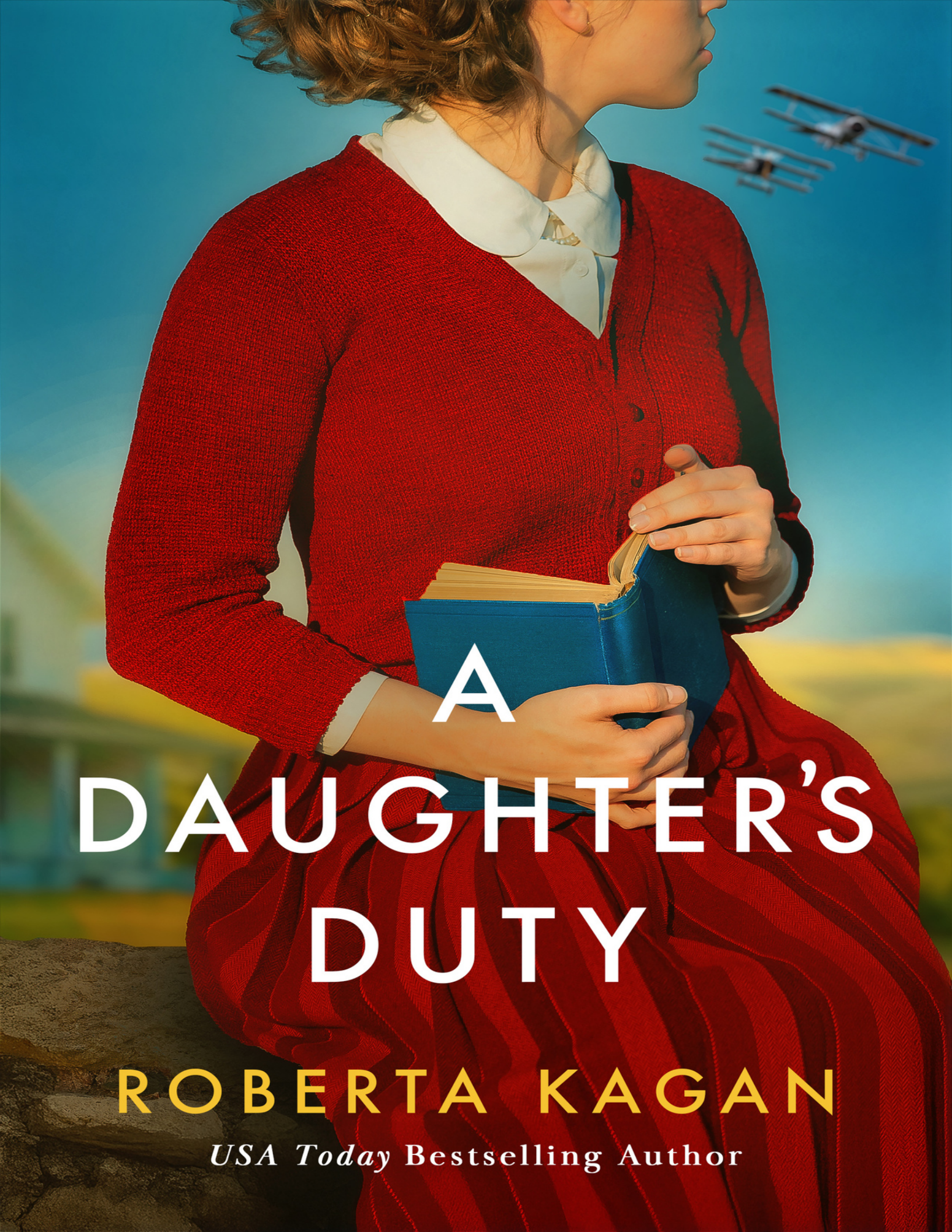




A DAUGHTER'S DUTY

ROBERTA KAGAN

USA Today Bestselling Author

A
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DUTY

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PROLOGUE

GERMANY
JULY 1917

The sky looked like a pool of black ink save for the large silver moon that seemed to have eyes of its own. A pretty but not stunning young woman looked around nervously as she walked out of the train station, carrying only her small handbag. Not a single soul was in sight, and yet she felt as if she were being watched. Like a small mouse with a giant cat pursuing it, she quickly darted away from the lights of the train station. Then, breaking into a run, she moved as fast as she could through open fields, her hair breaking free from the knot at the back of her neck and blowing in the wind as she made her way towards the outskirts of the small village. The village was familiar to her; she'd been a child there. However, it felt like so much time had passed since she left and it seemed different somehow. Smaller than she remembered. Her heart raced so hard that she felt a wave of nausea come over her. Bile rose in her throat and she gagged, almost vomiting. For a moment she stopped and bent over at the waist to catch her breath and ease the sick feeling in her gut. *I must not get caught.* She repeated over and over in her head as she glanced quickly behind her in desperation. Her hands were cold, and she shivered. *Is anyone there? Am I alone?* Frightened to do so, the girl turned around to see if anyone had followed her. *I am alone, yet I feel someone's presence. Is it just my nerves?* Taking another glance behind her, she thought, *Please God, I pray that I have not been followed.* No one was in sight, there was only darkness. The

heavy thumping of her heartbeat made her head ache as the blood pounded in her ears.

There was no time to waste. She had to fulfill her mission and get back as quickly as possible. All around her was the eerie quiet of the countryside broken only by the hooting of an owl. She caught her breath for a moment, and then she began to run again.

Before she'd moved to the city, it was the quiet of the countryside that had brought her peace. Now, it only fostered fear. When she first moved to Berlin, she'd been surprised to find that there were people out on the street at all hours of the night. But as time passed, and she'd grown used to living there, she found it comforting to be in the middle of the noisy city. Knowing people were always around gave her a feeling of safety. Something she did not feel right now. Tears wet her eyelashes as, once again, she remembered why she had returned home. And as she thought about it, she prayed for God's forgiveness. *I know I am about to break one of your greatest commandments, but I don't know what else to do. Dear God, please forgive me. My husband cannot be reasoned with. In his desperation, he's become violent and dangerous. If I continue to fail to give him what he wants, he will kill me. Besides, I must help my father. He's getting old, and I doubt he will last in the army now that they've begun conscripting older men. I wish my father-in-law would use his influence to get him released. But he won't, because he is disappointed in me. Before now, she'd never felt such true terror. If only I could turn back before I've committed this sin. If only I could see some other way. It's not only a sin against God, but it is a sin against the one person whom I love.* She wanted to turn back, return to Berlin, and refuse to take the advice of the old seer woman. However, she couldn't go back without fulfilling her mission. She knew in her heart that there was no other way. *Forgive me, dear God, but I am still so young, and even though my life is less than perfect, I am not ready to die.*

NOT FAR AWAY, hidden by the darkness and the shadows of the trees that reached with dark branches up towards the heavens, a woman watched, listened, and waited. Could this be what she had been waiting for? Was this

woman, running through the fields, about to give her what she needed to destroy the man who had ruined her life?

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CHAPTER 1

A SMALL VILLAGE ON THE OUTSKIRTS OF BERLIN
1899

Margareta Louise, or Greta as her family and friends referred to her, was a sweet and easy-going child who had been born to Joseph and Heidi Zolner, a not so young couple from similar backgrounds. Heidi and Joseph had lived on neighboring farms with their spouses. The two couples had not only been neighbors, but they had been friends as well. Since both couples worked small pieces of land and were still childless, they had enough in common to carry on a friendship. They often shared meals to celebrate a good harvest, and they always enjoyed Christmas dinners together.

One frigid winter, Joseph's wife came down with an illness that suddenly took her life. Heidi helped plan the small burial, and Heidi and her husband cried by Joseph's side when they lowered his wife into the cold ground. A few months later, when the wildflowers of the spring had bloomed, Heidi's husband suffered a fatal accident on the farm. Without hesitation, Joseph came to her side to help her with all the arrangements for her husband.

Left alone, Heidi and Joseph developed a deeper form of friendship. Since Heidi could not work the land, the two of them joined their fields together, and Joseph had more than his share of work each day. Heidi took care of him like a wife, preparing his meals and often cleaning his house. As harvest time grew nearer, there was too much work for Joseph to do alone, and so he was forced to pay outside help to harvest the crop from

both farms. This took away from the profit, but it had to be done. Joseph spent many nights thinking about how he could solve his problem, and he decided that the only way to keep the farm profitable was to have a son who would grow up and help him tend the fields. So, one night after Joseph and Heidi ate their dinner, he suggested that they get married. It was not a marriage of love, but one of friendship and convenience for both parties. Heidi, who needed Joseph as much as he needed her, agreed.

It wasn't long after the couple were wed that little Greta came into the world. Her mother had anticipated pain and hours of hard labor. However, that was not the case. On a chilly day in early April 1900, Heidi went into labor. After a mere four hours and a couple of pushes, without much struggle, Greta slid into the midwife's waiting hands. Both Heidi and Joseph were overjoyed to welcome a child into their lives. However, they were both disappointed, because they'd hoped for a son to grow up and help Joseph in the fields.

"Never mind about it," Joseph said, looking down at his newborn baby girl. "We'll keep trying. It's a good sign that you conceived and bore a healthy girl. The next one will be a boy." He smiled as he pushed the hair, damp with sweat, back from Heidi's forehead.

Heidi nodded, guilt settling heavily on her for not producing a son. As soon as she recovered from the birth, she began helping Joseph with his work on the farm. She got up before Greta each morning and tended the cow and the chickens. Then, while Greta napped, she went out onto the land and did what she could to help with the crops. It was never enough. And although they tried to love the tiny girl God had given them, they both knew that a boy would have been far more useful in the future.

"Well, at least we know that we are not too old to have children," Heidi said encouragingly.

Joseph nodded to his wife, trying to hide his disappointment. "Yes, let's try again."

As Greta grew into a chubby, happy little girl, the couple continued to attempt to have a son. Over the next several years there were two miscarriages, followed by a stillborn little boy. The stillborn had gone full term, and to make matters worse, the midwife had allowed Heidi to hold the child before Joseph dug a small grave behind the house to bury the tiny infant. This drove Heidi into a deep depression. She stopped taking care of Greta and no longer helped Joseph with the farm. Most days she hid in her

room. Joseph could not bring her out of her darkness, and so they gave up trying to have another son.

“I think we are wasting our time. It seems to me that you are just too old,” Joseph said, perhaps not realizing how harsh his words were.

Heidi looked away. Taking his criticism in stride, she swallowed hard and nodded. She’d been taught that it was the woman’s fault if she cannot give her husband a son, and she believed it wholeheartedly. “I’m sorry, Joseph,” she said softly. “I failed you.”

Joseph didn’t speak, he just nodded. This made Heidi feel even more guilty, and although she couldn’t say that she was in love with Joseph the way she loved her first husband, she felt the need to please him. She felt that failing to give him a son when he desperately needed help with the farm was unforgivable. Heidi was afraid that he might decide to leave one day and never return. And so, even though he had decided to give up trying, she was still determined to continue.

He did not come to her bed as often as he had in the past, claiming he was too tired. But sometimes he gave in to lust, and when he did, Heidi prayed it would result in pregnancy.

Two years later, when Greta was four, Heidi fell pregnant. She didn’t tell Joseph right away. She wanted to be sure that she didn’t miscarry again. On Greta’s fifth birthday in April, as the family sat down for dinner Joseph noticed Heidi’s housedress was very tight around her belly he asked her if she was going to have a baby. “Yes, I am,” she said, smiling. He nodded, and she knew he was pleased. He was concerned because of her age, but once again he was hopeful that he might have a son. So, he treated her very gently, refusing to allow her to carry anything heavy or to do anything strenuous.

And then on August 5th, 1905 with the most pain and suffering that she’d ever experienced, after twenty hours of difficult labor Heidi gave birth to the most beautiful little boy.

“He was born with a caul, a veil covering his face,” the midwife said as she handed the baby to his mother.

Heidi shivered. “What does that mean?” Heidi’s hands were trembling as she held the infant in her arms.

“It could be good luck. Or it could mean that he has connections to the other world.”

“The other world?”

“The spiritual world,” the old midwife said. “The world of the dead.”

Heidi nodded. “Please,” she said, “don’t tell my husband about the veil. He would be frightened by it. You see we are very religious people, and he would not feel as comfortable with the child if he knew.”

The midwife looked at Heidi with wizened old eyes. Then she nodded, “I understand. I will never speak a word of it to anyone.”

“Thank you,” Heidi clamored, touching the woman’s shoulder. “You see, we have waited and tried for so long to have another baby, and I am afraid that this news would frighten his father.”

Again, the midwife nodded as she gathered her tools together and placed them back in her bag. “Your secret is safe with me,” She winked at Heidi, then she walked outside the room where Joseph waited anxiously.

“Is the child all right?” he stammered.

“Yes, and your wife is fine too, Herr Zolner. You have a son,” the midwife smiled.

“A son? I have a son?” A big smile came over his face.

“Yes. Congratulations.”

With trembling hands Joseph Zolner paid the midwife for her services, then he ran into the room where Heidi lay in bed with the tiny bundle in her arms.

When Joseph saw the baby, he took it from Heidi’s arms and laid it down on the bed. Then he removed the blanket and when he saw the tiny penis his face lit up. “God has smiled on us, Heidi,” he said. “We waited and we prayed. And now we have a little boy, a son. Oh, Heidi. It is a miracle, a gift from heaven. You have brought me a son.”

She nodded and took his hand. He kissed her palm. “Thank you. Thank you, my dear wife,” he said.

Heidi smiled, pleased with herself. “What shall we call him?” she asked.

“Zeno. I’ve always wanted to have a son. Let’s name him Zeno.”

Heidi smiled at Joseph. “Zeno, yes, we’ll call him Zeno. It’s a good name.”

CHAPTER 2

Zeno was an easy child. He was a good boy who openly expressed his love for his parents and his sister. When Zeno was first born, Greta, who was still just a child, resented him. He was a new addition to a family that had previously had only her. However, as time passed, she became like a second mother to Zeno and found that she adored him. He made her laugh with his funny antics, and unlike other babies who she encountered because they were brothers and sisters of friends and neighbors, Zeno almost never cried. He was far too patient for a child. He wasn't bothered by sitting in a wet diaper, and hardly ever demanded food. Greta overheard her parents discussing their concerns when she was cleaning the kitchen one night. They were still sitting at the dinner table when Joseph finally admitted bitterly that he was afraid that something might be wrong with Zeno.

"He seems to have some problems." Joseph said, rubbing his forehead.

"Shall we take him to a doctor?" Heidi asked.

"Heidi," Joseph shook his head. "We really don't have the money. I think he'll outgrow it. I've seen this before. He'll be all right." Joseph said, but an undertone of worry was apparent.

Greta was too young to understand what her father meant. So, she just spent her time adoring the child, treating him almost like a living doll. Zeno cuddled into his sister affectionately. He was late to crawl, and even later to walk. Then finally, his parents breathed a sigh of relief when he pulled himself up, using the side of the sofa. And, on his short little legs, holding tightly to Greta's hand, he walked. However, he still did not speak. Zeno grunted and giggled, but he did not use words.

Joseph was appalled by his son's inability to grow in the way that was expected. So, when Zeno was three years old, and he still did not communicate with language, and although Joseph hated to spend money on doctors, he finally gave in and allowed Heidi to take Zeno to see the local doctor. The local doctor was just a small-town physician. He said that he could not diagnose Zeno's illness, and so he suggested that Heidi take him to a specialist in Berlin. Although money was scarce for the Zolners, Joseph finally agreed with his wife that they must take Zeno into the city to be examined by someone who might help him to develop properly.

Heidi emptied the jar in the kitchen, where she kept the family's life savings. Then she had Greta dress Zeno. Greta took her brother into the bedroom and put his clothes on. She kissed his cheek, then carried him out of the room and handed him to her mother.

"Your father and I are taking your brother to see a doctor. Do not go out of the house while we are gone." Her mother said.

"Can I go with you, mother?" Greta asked. "I can take care of Zeno on the bus."

"No dear. We can't be wasting money on extra bus fare. There is no need for you to come with us. Wait here like I told you." Her mother said as she turned and walked outside to where Greta's father was waiting.

After extensive tests at the hospital that cost the Zolners all the money they'd saved over the years, the doctor told them that the little boy's brain would never allow him to grow up to be more advanced than a five-year-old. Joseph, taken by surprise, was instantly angry. He raised his fist to punch the doctor, but an orderly stopped him. "You need to leave now," the orderly said assertively. Defeated and broken, Joseph would not touch his son. Zeno just sat smiling at his parents, which infuriated Joseph even more. Joseph slapped the child hard across the face, and Zeno let out a scream. "Don't hit him, Joseph. He doesn't understand." Heidi said as she lifted Zeno off the examining table and into her arms. "Come on, let's go. No one can help us here," she said. Then she and Joseph left the office, their faces were as pale as parchment paper. Zeno stopped crying quickly and fell asleep as they boarded the bus for home. He slept soundly, and his parents did not speak to each other the entire way home. Once they arrived home, Heidi handed Zeno to Greta. "Take care of him," was all Heidi said.

CHAPTER 3

1908

Greta fed and bathed her brother who smiled at her, as agreeably as ever. After his bath, Greta put Zeno to bed. Then she went downstairs to prepare dinner for her parents. Her father was outside, and her mother sat staring out the window. "Shall I make eggs for dinner?" Greta asked her mother.

"I don't want anything," Heidi said, and then she stood up and walked slowly into the bedroom she shared with Greta's father.

Greta walked outside and asked her father if he wanted eggs for dinner. He shook his head, "No, I don't want anything."

Greta could hear her mother weeping. She wanted to say something that would make her feel better, but she didn't know what to say.

Her father stayed outside until well after dark. Finally, Joseph entered the house, and without even looking at Greta, he walked past her and went directly into the bedroom. Greta watched him. She was trembling. She knew something was very wrong. Quietly she knelt by the door to her parent's bedroom and pressed her ear against the wood so she could hear them talking.

"Stop crying. Crying isn't going to help anything," Joseph said coldly. "I think the best thing for us to do is to put him in an orphanage."

"No, Joseph. We can't do that. Zeno is our child."

"He is no son of mine. He's an imbecile," he roared. "Don't you understand?"

Greta shivered. The word imbecile struck terror in her heart. Zeno was her brother and she loved him. But she was too afraid to say a word in his defense. She was only a small girl, and her father was a large, looming, brute of a man.

"Please Joseph, give him a chance. He might grow out of this," Heidi begged.

"He will never grow out of it," Joseph said, then he turned and glared at her. "I always wanted a son. And this is what you gave me. An idiot. An idiot." He growled at her. "I know what happened. I know..." he said angrily. "You were unfaithful. This child does not spring from my loins. This thing is from another man. I am ashamed for people to know what you did. How you betrayed me and brought this terrible thing into our lives." Joseph spat out the words, pointing at Heidi and storming out of the bedroom, slamming the door so hard behind him that it swung back open.

Greta was thrown out of the way. She fell backwards and hurt her elbow, but the pain didn't register. Somehow, she must convince her father that Zeno was an important part of their family. "He is not a thing or an imbecile. He is a good, kind little boy. And I love him. Mama loves him too!" Greta said bravely as she wrung her hands on her skirt.

Joseph turned to look at her. His face ruddy with rage. "What did you say?" he turned to face his daughter.

She shook her head wishing she'd stayed quiet, as he walked towards her. Then he slapped her across the face so hard that she fell to the ground. Blood flowed from her nose, and tears ran from her eyes.

Joseph turned back to Heidi and said, "That boy is not right. He never will be."

"I was never unfaithful to you." Heidi's voice was barely above a whisper. "I swear it."

"You're a liar. All women lie. That's what you creatures are good at. Anyway, even if I did believe you, this is still your fault. You were too old to bear a child, but you did it anyway," he accused.

"Zeno is your son, Joseph. I swear it. Would you put your own son into an orphanage?" Heidi cried.

"Don't you ever say that again. Do you hear me? That thing you call your child is not mine. He can't be mine. He is no Zolner. Idiots don't run in my family. Maybe they run in yours. And if they do, you should have told me. I would never have married you."

“No. No. I swear nothing like that runs in my family. I swear it doesn’t!” she was shaking and Greta could see she was afraid.

“That boy is an embarrassment to me. He’s nothing but a burden. He will never grow up and help me with this farm, Heidi. He will never be a man. He is just another mouth to feed, and we have enough of those already. I am going to take him to an orphanage and leave him there. Let them do as they will with him. Now you listen here. You listen too, Greta. None of us will ever tell the neighbors that we found out that Zeno was not right. If they ask about him, we’ll just tell them that he got sick and died. And that will be the end of it.”

“But Joseph, please... Be reasonable.” Heidi pleaded with him one last time.

“Enough said, woman! Stop crying and shut your mouth. I don’t want to hear another word from you. I’m going to sleep. When I get up, I am going to take that idiot away from here. You hear me?”

Then there was silence.

“I said, do you hear me?”

Heidi nodded.

“Greta? You understand?”

She nodded.

Then he walked into the bedroom and slammed the door behind him. This time it remained closed.

Greta shivered at her father’s words. *He can’t be so heartless. He can’t do this to Zeno. How can he just send my brother away like this? I won’t let him. I won’t.* She sat up on the floor and wiped the blood and tears from her face with the back of her hand. She wished she were a boy. *If only I were strong enough to fight him.* But the truth was Greta knew she was powerless to do anything against her father’s will. In the end, whatever Joseph Zolner decided was what was going to happen.

The following morning, Joseph woke up determined. “Pack a small bag with a few pieces of clothing you made for the boy and bring him to me,” her father said.

“Please Papa,” she whispered softly, hoping he wouldn’t hit her again, but unable to let Zeno go without trying to save him. “Please, don’t take him away. I will take care of him. He won’t be any trouble to you. I will share my food with him, so you won’t have to feed both of us. Please,” she begged as tears flowed down her face.

He whipped around and slapped her again. The scab of dried blood on her nose broke, and she began to bleed again. "Do as I say!" he commanded.

Terrified, she turned and walked into her bedroom and packed a small bag of things for Zeno. Then she began to sob as she lifted the boy from the drawer that served as his bed. Holding him tightly to her chest for a moment, she whispered in his ear, "I love you, Zeno. No matter what Papa does to separate us, I will always love you." A drop of blood from her nose fell on Zeno's shirt. The bright red contrasted with the white cotton. Trembling, Greta walked toward the door. Both her mother and father were waiting in the living room when Greta entered with Zeno in her arms. "Please. Have pity," she whispered. But neither her mother nor father said a word. Her mother took Zeno from her, and Greta stood staring at her parents in disbelief. She wanted to know where the orphanage was, where they were taking Zeno. But she knew better than to question her father. If she asked him anything, he would strike her again. He might even be so upset at being confronted that he would beat her with the strap he kept for just such occasions. Her arms felt empty as she watched her parents carry her little brother away. Through her tears, she could see Zeno was smiling. He was always smiling. When they were gone, Greta went outside and vomited.

Late that afternoon, when Greta's parents returned, they did not have Zeno with them. Greta looked to her mother for an answer, but her mother would not look directly into Greta's eyes. She felt sick to her stomach, and wanted to throw herself into her mother's arms and beg her to tell her where they'd left Zeno. She was only a child herself, but she would have gone there and begged to have her brother back. Then, like a roar of thunder into her already unsettled mind, came her father's voice. "Greta, come into the kitchen, now."

She was trembling and afraid, her knees were too weak to hold her up. But she did as she was told.

"Sit down," he demanded. "I have something important to say."

She nodded, hoping he was going to tell her that somehow Zeno was going to be returning home. She prayed that they'd found a doctor who might be able to help him. Her entire body was shaking violently when her father grabbed her shoulder roughly and shook her. "Listen to me, girl," he said. "No one must ever know that your brother was not right. You must

keep our family secrets, because if people find out that Zeno was born defective, the entire Zolner name will be ruined. No decent man will ever want to marry you. And let's face the facts, you are no beauty. You're actually quite plain, and I'm afraid we are going to have a difficult time finding a husband for you as it is. The last thing we Zolner's need is for word to get out that a disease like this runs in our family. And you know how people love to gossip. If one person hears about this, everyone in town will know. So, you keep your mouth shut. If anyone asks about your brother, you tell them he caught a bad chill and died. That's all you say. Do you understand me?" He stared directly into her eyes, holding her gaze until she looked away. Then he put his hand on her chin and forced her to face him again. There was no tenderness in his tone of voice. It was as if he truly believed, or at least he wanted to believe, that Zeno was not his son.

Greta felt the tears welling up in her eyes. But she knew that if she started crying, her father would probably beat her. He didn't want to see emotions. He wanted her to promise to keep the secret. She was just a slender girl, small for her age, with no ability to fight against him. So, all she could do was agree. As he stood over her, looking like a monster, his eyes red and his face stern. In a small, helpless voice, she said, "Yes, I understand." Then he let go of her chin, and she turned her face away from him.

He was not satisfied. He reached down and grabbed her chin again. It hurt, but he held it firmly, turning her head and forcing her to look directly into his eyes again. "I said, do you understand me?"

"Yes," she whispered. He slapped her face, and she let out a whimper.

"Answer me. I can't hear you."

"Yes, sir." she said more clearly and louder this time. She was terrified of him. His thick fingers were squeezing her small chin, and she knew the only way he was going to let her go was if she answered him loud and convincingly.

It worked. Her father nodded. He took a deep, long hard breath, then he released her chin. "Good. Don't ever forget what we discussed here today," he said as he got up and walked slowly out of the kitchen.

I hate you. She thought. Then she began to cry.

CHAPTER 4

1912

For four years following that terrible day when Greta's parents took her brother away, Greta could still not look at the drawer where Zeno had once slept. She missed the little boy terribly. There was no trace of him in the house, except for the empty drawer. It was as if he had never been there at all. And after that day, when her parents returned from dropping Zeno off, the relationship between them changed. They were civil to each other and to Greta, but there wasn't a closeness between them anymore.

With each passing year, Greta's responsibilities grew. She was still in school—her father had not yet forced her to leave—but the weight of her chores made arriving on time a daily struggle. Before dawn, she milked the cow and gathered the eggs from the chicken coop. Her mother no longer helped with the farm, often claiming illness or exhaustion, and so the work fell upon Greta's young shoulders.

On days she did not have school, she knelt over the washboard, scrubbing the clothes and sheets clean until her knuckles bled. Then there were the windows, walls, and floor. Only after she finished all her chores, could she either cuddle up in her bed to read, or if there was still light outside, she went to her favorite place in the world: the library.

Even though she was tired when she went to class, she loved school, especially reading. However, her parents—mostly her father—didn't think an education was important. And her mother didn't care at all. Life had worn her down, and now her mother slept all the time. She had once been a nice-looking woman, but now she had grown very fat. Greta felt sorry for

her mother—she knew that losing Zeno had hurt her as much as it hurt Greta—and so Greta tried to do as much for her mother as she could.

One morning after she fed the chickens, Greta went into her mother's room to tell her she was leaving for school. What she saw shocked and terrified her. Her mother lay on the bed sweating.

"Mama, what is it? What's wrong? Are you dying?" Greta was only twelve years old, and she had not recognized the signs of pregnancy.

"I am going to have a baby," her mother said. She had begun to cry.

"Mama, don't cry. Please don't cry. Does it hurt that much?"

Heidi turned her face away from her daughter. "It hurts; I won't lie to you. It does hurt a lot. But that's not why I'm weeping. I'm worried, Greta." She grabbed her daughter's hand and squeezed tightly. With tears rolling down her cheeks, she closed her eyes and whispered to Greta. "I'm afraid that this baby will not be right. I am afraid that he might be like Zeno, and your father will take him away from us again. I can't bear the thought of another child being lost to me. Especially if it is a son."

Greta felt the tears form in her own eyes. It hurt her to know that a boy was so much more valuable to her mother. And that even as hard as Greta tried to win her mother's love, Heidi would have traded Greta's life for the life of a little boy if she had the choice to make. Greta took a deep breath and told herself, *I should not be so hurt by this. My mother has often said that a male child is much more valuable to a farm than a female.*

Heidi Zolner lay struggling with labor pains with a wrinkled old midwife by her side. The midwife was in charge of everything, and even Joseph, who usually had little respect for women, showed the midwife the utmost respect. He did this because if he insulted her and caused her to leave, there would be no one to help Heidi with the birth. And so, Greta was surprised to see Joseph heeding her orders. The first thing the midwife did was to forbid Joseph or Greta from entering the room while Heidi was in labor. Joseph nodded agreeably when she told him this. Greta thought he secretly was pleased that he did not have to witness the birth or attend to his wife's needs. He left the house and walked outside where he did his work, while Greta sat on the floor outside her parents' bedroom door listening to her mother's anguished cries, and praying she would not die. Her parents were not the best parents in the world. She knew this. But they were the only ones she had. And if her mother died in childbirth, she would have to spend her life alone with her father. The very idea of this was horrific to her.

Hours passed and Greta felt such terrible tension as she listened to her mother's cries of pain. The only time she left was to prepare a meal for her father. Greta served him as he expected her to, but she could not eat. And she wondered how it was so easy for him to eat his meal while the echo of her mother's screams filled the house. He slept on the sofa that night. And Greta was careful not to disturb him even though the screaming from the bedroom did not seem to disturb him at all.

Then in the wee hours of the morning, as Joseph snored and Greta sat by the door with her head against the door frame, the hearty cry of an infant shattered the night. Joseph awakened and walked over to the bedroom door. Greta sat up.

"The baby is born," Joseph said.

Greta nodded. She heard the baby. However, now she did not hear her mother at all. The cries of pain had ceased, and Greta felt a chill run down her spine. She wished she could enter the room. Slowly Greta stood up, shivering in the darkness until the door opened and the midwife came out. Her white apron was covered with blood. Greta saw the blood and felt a wave of panic come over her.

"You can go in now," she said to Joseph ignoring Greta. "You have a daughter. And your wife is doing fine."

Greta let out a sigh of relief. Her mother was not dead. She pushed past the midwife and entered the room where she saw her mother holding a small bundle wrapped in a wool blanket.

"You have a sister," Heidi said to Greta and tried to smile, but Greta knew that she was disappointed.

"A girl." Joseph said when he walked into the room. "All of this waiting and paying a midwife for another girl." He slammed his fist against the wall. "That midwife cost me a fortune," he growled. Then he stormed out of the house.

Greta looked at the little girl in the blanket and smiled. She caught a glimpse of the infant's tiny perfect hand, and she was in awe. "She's so pretty, Mama."

"Yes, and that is a blessing. Beauty is the only thing that counts for a girl in this world. Unless of course her family has money. But we are poor," her mother sighed. "Oh Greta, I wish you had been born pretty. It would have made life so much easier for you." Heidi patted Greta's hand. "But you are a good girl. You've always been such a good girl."

“I love you, Mama.”

“I know. I love you, too.”

It took several days before Joseph held his new daughter. At first, his disappointment was all he could express. “You are getting older and you shouldn’t have any more children,” he groaned. “How am I expected to run this farm alone? Perhaps I should divorce you and marry someone younger,” he said, then he handed the baby to Greta and said, “Take care of her. Your mother has work to do.”

Heidi frowned at him. Then she turned to Greta, “Don’t look so worried. He won’t go anywhere. Who would have him? He’s an old farmer with no money. Worthless, really. But he’s my husband and your father. So, we keep him. And we do our best to love him, yes?” Heidi cracked a small smile at her daughter.

“Yes.” Greta agreed and smiled back at her mother.

They named the baby Mary Beth. And although Greta was still only a child herself, Mary Beth became Greta’s responsibility.

CHAPTER 5

Greta took excellent care of her sister who was very different than Zeno. Mary Beth was a demanding child—if she didn’t get what she wanted, she screamed for hours, refusing to be quiet. Still, always hoping to win her parents’ love and approval, Greta did her best to keep her little sister happy and quiet. Sometimes Mary Beth would get up in the middle of the night and cry. Greta could not force the child to sleep. If Greta tried to put her back to bed, Mary Beth would scream. All Greta could do was sit in a rocking chair and sing, or try to tire her by reading to her. However, because she was not getting enough rest, Greta was exhausted, and she sometimes fell asleep in her classes at school. Even though taking care of her sister, going to school, and her daily chores were draining Greta, she was delighted because her efforts seemed to make her mother more affectionate towards her. And all of it even seemed to win her father over.

A few months after Greta had turned thirteen years old, for no apparent reason, her father decided that she was wasting her time in school. He insisted that she drop out so that instead of being away all day, she could stay home and care for the baby. Then, when her baby sister slept, she could help her father in the fields. He said he had given up on the hope of ever having a son, and so he had no choice but to teach Greta to assist him. She begged her mother to intervene, “Please Mother, please talk to him. I don’t want to quit school. I want to continue. Will you help me?” Greta pleaded.

Her mother just shook her head, “A woman doesn’t need an education, dear. You’re lucky you were able to go as far in school as you went. I never went to school at all. I can’t even read. I can’t count or make change. At least you can do that. I’m dependent on your father for everything.”

“Please Mother. Please.” Greta begged. “I’ll still do the farm work. I’ll do all the housework. And when I am home, I’ll take care of Mary Beth, only please let me go to school.”

“I’m sorry, Greta,” her mother said firmly. “I need your help in the house, and your father needs you on the farm. Mary Beth requires a lot of attention and care. And when you go to school, I am left alone to care for her. Besides that, I must find time to do the housework. I am getting older, Greta. And I’m sorry to have to say this, but this is far too much for me. I have not been well for a long time. And I’ve been feeling even worse since my last pregnancy. I am too old to have children. It took a lot out of me. So, I agree with your father when he says that you have had more than enough schooling. You are needed here at home.”

Greta was distraught. She had always loved school. It had been her only escape from a family that seemed to tolerate her more than love her. And reading was the only thing she felt she could ever excel at. Greta had been one of the first students in her class to master the ability to read and write. And although she knew that her parents would never pay for books, she had found a way to get her hands on them. The library. Since Mary Beth was born, she could not slip away as easily on her days off from school. But once a week, Greta lied and told her mother that she was expected to stay late after school to help the teacher in her classroom. Her mother had scoffed at this, but she had not stopped her. So, having a few minutes free on her way home from school, she raced to the library. She dared not take advantage and be too late, so she was forced to choose quickly. This was difficult for her, and so she would ask the librarian’s assistant—a young girl called Ruth—to help her. This was how the two girls became friends.

RUTH BERNSTEIN WAS SIXTEEN, three years older than Greta. She was a quiet girl who did not attend the same school as Greta. Ruth attended a Jewish school two miles away in another village, where the Jewish population lived. She did not live in the Jewish village because her father, before he died, had been a young, idealistic doctor who had worked primarily with poor, non-Jewish clientele. He’d never earned much money because he treated many of his patients regardless of the fact that they were

unable to pay. Sometimes they brought him a basket of potatoes or a few eggs as payment, and he had been glad to accept. Even though Ruth was only a little girl when her father died, she remembered him to be the kindest man she'd ever known. Her paternal grandmother had always lived with Ruth's family, and after both of Ruth's parents were killed in an accident, Ruth and her grandmother considered moving to the Jewish village where Ruth was to attend school, but moving meant selling the house and packing up their things. Then they would have needed to find a place to live in the new area, and since they didn't even know their way around the new village, her grandmother had decided not to move.

As Ruth grew older, they both began to realize that staying had been a mistake. Ruth had no friends in the village. The fear of Jewish people that her neighbors had been raised with kept them from speaking to Ruth and her grandmother. They knew that Ruth was Jewish, but even though her father had been kind to them, they did not want their children socializing with a Jew.

There were many terrible lies circulating in the village—ridiculous rumors that Jews had tails or drank the blood of Christian babies. Such nonsense made Ruth squirm. She knew that Jewish people did not consume blood of any kind; it was against Jewish law. And she certainly did not have a tail. However, this was a small, backward farming town. Most of the older residents were uneducated, and so they still believed in these terrifying old stories.

Ruth found her escape in books, and so as soon as she was old enough to work after school, she got a job at the local library. The library was very small because it was not a popular place, and by the time they were sixteen, most of the other girls in town had left school and were busy at home learning how to be good wives. They would soon be married and children would follow. They put their focus on cooking, cleaning, and child rearing. There was no interest in books.

FOR GRETA, books were the only escape she had from her unhappy life. Greta was busy at home where she was being forced to learn all she would need to know to be a good wife. However, unlike the other girls in town

who were always talking about marriage and children, this was not her dream. Deep in her heart she longed to be a novelist, like the writers who penned the stories she loved so much. But Greta never believed that she would be able to accomplish this goal. And she could not tell anyone about it, as they would have laughed at her. However, she could dream. She could read, and she could allow the wonderful words of her favorite authors to transport her to a world where she was far away from her little village. Her father had scoffed when he saw her reading, but he had not yet forbidden it. Greta was sure that this was because she did not read until all her work was done. He would walk by her room where she was reading, and he would shake his head, often saying that her books were nothing but a waste of time.

When Greta met Ruth, she found that Ruth was different than anyone she had ever met and as they got closer, Ruth began to treat Greta like a little sister. When Greta finally felt comfortable enough to tell Ruth of her dream of being a novelist, Ruth smiled, and with great enthusiasm she said, "You can do whatever you put your mind to. I believe that someday you will be a wonderful writer."

"You do? Really?" Greta said, her heart filled with glee at the thought.

"I do."

"How can you tell?"

"I can tell by the way you devour books," Ruth said laughing. "I give you a book and you've finished reading it in a couple of days. It's amazing."

"That doesn't mean I'll be able to write them," Greta said, looking down at the books in her hands.

"I think you'll be able to do it if you choose to," Ruth said, smiling.

Greta smiled back broadly.

Greta rarely had a free moment during the day. The more her father found her busy reading, the more work he found for her to do. She began to realize that although he did not forbid her to read, he was making sure she didn't have time. So, when everyone in the house was asleep, Greta would read by candlelight. In her mind, she would envision herself becoming one of the beautiful women she read about in her books. These were women who were adored by their husbands and lovers and often cherished by their families too. When she was lost in the pages of a book, Greta came alive.

And often, she wished she could leave her reality behind and live within the all-encompassing stories she read about.

When Greta was forced to quit school, she secretly hoped that if she wasn't attending classes, she might at least have extra time to read. This was not the case. Her parents seemed to have a mounting pile of work for her to do each day, which kept her constantly busy. And what had seemed impossible for Greta, winning her parents' love, came naturally to Mary Beth. As Mary Beth grew up, she somehow won her father's deep affection with very little effort. And their mother was always telling Mary Beth how proud she was to have such a beautiful daughter. Greta was sure this was because by the time Mary Beth was four years old, she had grown into a stunning child whom everyone stared at whenever they went into town. Mary Beth had bright blue eyes, a winning smile, and long golden curls flowing like a waterfall down her back. With the voice of a songbird and the grace of a fawn, Mary Beth was a born entertainer who loved to sing and dance. Greta couldn't help but be envious. She couldn't sing or dance, her light brown hair was pin straight, and her eyes were an ordinary shade of hazel. They didn't sparkle the way her sisters did. But she wanted to love Mary Beth, so she fought against her feelings of jealousy and tried as hard as she could to be happy that her little sister was perfect, even though her parents always said that she was not.

Greta compared herself to Cinderella in *Aschenputtel*, which she had read in an old Brothers Grimm book. This was because for as long as she could remember, Greta had been treated like a servant by her parents. And until Mary Beth came along, she'd believed that this was the way all children were treated. However, Mary Beth was no servant. Their parents spoiled her as much as they could, and treated her like a princess. And even though they went to great lengths to try to please Mary Beth, nothing they did was ever good enough. She was a discontented child who was never satisfied. On Mary Beth's fourth Christmas, her mother labored many long hours to make a doll to give her as a Christmas gift, but when she presented it to Mary Beth on Christmas Eve, Mary Beth showed how disappointed she was. "This doll is ugly. I saw a doll in the toy store with beautiful blonde hair just like mine. I want a store-bought dolly. Not this thing made of rags. My friend Elke has a store-bought dolly. If she has one, why can't I?" she said, letting the ragged doll slip from her hands and drop onto the floor. Then she got up and walked out of the room, leaving the doll behind her.

Meanwhile, on that same Christmas Eve, Greta received a single pair of wool socks for which she showed gratitude, even though she had hoped for a book.

Greta thought her mother would be angry at her sister for being ungrateful. Instead, a week later her parents brought a doll home from the toy store. It was a lovely doll with golden hair, just like its owner. And when they presented it to Mary Beth, she smiled broadly, and both her parents seemed pleased.

Boldly, Greta asked her mother why she had spent so much money on a doll for her sister, and her answer stunned Greta. “She needs nice things. Look at her, Greta! She is perfect. We can’t expect her to be satisfied with things that are less than perfect. This is just the way she is. It’s her nature. You are different. You don’t need fancy things.” Heidi paused and inhaled sharply. “You must understand I cannot have any more children, and therefore I cannot produce a son to help on the farm. While you do a fine job, its just not enough, Greta. Mary Beth will have her choice of men, and she will marry a boy that can take over the farming work.”

Her mother’s words were like a dagger in Greta’s heart.

CHAPTER 6

1917

Mary Beth's birthday was a celebration each year. While there had never been any celebration for Greta's birthdays, and their parents couldn't afford to have a grand party for Mary Beth, the best they could offer was to allow her to invite some of her friends to the house for a slice of cake, which Greta was told she must bake.

Greta tried to fight her hurt feelings. She wanted to love Mary Beth, but it was so hard, and she found that she began to resent her instead. Sometimes Mary Beth would throw a tantrum, and instead of punishing her, her parents gave her whatever she demanded. When this happened, Greta resented her little sister even more, and had terrible thoughts that she was ashamed of. Greta would secretly wish that instead of taking Zeno away, her father had taken Mary Beth. If she could have traded Mary Beth for Zeno, she had no doubt that she would have.

Then, like a blessing from heaven, Mary Beth started school. Having her gone for several hours a day was such a relief for Greta. There was still plenty of work to do, but sometimes she was able to find a little time to go to the library. Over the years, she and Ruth had developed a deep friendship. Ruth was the only person Greta felt she could be honest with. She even felt safe enough to share her true feelings about Mary Beth. And although her father had forbidden her to tell anyone about her brother Zeno's condition and what had happened to him, Greta told Ruth. Ruth promised to keep her secret in the strictest confidence, and Greta knew she could trust her. They talked about everything. Ruth told Greta how difficult

it was for her and her grandmother, being Jewish people in the village. And Greta said she understood. "I know how hard it is not to be accepted," she said, holding her friend's hands in her own. "I have always been the plain looking girl. Never the pretty one. And to make matters even worse, my parents are the poorest farmers in our village, so I have never had decent clothes. You know how cruel girls can be. They were always making fun of me because my clothes were so worn."

Ruth patted her friend's hand. "They are only clothes. Clothes can be bought and sold. You have something far more valuable. You have a golden soul, and a beautiful heart. I can see them both," she smiled at Greta.

Greta didn't know if this was true, but the idea of it made her feel so much better. In fact, in a way that she could not explain, Ruth's words made her feel as if she had a special kind of beauty. And maybe someday the right man would see it, and he would want to marry her. Not that she was eager to marry, but she would have been happy to leave her parents' home.

On Greta's seventeenth birthday Ruth gave Greta a gift. It was a book she'd bought for her, a beautiful book of fairy tales with a dark blue leather cover. The title was written across the leather in deep set gold letters. When Greta saw the book, she began to cry, and she hugged her friend. "You are so good to me."

"I knew you would love this."

"I do. I really do."

CHAPTER 7

On a morning in early October, Greta's mother sent her and Mary Beth into town to buy some flour so that Greta could bake bread for dinner that evening. Mary Beth was in an ornery mood. She kept insisting that she wanted an apple. But since Greta had just enough money to buy the flour and no extra, she had to say no.

"But I said I want an apple," Mary Beth demanded, stomping her foot on the ground.

"I don't have enough money to buy it for you," Greta said firmly.

Angry, Mary Beth puffed out her lower lip and sat down on the ground refusing to go into the general store with Greta. "I'm not going," she said stubbornly.

Greta's mother told her to be home in half an hour, so there was no time to argue with Mary Beth. "Don't move from here then. Stay right here. I'll be right back," Greta commanded.

Mary Beth looked away and grunted.

Quickly Greta went into the store and bought the flour. When she walked back outside, she couldn't find Mary Beth. She was not where Greta had left her. Greta's heart raced with fear as she looked around quickly. *Why does that child never listen to what I tell her to do? Where are you, Mary Beth?* Greta shivered, although it was not from the cold air outside. Then she noticed that there was a commotion in the center of the square. A large group of people had gathered and were surrounding one of the vendors. They were talking amongst themselves, but Greta was too far away to hear what they were saying. However, she could see that they were upset by their animated hand gestures. Her first thought was of Mary Beth.

She was worried. Had something happened to her? *Oh, dear God, no. Please let her be all right.* She thought as she ran over to where the crowd had gathered. The fruit and vegetable vendor was standing over Mary Beth. He had his hand on her shoulder, and she was crying. She held an apple in her trembling hand. Greta felt her heart drop into her stomach. If her parents found out that she'd left Mary Beth outside alone, and Mary Beth had gotten into trouble, they would blame Greta. It was always that way. When Mary Beth got into trouble, it was never her fault. At least that was how her parents saw it. No matter what Mary Beth did, somehow Greta was blamed. She pushed through the crowd to the vendor. It was a tall boy around her own age. She thought she might have recognized him as someone she'd seen at school when she attended. Greta sucked in a deep breath. She was relieved to see that Mary Beth was unharmed. But at the same time, she was angry that her sister had gotten into trouble.

"She stole that apple from me," the vendor said to Greta, who had grabbed Mary Beth's hand hard enough to make her release the apple. Then she handed the ripe red fruit to the vendor.

"I'm sorry," Greta said sincerely, "this girl is my sister." Then she turned to Mary Beth and said, "Why did you do that? Why didn't you listen to me and stay where I told you to wait for me?"

"I wanted an apple, and you wouldn't get me one." Mary Beth said defiantly. "So what was I supposed to do?"

"I told you that I don't have enough money right now. You had no right to go and steal from this man."

Suddenly the vendor softened, "It's all right. No harm done." He said, and she noticed that when he walked over to where she stood, he walked with a severe limp. His right leg was unnaturally twisted. She looked away not wanting to stare.

The crowd had begun to disperse. "I really am sorry about my sister's behavior," Greta said.

"Children often do things they shouldn't," he shrugged. Then he added, "By the way, my name is Hermann. I don't mean to be bold, but I recognize you from school. I remember seeing you in the halls. I should have asked you your name then. But I guess I was too shy. What is it anyway? Your name, I mean?"

Greta's face felt hot, and she knew she was blushing. She looked away. "Oh," she stammered. "My name is Greta."

“Let’s go home,” Mary Beth moaned annoyingly. “If I can’t have an apple I want to go home.”

“Hello Greta, it’s a pleasure to meet you,” he said, ignoring Mary Beth and smiling. Greta’s heart melted. He wasn’t handsome in the classic sense, but Greta found him to be very good looking.

“I want to go home.” Mary Beth stomped her foot on the cobblestone street. “I want to go home right now!”

“I’m sorry. I must go. She’s about to have a tantrum and I would rather not have that happen in the middle of the square. Anyway, thank you for not calling for the police.”

“Would you like that apple?” Hermann turned to Mary Beth.

“Yes,” she answered. “I want an apple.”

“If I give you one, will you sit down over there by the tree and eat it so I can speak with your sister for a minute?”

“Yes. If you give me an apple, I will.”

“Do you promise?”

Mary Beth nodded anxiously, awaiting her prize. He nodded back with a knowing look on his face. Then he handed Mary Beth an apple. Without so much as a thank you, she grabbed it from his hand and walked over to the nearby tree, where she sat down and took a bite.

Hermann smiled at Greta. “I haven’t seen you around school for a while,” he said. Then he added, “Your surname is Zolner, right? I remember hearing someone call you that, but I would much rather call you Greta.”

She nodded. “Yes, Greta Zolner.”

He smiled. “I’m Hermann Weber.”

“It’s nice to meet you.” She smiled and looked over at her sister eating her apple. “I had to quit school because I needed to help my family. We have a farm. And besides the farm being a lot of work, as you can see, my sister is a handful.”

He laughed, “No worse than my own sister. She’s just a child. She’ll grow up soon enough.”

“Thank you for being so understanding,” Greta said.

He shrugged. There were a few moments of awkward silence then he cleared his throat and stood up tall as he pushed out his chest. Then finding courage, he said, “There is a dance coming up at the church in town. I have seen you there, but not in a while.”

“No, after my brother died, I didn’t have the heart for it. So, I haven’t been to church. I suppose I should go back again,” she said.

“That’s why I’ve never seen you at any of the dances.”

She laughed uncomfortably. “I’ve never been to a dance at the church or anywhere else.”

“Well, it’s about time we changed that, don’t you think?”

She looked down at her shoes. “I don’t know.”

“I would like you to go to the dance with me. Would you?”

“You mean like would I be your date?”

He laughed, “Yes, that’s exactly what I mean. Would you?”

She nodded quickly, “I would like that.”

“Well then,” he smiled eagerly, and she thought his smile made him look sweet, sincere, and almost boyish. She couldn’t help but return the smile. “The dance is next Saturday night,” he said. “I’ll come to your home at about seven o’clock and then we can walk to the church together. If that would be all right with you?”

Greta bit her lower lip and looked away. She didn’t think her parents would approve. They were always reluctant to allow her to spend time with friends, especially boys. A year ago, when she asked her father if she could go to a party that one of the girls from school had invited her to, he shook his head and said, “Will there be boys at this party?”

“I don’t know, but I would assume so. All the other girls my age are dating,” Greta had answered.

He shook his head in disgust. “Oh Greta, you are such a naïve girl. Boys your age are all no good. You see, I know what they want from a girl. And it will do nothing but get you into trouble. After all, I was once a young man myself.” Her father laughed. “No Greta, you may not attend this party. And you don’t need to be dating either. When the time is right, I will find you a husband. A man who can help me on the farm.”

She was so disappointed, but she knew that there was no arguing with her father. And she didn’t want to give him any reason to think she was getting into trouble when she left the house, or he might have stopped her when she went to the library. Because of this, she knew that she didn’t dare ask for his permission to go to this dance. However, she liked Hermann, and she wanted to go.

“I would prefer to meet you at the church,” she said. “But I do have some chores, and I couldn’t get there until eight. If that’s too late for you I

would understand..." she said.

"It's fine. I will be there waiting for you," he smiled again and her heart melted. For the first time she noticed he had a dimple on his right cheek. She wanted to reach up and touch his face, but of course, she didn't.

Then he reiterated, "Saturday night at eight, at the church. I'll see you there?"

"Yes," she said, relieved that he had not rescinded his offer.

"I look forward to it." He looked into her eyes.

"Me too," she said shyly. Then she remembered *I don't know how to dance. And, even worse, I don't have anything to wear.* Greta was about to tell him that she had changed her mind when Mary Beth walked over to them.

"I am done with the apple, and I want to go home now." Mary Beth said, wrapping her arms around her chest. "If Papa knew you were talking to a boy, he would be very angry."

"And that's why you aren't going to tell him," Hermann said to Mary Beth. "And...if you are a good sister and you keep your mouth shut, I'll give you another apple."

"I won't say anything," Mary Beth answered.

Hermann nodded, then he winked at Greta and handed Mary Beth another apple. She took a bite and smiled. She beamed as if she had won, and then she gave Greta her hand and the two of them walked away heading towards home.

CHAPTER 8

The following day, Greta finished her chores as quickly as she could. After her father had finished his midday meal and her mother lay down for a nap, Greta ran out the back door and headed straight for the library.

Ruth's face brightened, and she smiled broadly when she saw Greta. "I have a good book for you," she said, reaching under the counter in front of her.

Greta was out of breath from running. "I need your help. I need more than a book," she said desperately.

Ruth looked at her friend with concern. "What is it? What can I do for you?"

"I hate to ask you for this. I really do. I know that it's asking a lot. But I must ask..."

"What's wrong? Just ask me."

"I need to borrow a fancy dress to wear to a dance. I don't even know if you have one. But I don't have one. My church dress hardly fits anymore and when I ask my mother to make me a new one she says we don't have money for fabric," she scoffed, then she shook her head, and added in a sarcastic tone, "Yet, somehow we always seem to have enough money for her to make new clothes for my sister."

"I know, I know," Ruth said reassuringly, because Greta had told her all about Mary Beth and how her parents treated them both. "And don't you worry. I actually *do* have a very special dress that I will loan you."

"Oh, thank you, thank you!" Tears were forming in Greta's eyes.

“But I am going to require something from you,” Ruth paused for dramatic effect, then she broke a big smile. “Tell me everything. Where is the dance? Do you have a date?”

Greta’s eyes lit up as if there were candles flickering behind them. “I have a date to go to a dance at the church with the most handsome boy. His name is Hermann.”

“Oh my,” Ruth said, smiling. “That’s wonderful news. Tell me all about him.”

Greta told Ruth everything that had happened when she met Hermann. Ruth smiled, then winked, “So, at least Mary Beth’s antics of stealing an apple turned out to be good for something, yes?”

They both laughed.

“I suppose so,” Greta said.

“So, when is this dance?”

“Next Saturday night.”

“Do you want to come to my house to get the dress, or shall I bring it here to the library? What is easier for you?”

“I will slip out and come by tonight when everyone is asleep. It will be a good trial run for Saturday. I’ve never left the house at night like this before.”

“I know. Won’t your sister see you? You two share a room, don’t you?”

“Yes, we do. But there is no other way. So, I am going to have to escape while they are all asleep. By the way, would that be all right that I am coming late in the evening or would my coming over at night disturb your grandmother?”

Ruth had told Greta about her family and her grandmother. And although Greta had never met Ruth’s grandmother, she felt like she knew her.

“My grandmother won’t mind at all. I’ve told her all about you.” Ruth smiled. “I don’t know how much she will remember because her memory seems to have started fading with age. But she will be happy to have a visitor. So, what time can you come tonight?”

“I can get there about eight thirty or a quarter to nine if that’s all right?”

“Of course, it is. In fact, I’ll bake some cookies when I get home from work so we can all have a little treat.” Ruth smiled, “My grandmother loves to make tea. So, she’ll do that for all of us.”

“You are such a good friend. I don’t think I will ever find a way to pay you back for all the kind things you have done for me,” Greta said.

“There is no need for you to even think about paying me back, Greta. You are my friend. Friends help each other. That is what friends do.”

“Someday I will find a way to help you too. But for now, I have to get home. I must make supper,” Greta said.

“Here, before you go, take this book. I finished it last night. It’s called *Das Phantom der Oper*, or the *Phantom of the Opera*, it was published a few years ago, but we just got it in the library. It’s very good. You’ll enjoy it.”

“Thank you. I will return it next week. Is that all right?”

“Of course.” Ruth said, “I’ll see you tonight.”

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CHAPTER 9

Greta was nervous about getting out of the house. She knew she had to make sure that Mary Beth was very tired and would go straight to sleep that night. So, when Mary Beth got home from school, Greta gave her a snack then asked her to come outside so they could have a jump rope competition. Greta knew her sister could not resist this game. She was an expert at jumping rope, and she had won every competition she'd ever had with the other girls her age. Greta was tired from her chores and would much rather have started the new book that Ruth gave her, but she had to tire her sister out, and so she continued the jump rope competition with Mary Beth until it was time to serve the evening meal. After what felt like hours of jumping rope, Mary Beth, looking radiant with her skin lightly pink from the exertion, was exhausted. Greta sent her sister to take a quick bath before dinner. Then their father came in from the fields, and Greta served supper. After eating a large bowl of the heavy stew that Greta had prepared, Mary Beth fell asleep on the rug while playing with her doll. Gently, so as not to awaken her, Greta carried Mary Beth to their room and put her to bed. As always, because life on a farm began in the early morning hours, their parents went to bed early too. Greta watched as Mary Beth snored softly for a few minutes to be sure that she was sleeping soundly. Then as quiet as she could, Greta slipped out the window of the bedroom that they shared and climbed down to the ground.

CHAPTER 10

Greta ran all the way to Ruth's house. And although they had been friends for a long time, this was the first time in all those years that she had ever gone to Ruth's home. It was a very small house, but was well kept, with a recently tended vegetable garden in the front yard. Greta knocked and Ruth opened the door, immediately pulling her friend into a big hug. "I'm so glad you were able to get away."

"Me too," Greta smiled, still catching her breath from running.

True to her words, Ruth had baked cookies and the house smelled of the delicious baked goods. "Come in, sit down," Ruth said, indicating a kitchen chair.

"Where is your grandmother? Does she know I was coming to see you?"

"She knows. But she fell asleep. Don't worry. It's all right. Let me put a pot of water on the stove and I'll make us some tea."

Greta was angry at herself for remembering all the scary tales she'd heard over the years about the dangers of going to the homes of Jews. *There had been so many warnings to children to stay far away from anyone who was Jewish. Even the teachers at school said that a Jew might sacrifice a Christian child at an altar and drink their blood.* Greta hated those old terrible lies. And she refused to let them cloud her mind. She had been closer to Ruth than anyone she'd ever known, and she thought that Ruth was one of the kindest people she'd ever met. And so, she was ashamed that all those horrible warnings had even entered her mind.

They sat at the kitchen table and spoke softly, so as not to awaken Ruth's grandmother as they ate the delicious cookies along with cups of hot

tea. "Did you like my cookies?" Ruth asked after they finished.

"Oh yes, they were wonderful."

Ruth smiled.

"I'm glad," she said. "They are called Mondel Brot. They are Jewish cookies. In fact, they are my grandmother's recipe. She showed me how to make them when I was very young, and they always remind me of being with her in the kitchen."

"I loved them," Greta admitted, "and it was really kind of you to take the time to bake them for me."

"I never have visitors, so it is very special to me to have you here," Ruth said. "Now, sit right there and I'll be right back." Then she stood up, and as she left the room, she said, "I'm going to get the dress."

While Greta waited, she took another cookie from the clean china plate and dipped it into her tea. She took another bite and closed her eyes. The cookies really were good, and she loved Ruth even more for taking the time to bake them. Just then, Ruth entered the room carrying a dress made of dark burgundy satin. Greta gasped when she saw it. "It's so pretty," Greta said.

"I was hoping you would like it."

"Can I try it on?"

"Well, of course you can," Ruth smiled. "And don't make yourself sick eating all those cookies at once. I am going to pack the rest of them up for you to take home."

"You don't have to do that."

"I know. But I want to," Ruth said. "Now, come on, try the dress on."

Greta removed the cotton house dress she wore every day. Then she was standing in Ruth's kitchen wearing worn gray underwear that had once been white.

Ruth handed Greta the dress and she slipped it over her head. Then she pulled it down, and within a few moments, she felt as if she had been transformed from a poor farmer's daughter into a princess. *Cinderella*. The word came into her mind.

Ruth gasped and smiled. "Greta, you look beautiful."

"I feel beautiful." Greta smiled and she whirled around. Both girls laughed.

"Come, follow me there's a mirror in my room. You can see the dress," Ruth said.

Greta followed behind Ruth who led her to a sparsely furnished, but impeccably clean bedroom.

When Greta saw her reflection in the mirror tears came into her eyes. “I do look beautiful,” she said. “I’ve never felt beautiful before in my entire life. I have always accepted the fact that I was plain and would always be plain. But tonight, in this dress, I am beautiful.” Tears ran down her cheeks as she smiled at Ruth.

“Yes, you certainly are. Now, a young lady also requires the proper undergarments,” Ruth said as she opened the drawer of her small dresser. She took out a bra and two pairs of clean white panties. “Take these and wear them under your dress. They are yours to keep.”

“You don’t have to do that,” Greta said. “I’ll wash them and return them.”

“I want you to have them. You should be wearing clean undergarments every day.”

Greta nodded, “I know, but I don’t have any.”

“Well, you have these.”

“Thank you,” Greta said, wrapping her arms around Ruth.

“No need to thank me. You’re my best friend. But you’re more than a friend, you’re like my little sister,” Ruth said.

“I’m only three years younger than you,” Greta said, “it’s not like I am a child.”

“Of course not. But you are like a sister to me. And since you’re younger, you are my younger sister.”

Greta smiled. “You’re right. And I feel the same way. You are closer to me than my own sister.”

Ruth left Greta in front of the mirror to admire her reflection for a few minutes longer. Then she returned carrying the dress Greta had worn earlier. “Go ahead and change back into your dress while I wrap up the cookies for you.” Ruth said. “I’m going to go back into the kitchen so you can have some privacy while you change clothes.”

Greta nodded and reluctantly slipped the wine-colored dress over her head and replaced it with her old one. Then, carrying the dress and her new undergarments, Greta went into the kitchen, where she found a package tied neatly with a ribbon. She looked at it for a moment. Then she turned to Ruth and said, “You didn’t have to pack the cookies, you could have kept them for you and your grandmother.”

Ruth smiled. "I want you to take them home and enjoy them. But before you go, do you know how to dance?"

"No. I am a little worried about it." Greta admitted.

"Don't worry." Ruth said, "Let me teach you how to dance so you're ready when Hermann asks you to dance on Saturday."

Greta nodded. Ruth showed her how to dance and then quietly sang while they danced around Ruth's small living room. "You're a quick learner," Ruth said smiling, "you're doing very well."

"Really?"

"Absolutely. You're ready for Saturday night," Ruth smiled.

"I am so excited."

"I know. I am excited for you. You'll have to come and tell me everything as soon as you can get away."

"I will. I promise. I guess I should get home now," Greta said. "Thank you for everything." She wrapped her arms around Ruth again.

"Again, there is no need to thank me." Ruth said, winking at her. "Just be careful walking home. It's late and it's dark outside."

"I'll be all right," Greta said.

CHAPTER 11

Greta climbed back through the window hoping she would not awaken Mary Beth. And she was relieved when she looked over to see Mary Beth sleeping deeply. Quickly, Greta hid everything that Ruth had given her under her bed. Then she took off her old dress, slipped on a nightgown, and climbed into bed. Closing her eyes, she pictured herself in the dress that Ruth had loaned her. In her mind, she became the beautiful Cinderella from the storybook that Ruth had given her. She read that story repeatedly, and it was her favorite. In her mind, Hermann was no longer a vegetable vendor, but he had become a prince. And the church recreation room was a royal ballroom where they danced in each other's arms across a white marble floor while crystal chandeliers twinkled overhead. Greta drifted off to sleep with a smile on her face.

Greta's chores seemed easier the following day, and she sang to herself as she washed the kitchen floor. This was because her mind was on the upcoming dance. No boy had ever shown an interest in her before. She felt light, and work that seemed like a burden the previous week was now not even difficult.

Greta usually hated Monday's because there was so much to do. But not this time, Greta was cheerful as she forced Mary Beth, who hated to get up in the morning, to get out of bed and get ready for school. And then, because she was thinking of Hermann, she even found herself smiling as she prepared and served the family's breakfast. After her father went to work outside and her mother went back to bed, Mary Beth left for school. Then, not resentful, as she usually was, Greta pulled the washboard out from under the cupboard and sat down on the floor to scrub the dirty

clothes. Once the clothes were hung on a line outside to dry, Greta peeled carrots and potatoes and cut up a large head of cabbage which she put into a pot filled with water for soup. And all of this she did with a heart as light as a moonbeam.

The week seemed never ending. Each day was filled with the same mundane chores. But finally, Saturday morning came. And as Greta did every Saturday morning, she took Mary Beth to the market with her. But this time when they passed the vegetable vendor, she saw Hermann glance over at her and she blushed. Greta looked away, but then she turned her head back and looked up at him. He smiled and she smiled too.

Mary Beth broke the moment between them, "Why are you smiling at that boy?"

"I wasn't. I don't know what you're talking about," Greta said defensively.

"Oh yes, you do," Mary Beth's eyes narrowed. "And if you don't make him give me an apple, I am going to tell Papa on you. I am going to tell him that you were flirting shamelessly with one of the vendors at the market."

"I don't have enough money to buy you one. And I don't want to ask him. Please don't do this today, Mary Beth," Greta said, but she was feeling so much resentment towards her sister that she had to take a deep breath to stop herself from slapping her.

"I told you something. Now, I want an apple. And if you don't get me one, I am going to tell Papa, and he will be very angry with you." This time when Mary Beth spoke, she was very loud.

"Mary Beth, please, don't do this."

"I will if I want to," she sat down on the ground. "I am not getting up until you get me an apple."

"I will leave you here then!" Greta growled.

"You wouldn't dare. Mama would kill you."

"You are a brat. You know that, don't you?"

"I want an apple. And I want it now," she was screaming and kicking her feet.

Greta was embarrassed. Her sister had gotten Hermann's attention, and he was looking directly at her. She had hoped to go to the market and return home without him noticing. She hadn't wanted him to think she had come there just to see him. Then, when he saw her and smiled, she felt better about being there. But now, with her sister causing a commotion, she was

embarrassed. *Everything had been going so well, but now Mary Beth's willful temper had ruined it.*

Hermann didn't seem phased by her sister at all. He walked over to Greta and smiling, he held out an apple to Mary Beth. "This is for you, little girl," he said, and Greta realized that she'd never told him Mary Beth's name.

Mary Beth smiled broadly, her crocodile tears already drying on her cheeks. She took the apple then took a bite.

"How is it?" Hermann asked.

"It's good."

"I'm glad you're enjoying it. Why don't you go and sit down under the tree like you did last time."

"Why? Do you want to talk to my sister? Like you did last time?" Mary Beth said, accusingly.

"Yes. That's right."

"What do you want to talk about? Is she flirting with you?" Mary Beth said, and Greta felt her face grow hot. Sometimes she hated her little sister.

"It's nothing like that," he smiled. "It's just that your sister and I know each other from school. Since we are old friends, we like to talk about the things we did at school."

"Well, she doesn't go to school anymore. So, there's nothing to talk about," Mary Beth said rudely.

"That's why I want to talk to her while she's here at the market. Because she doesn't go to school, so we can't talk there. Anyway, if you are a good girl and you go and sit under the tree for a few minutes, I'll give you another apple to take home for later. How does that sound?"

Mary Beth nodded. This seemed to make sense to her. Then she began to walk away, but before she was too far away for Hermann to hear her, she said, "In case you were wondering, my parents don't permit my sister to go out on dates with boys. Not that any boys have ever asked her."

Shut your little mouth, Greta thought. Go and sit down and eat your apple. I wish you would choke on it. God forgive me. But you've caused enough trouble for one day. Greta could feel her face growing even hotter, and she knew she was turning as red as ripe strawberries. "I'm sorry," she said, not knowing what else to say. "My little sister can be quite a handful. But thank you for the apple, again."

He shrugged. "You're quite welcome." Then Hermann looked into Greta's eyes and said, "Please tell me that you're still coming to the dance tonight. I've been looking forward to it all week."

She smiled broadly. Then quickly looked away, "I'll be there."
"I'll be waiting for you."

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CHAPTER 12

Greta was very excited. Her heart was beating like the wings of a hummingbird trying to break out of her chest as she and Mary Beth walked home from the market. She was nervous, but happy too. She had never been on a date before, and she didn't want to make a mistake and say or do the wrong thing. She wished she could get away for a while to talk to Ruth. But Greta knew that this was impossible on a Saturday, because Mary Beth was home from school. Besides, there was far too much work to do at home. And she knew that she would have to have all her work done early, or she would be working late into the night, and she would miss the dance. *Just like Cinderella*, she thought, and then a smile came over her face. *Things had worked out well for Cinderella. Is it possible that they could work out just as well for me?* A warm glow spread over her, and suddenly she didn't feel as bad about her lot in life.

It rained hard that Saturday afternoon. The sky turned the color of the ashes of burned charcoal. And angry shots of silver lightning broke through the darkness with thunderous roars, almost like a warning. Greta shivered as she looked out the kitchen window while she stood cutting up potatoes to fry with oil in a pan. She planned to serve them for dinner along with several eggs she'd gathered from the chickens earlier that morning. She hoped the rain would stop before she had to go to the dance. Greta had been so touched by the fact that Ruth had loaned her the dress that she wanted to be sure to return it in perfect condition, and now she was worried about ruining it in the rain.

There wasn't much Greta could do about the weather. She said a prayer and then forced herself not to think about it. It was still raining by early

evening, and Mary Beth was growing bored. She hated rainy days because she couldn't go outside and play with her friends. And so, she was sullen and very demanding of Greta's attention. "I have nothing to do," Mary Beth complained.

"I have to bake some bread for dinner. Would you like to help me?" Greta suggested.

"I suppose so. Can we bake cookies too?"

"I don't have enough flour or sugar," Greta said.

Mary Beth groaned.

"I'm sorry, I wish I did," Greta said as she searched the cupboard and found enough flour to bake a loaf of bread. Once they started baking, Mary Beth was pleased to be busy. Meanwhile, Greta felt sick inside. She couldn't share her feelings with Mary Beth, but she hoped that the rain would lift.

Sheets of rain were coming down from an angry sky when Greta served dinner that night. She was too nervous to eat. As she watched her family devour their food, she decided that her only choice was to wear her old dress over Ruth's dress in order to protect it from the weather. Once she was close to the church, she would take off her old garment before she entered the dance, and that way she would be dressed appropriately when Hermann saw her.

Mary Beth complained that she was not tired. It would have been much easier to get Mary Beth to go to sleep if she had been able to play outside that afternoon. But as it was, Mary Beth said she was unable to sleep. So, Greta sat down on her bed and read her sister two fairy tales before Mary Beth finally fell asleep. Quickly Greta got dressed and combed her hair in the darkness. Sucking in a deep breath she hoped that she looked all right. *If only I were able to glance in a mirror before I put my old dress over Ruth's lovely one*, she thought. But there was only one mirror in the house, and it was in the living room. If she walked through the house there was a possibility that she might wake one of her parents, and then it would be impossible to get out of the house. She shivered with nervousness as she tried to be as quiet as possible while climbing out the bedroom window. But once she was outside, she was relieved to see that the rain had stopped. In a moment she removed her coat and old dress and pushed it back through the window into the bedroom. Now she stood in the darkness wearing the beautiful burgundy dress. Greta took a deep breath and filled her lungs with

the fresh air that only comes after a heavy rain. The sky was no longer gray. It had turned an inky blue-black, and was illuminated with millions of tiny stars. Greta felt her toes tingling, and her stomach fluttering as she began to walk quickly towards the church.

The church was lit up with candle lights, the music of a local band filled the air, along with the laughter of young people. When she first arrived, Greta felt uncomfortable. She'd always been introverted and shy. Her only real friend was Ruth, and she knew for certain that Ruth would not be there. All the confidence and excitement she felt earlier began fading quickly as she looked in the window and saw the other girls her age. They were so pretty, almost like flowers, in their gowns. Greta thought about turning around and running away. Running as fast as she could to the safety of what was familiar, the safety of home. But before she could leave, Hermann walked out of the church door. He wore a dark blue suit, and although the sleeves were a little too short, Greta thought he looked incredibly handsome.

"You came!" he said, smiling.

She nodded and looked down at her feet embarrassed. Greta felt sick when she realized that her shoes were covered in mud from the wet ground.

"I'm glad you came," he said. "I was afraid you wouldn't."

"Yes. I came," she said. It was all she could manage to say. Everyone in the church looked so perfect, and she felt so out of place.

"You look beautiful," Hermann said.

If she didn't know better, she would have thought that he was teasing her. But when she looked into his eyes, she saw that he wasn't. Greta smiled, her lips trembling. "The ground was wet and well...I got mud all over my shoes," she said.

"Of course, everyone did. It was such a heavy rain today," he said.

"Yes, it was."

"Good for the crops, though." Hermann said, trying to make conversation.

"Yes, good for the crops."

Then, in a cheery voice and to make things less awkward, Hermann said, "Come on in. Let me get you some punch. Then perhaps you will allow me to dance with you?"

He was so chivalrous, and although in reality she knew he was only a vegetable vendor—probably the son of a farmer—and the other girls might

not have found him as attractive because of his twisted leg, to Greta he was the charming prince from the fairy tale she'd read when she was just a child.

"Wait here. I'll get us some punch," he said, pulling out a chair for her to sit down. Greta sat and waited. In a few moments Hermann returned with two cups of very sweet liquid. She sipped it slowly because she wasn't used to consuming so much sugar, and she didn't want to risk getting a stomachache. Hermann did not sit down beside her. Instead, he reached out for her hand. "Dance with me?" he asked.

She nodded and stood up taking his hand. Candles flickered all around the room. The faint fragrance of cheap perfume filled the air. And Greta thought that it was magical. Almost like a dream.

"You're beautiful," he whispered in her ear as they whirled around the dance floor. She never noticed that he was a bit clumsy when he danced, due to his leg. To her, he was a wonderful dancer. Although this was only the recreation room of a simple church, but in Greta's mind it was the grand ballroom where Cinderella danced with her prince. *Beautiful... No one has ever called me beautiful*, she thought, as she felt heat spreading through her, starting at the place where Hermann's hand rested gently on her waist. Even though she could see that all the couples were dancing this way, with the boy's hand at the girl's waist, no one had ever touched Greta so intimately. Was it the dancing or the excitement that made her feel lightheaded and out of breath? She couldn't say. But for a moment the room turned dark, and she thought she might faint. Hermann held her tightly, and she allowed him to hold her up and keep her from falling. The feeling passed, and they danced this way for the rest of the night until Greta was so breathless she had to stop.

"It's late. I should get home," she said shyly.

"I'll walk you. I don't like the idea of you walking alone in the dark."

"I walked here alone," she said.

"I didn't like it, but you wouldn't let me come to your house and get you. So, now that you are here with me, I won't allow you to go off in the dark by yourself. As a man, it's my responsibility to see to it that you get home safely."

My parents will be livid if they awaken and find out I'm gone. They will see the window open and know I sneaked out. And what if now they are waiting for me? If they found out, I can expect a beating from my father. But

that would not be half as bad as having my father tell Hermann that he must stay away from me. I don't want to displease Hermann, but I can't allow him to meet my parents, not yet. So, she said, "I can't allow you to walk me all the way home. But you can walk me to the edge of our farm if that would be all right."

"Are you ashamed of me?" He asked self-consciously, "It's my leg, isn't it?" Even in the darkness she could see his face fall as if he were deeply wounded, and she felt terrible.

"No, never. I would never be ashamed of you. I hardly notice your leg."

"You're lying," he said. "Everyone notices it."

"It doesn't bother me," she said honestly. "I think you are so handsome." Then realizing she'd said this she felt her face grow hot again.

"Do you really?" he asked.

"Yes."

"So why can't I pick you up from your house or walk you home, Greta?"

"Well, the truth is, I am afraid of my parents. You see..." she inhaled deeply. *I wish I didn't have to tell him this.* "I never told them I was going to the dance. I slipped out when they were asleep."

"But why? Didn't you want them to know you were going with me?"

"It's not you. It's them. I was afraid they wouldn't let me go. Remember when my sister told you that my parents don't allow me to go out with boys? Well, it's true."

"But why? We were only going to a church dance."

"I know. But my parents, especially my father, is afraid that if I go out with a boy, something bad will happen."

"Something bad?"

"Yes, he's afraid I will become a fallen woman, and then no one will want to marry me. And well..." she hesitated. "You see... I wanted to go with you. I couldn't risk asking my father in case he said no. So, I snuck out of the house in order to go to the dance with you."

He smiled and nodded. "I understand. So, Greta, to the edge of the farm?" He gestured with his hand toward the cobblestone street, and they began walking.

CHAPTER 13

As they left the church and began to walk, Hermann took Greta's hand. "Lead the way to your home. I'm not sure where you live," he said. "But I'll walk you as far as you will allow me to."

She smiled, "It's really not too far from here."

"I wouldn't mind if it was," he said. "I would be happy to walk you home wherever you live."

They were bathed in the light of a large and luminous full moon, as a bed of stars twinkled like fireflies in the midnight blue sky.

Her heart fluttered. *Am I dreaming? Could this really be happening to me? Nothing so wonderful has ever happened to me,* she thought, as she took a quick sidelong glance at Hermann. *I could be happy being his wife. I know he doesn't have much, but I don't need much, and I wouldn't ever ask for more. It would just be wonderful to feel wanted and beautiful, the way I am feeling right now.*

They didn't speak, but he held her hand the entire time they walked side by side. When they were close to her family's farm, Greta turned to him and said, "We're very close. We should say goodnight here. Thank you for a wonderful evening."

"I should be the one thanking you," Hermann said, and before he released her hand, he raised it to his lips and kissed it.

She was trembling. "I really should go now."

"Wait," he cleared his throat. "Before you go. Can I ask you something?"

"Of course. You can ask me anything."

He was nervous. She could see his body quivering, and she wondered why anyone would be nervous around her.

"I was wondering, if I could, well, I mean, I was wondering if I could kiss you good night."

"No," she said, suddenly surprising herself that she had refused, because there was nothing she wanted more than to be kissed by this young man whom she found so handsome.

"I'm sorry. Did I offend you?"

She shook her head. "I'm sorry too. It's just that I've never been kissed."

"Really? I find that hard to believe." He looked into her eyes. "I mean, you are so pretty. I would think that some lucky lad had already kissed you. Maybe even more than one."

She let out a harsh laugh. "Pretty? I'd hardly call me pretty," she said. "And no one has ever tried to kiss me before."

"Well, you are very pretty. I know you don't see it in yourself, but I see it in you."

She hoped that the darkness hid how red her face was turning. "I don't know what to say."

"You could say that it would be all right if I gave you a kiss."

She felt her lips quiver. Greta wanted him to kiss her, but she was afraid it would lead to something else, something she couldn't control. All her father's warnings about young men only wanting one thing from a girl came flooding back to her. She couldn't risk getting pregnant, and she was afraid if she let him kiss her, she wouldn't be able to stop there. But her heart raced with desire, and that desire was stronger than any warning. *I might never see another night like this. And I want to feel what it would be like to kiss him. I want it more than anything. And if it ends badly for me, if I do something I will be ashamed of later, then I will suffer the consequences. It will have been worth it.* Greta took a deep breath. "Yes," she said bravely, "Yes."

"Yes?" he repeated. "You're saying yes, I may kiss you?"

She nodded and pursed her lips. Her body grew rigid with nervousness.

He put his arms around her and smiled. "It's all right, you're very tense. Just relax."

"I don't know what to do," she said simply.

“There’s nothing to do. It’s only a kiss and it will come naturally,” Hermann was much taller than Greta. He leaned down to place his lips softly on hers. She felt her body grow soft with surrender. His arms tightened gently around her, and she thought that if he weren’t holding her up, her knees might give way, and she would fall to the ground. But he held her tightly enough to make her feel secure. Then he kissed her again, this time more passionately. The sweetness of the kiss left her breathless. “I like you. I like you a lot,” Hermann said. “And I would like to see you again. Maybe we could go for a walk one evening or just sit by the creek and talk some afternoon. Would that be all right with you?” he asked, still holding her in his arms.

“I would like that,” she admitted. “But don’t you have to work at the market and aren’t you still attending school too?”

“I had to drop out of school. My brother used to tend the farm and work as a vendor at the market, but he got conscripted a couple of years ago. My father is getting older and he’s not as strong as he once was. He still works on the farm, but he can’t do as much as he used to. So, I dropped out of school and took over the market. However, my family and I get along very well. And if it just so happens that I need to take an afternoon off to visit with a pretty girl,” he smiled and winked, “either my brother or my father will cover the vegetable stand for me.”

“And your mother? Is she at home?”

“No, unfortunately she died when I was very young, in childbirth when my younger brother was born.”

“I’m so sorry,” Greta said.

“It’s all right. It was a long time ago,” he said smiling at her, but in his eyes, she saw a hint of sadness.

“Anyway, when can I see you again?” he asked.

“I don’t know. I have to find a way to tell my parents that I want to go out with a boy.”

“You don’t have to tell them alone. If you will allow me to, I’d like to come over and speak with your father. I’ll explain to him that my intentions towards you are completely honorable.”

She smiled, feeling like somehow things might be all right. “I don’t think that’s a good idea. Just give me some time to speak to him, please. I think he might be more willing to allow me to see you if I talk to him first.” Greta said, she was already thinking about how she could get away to see

Hermann again. "Well, goodnight, and thank you for a wonderful evening," she said. Then she turned and began to walk towards the farmhouse.

"Greta," he said her name, and she felt a shiver of excitement. Never had her name sounded so lovely.

"Yes?" she whirled around to face him.

"Next time you are in town. I mean, next time you go to the market, perhaps you could bring your sister to my vegetable stand. I would be happy to give you both a bucket of apples," he said, then he laughed and he added, "That sounded rather stupid, didn't it?"

"Not at all," she reassured him. "I will need to go to the market in a few days, and I will be sure to come by and see you."

"Yes, please do. And...well, goodnight," he said.

"Goodnight," she began walking again.

"Greta?"

"Yes," she stopped and wished she could go back and hold his hand again.

"I want you to know that I really do like you. I feel good when I am with you."

She smiled, and although it was dark, she hoped that there were enough stars illuminating the sky for him to see her smile. "I like you too," she said, then she turned and walked up the steep incline to the house.

Quietly, Greta opened the window to her bedroom. Then, careful not to damage Ruth's dress, she climbed through. Once inside, she carefully removed the burgundy dress and laid it on her bed. She slipped her nightgown over her head. Her heart was singing with joy until in the darkness she heard Mary Beth say, "Where have you been?"

"Why are you awake? You should be asleep." Greta said, feeling suddenly cold.

"I was sleeping, until you woke me up. What were you doing out at this time of night, and why were you all dressed up? Besides, where did you get that dress? I have never seen it before."

Greta couldn't come up with a lie. She had never been good at lying. And so, she stood dumbfounded, knowing she was at the mercy of her sister. If Mary Beth decided to tell her parents that Greta had gone out without permission, Greta would be in terrible trouble. Her father would probably beat her. And her mother would give her the look of disappointment that Greta dreaded. She tried desperately to come up with

some sort of excuse that would satisfy her sister, but Greta could think of nothing. "Mary Beth," Greta could hear the pleading in her own voice, and she hated herself for it. "Don't tell Mama and Papa. Please."

"If I don't, what will you give me?"

"What do you want?"

"I don't know, what do you have?" Mary Beth said slyly.

"I will take you to the market and get you apples," Greta said.

"Not good enough. I want more than that," Mary Beth smirked. Then she was quiet for a moment, and Greta felt beads of sweat begin to form on her brow.

Greta hated the idea of being beaten, and of disappointing her parents. But even more so, she was terrified that once her parents found out that she had gone out without permission, they would be more likely to watch her even more closely. If they did, it would be almost impossible for her to see Ruth or Hermann without Mary Beth being with her. "So, what do you want? I will play jump rope with you tomorrow afternoon, for as long as you like."

"Nope, still not good enough," Mary Beth said. "I want you to steal the lace Mama bought for the dress she is making for herself, and I want you to make a dress for my doll out of it."

"I can't steal that from Mama, Mary Beth. Do you know how bad that would be?"

"I don't care. I know how bad it was for you to sneak out the window, so you had better do what I want or I am telling. Now, I want that lace for my doll's new dress," Mary Beth said.

"What will Mama say if she sees you carrying your dolly, and the dolly is wearing a dress made from her lace?"

"I don't know and I don't care."

"You're being unreasonable. Let me see if I can get some kind of work that will pay me enough to buy you some lace. Tomorrow I will go and see if some of the rich people on the other side of town would like me to do some of their wash. If not, I will offer to watch someone's child for a few hours. You will just have to give me a little time."

"I don't want to wait. I said that I want the dress made now," Mary Beth said firmly.

"I could cut up one of my dresses and make a new dress for your doll."

“You only have two dresses, and both are old and ugly. Even your church dress is ugly.” She hesitated, then in a sly voice she said, “Except... that one. I would accept a doll dress made from that material.” She said, pointing to Ruth’s dress that lay on Greta’s bed.

“I can’t do that. This dress doesn’t belong to me. It belongs to a friend of mine. Let me get some work and make some money, then I promise I will take you to the general store where we can buy some fabric. You can pick out the fabric you want.”

“No! I don’t believe you will ever get me the fabric. You won’t do it. You’re just lying.”

“Have I ever lied to you? Have I ever broken a single promise to you?”

“No...” Mary Beth said, thinking for a moment. And Greta thought her sister might give in. But then Mary Beth said, “I don’t care if you’ve ever lied before or not. It makes no difference to me. I want the dress now. Either use the fabric from that dress on your bed and make some excuse to your friend about why you can’t return her dress, or steal Mama’s lace.”

“I can’t do either of those things, Mary Beth.”

“That’s just fine. Then I am telling on you,” Mary Beth got up and began to walk towards the door. Greta grabbed her arm, not realizing she was squeezing too tightly. “Ow,” Mary Beth snapped, pulling her arm away. “You hurt me.”

“I’m sorry,” Greta said exasperated. “I didn’t mean to. But please be reasonable. I will give you what I can. Just don’t ruin this special night for me.”

“So far you aren’t willing to do anything I am asking of you,” Mary Beth said. “Either cut up that dress or steal Mama’s lace.”

“I can’t. I told you. I can’t.”

“Then I am going to wake up Papa and tell him that you just got home,” Mary Beth started yelling. “Mama! Papa! Come quick!”

Greta felt her heart sink as she sat down on her bed and began to cry.

I hate my sister. I wish she were dead. I really do. I wish she were gone from here instead of my brother. Zeno was such a good boy, and Mary Beth is such an evil little child. She has me trapped. I can’t steal from Mama, and I won’t destroy Ruth’s dress. So, what can I do? There is nothing I can do but sit here and wait for my father’s wrath. I can’t stand Mary Beth.

Waking a farmer in the middle of the night when he must be in the fields before dawn is never a good idea. He was disoriented and came

running into the bedroom with a knife in his hand. Their mother followed close behind. "What is going on in here? Has someone broken into the house?" He asked Mary Beth.

"No, Papa, but Greta did something very bad," Mary Beth said innocently. Then she told her parents everything.

No blame or punishment fell upon Mary Beth for disturbing their rest. All the anger her parents felt was directed at Greta. Greta's mother left the room. She walked into the hall and lit the kerosene lamp that stood on a shelf in the hallway. When she returned, the room was lit up, and she saw Greta sitting on the bed beside the satin gown.

"Where were you, Greta? And...where did you get that dress? Did you steal that from one of the shops in town?" Her mother demanded an answer.

"Yes, where did you get that and where have you been?" Greta's father said in a warning voice. Mary Beth smirked at Greta.

"I went to the dance at the church. I borrowed this dress from a girl I know."

"What girl? A girl from the church? A neighbor? A girl from school? You don't have any friends," her father said. "You stole this dress, didn't you? You are nothing but a common thief. And a sneak too. You went out without permission. Who knows what you did when you were out. My guess is that you were with a boy doing things you shouldn't be doing," he shook his head.

Greta knew she dared not tell them that she did have a friend, and that it was the Jewish girl who worked at the library. They would have been appalled and furious. "I borrowed it from a girl I know from school," she lied.

"Who is she?" Mary Beth asked slyly, "Who is your friend, Greta?"

Shut your mouth. You've caused me enough trouble. Why don't you just die. I would like to be rid of you forever, Greta thought as she glared at her sister. Then, Greta felt a shiver run down her spine.

"Admit that you stole this dress, Greta," her father said. "You are a good for nothing daughter who has brought shame on our family. We might be poor, but we are not thieves," he said. Then he walked over to where Greta sat weeping and slapped her hard across the face. "Say it, say you stole it from one of the shops in town!"

"I can see that it's an expensive dress," her mother said. "It's satin. We could never afford something like that. And I don't think you have any

friends who are close enough to you to loan you a dress like this. So where did you get it?"

"Don't lie to us, Greta," her father was angry.

Greta glanced at her sister, who was smirking. She shook her head at Mary Beth, who stuck out her tongue in response. "I know where she got it," Mary Beth said.

Both of their parents turned and stared at Mary Beth, waiting for her to tell them. Greta was frozen in place. She couldn't speak. She was terrified of what Mary Beth might say.

"Greta is friends with the Jew girl who works at the library. Jews are all rich. I'm sure she got it from her."

How could Mary Beth know that I am friends with Ruth? She must have followed me when I didn't know it one day.

"A Jew? This is even worse than I thought. You have made friends with a Jew? Do you know what that can do to our family name? To your reputation? And what about your sister? What about Mary Beth's chances of marrying a nice boy from a good family, never mind your own chances." Her mother was frantic. "You are such a disappointment. How could you be so stupid?"

"Is it true?" her father growled. "Are you friends with a Jew? You must be the dumbest girl in this town. I wonder how many people have seen you talking to a Jew?"

"Greta, I don't know what is the matter with you," her mother said. "I can just imagine the terrible things people must be saying about us."

The satin dress was illuminated by the moonlight that filtered through the window. In an instant, her father grabbed the dress and took the knife which he brought with him in case the house had been broken into, and cut the garment in half. Greta let out a scream. Then her father pulled her by the arm and threw her onto the floor. He began to kick her in the stomach, then in the legs, and when she turned over to protect herself, he began to kick her in the back. She was weeping, not only for the pain, but because she was going to have to tell Ruth that her dress was ruined.

"Stupid, stupid, girl," he said. Then he turned to his wife and said, "Come, let's go back to bed. There is nothing more we can do now."

After they left the room, Mary Beth said, "You should have done what I asked. Now I am going to get the fabric from the dress anyway."

"Shut up. Shut your mouth. I don't want to hear your voice."

All night Greta lay in bed, unable to sleep. Her body ached from the beating, and she had no idea how she was going to tell Ruth about her dress. Horrible thoughts crept into her mind: thoughts of her sister getting sick and dying, thoughts of her sister being attacked by a wolf, thoughts of her sister suffering. Greta hated herself for feeling the way she did, and yet she couldn't stop. Soon she would have to get up and prepare breakfast for the family. A little voice in her head said, "*You know, you could poison them?*" The thought was satisfying. But she wouldn't. She knew she could never do that. She could never live with herself if she did.

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CHAPTER 14

The following day Greta's entire body was covered with purple and black bruises. Neither of her parents would even look her way when they came into the kitchen in the morning. Finally, after several moments of silence, her father said, "You cannot be trusted. And so, you will not be permitted to leave this house without taking your sister with you from now on."

Mary Beth was smiling behind her hand. Then Mary Beth's eyes met Greta's, and Mary Beth winked.

They ate in silence for several minutes. Greta kept her head bowed, unable to look at either of her parents. After he finished eating, her father pushed his plate away, burped loudly, and then took a long breath. "Greta you are a disappointment to me. Now, I am not sure where you were when you went out last night. What I do know is that good girls don't behave like this. I always wanted to believe that my girls were good girls. But you sure proved me wrong, and I am ashamed of you."

Greta swallowed hard, but she couldn't find it in her heart to apologize. Her body hurt all over from the beating he'd given her, and she was angry. For as long as she could remember, she'd wanted her father's love. But he never gave it freely. She tried to win his affection in every way she could. Last night was the only time she'd ever done anything for herself, and she paid a hefty price. Right now, she hated her sister and resented her parents. And she was afraid that if she said anything she would lash out and her father would beat her again.

After breakfast, her father went outside to work, and her mother went to her room. Greta and Mary Beth were alone together in the kitchen. Greta

didn't dare look at her sister. She was afraid she might strike her if she did. But Mary Beth had no fear of Greta. She walked over to Greta, and in a taunting voice she said, "I talked to mother this morning, and she said she is going to use that satin fabric from your Jew friend's dress to make me and my dolly matching dresses. She said it was a shame to let it go to waste. So, as you can see, you should have listened to me and done what I asked in the first place. But it doesn't matter to me because it all worked out even better for me than I expected."

"Just go away. Please, just go away," Greta said, gritting her teeth.

Mary Beth shrugged. There was no school that day, and so after church she went to her mother's room to ask if she could go outside to play with Adelheid, a girl who was the same age as Mary Beth and who lived on the farm next door.

"You may go, but be careful, and be home for supper," her mother said.

"I'll be home by supper, Mama. I promise." Mary Beth said in a sing-song voice.

"Wash the floor, Greta," Her mother called out from her room. "I can't begin to tell you how ashamed I am of you. I would never have thought you would be so devious."

Greta didn't answer. Her parents may have considered keeping her at home and making her work a punishment. However, she knew that nothing was different. Even if she had not gone out the night before, she still would have had to wash the clothes and scrub the floor. But not Mary Beth, Mary Beth was never told to do heavy chores. She cursed Mary Beth under her breath as she filled the bucket with soapy water. Then she got down on her knees and began to scrub.

CHAPTER 15

Later that afternoon, after Greta prepared lunch, while her father was busy in the fields, Mary Beth was still visiting her friend at the neighbor's house. Their mother did not come out of her room. She claimed she had a headache and was going to take a nap. Greta wanted to get to the library as quickly as possible. She would have liked to avoid seeing Ruth, because she was so sorry for what had happened. But she felt that it was only right that she go to the library and tell Ruth everything, even though it was going to be very hard. Ruth had loaned Greta her best dress and now it was destroyed. *I'll get some extra work and pay for it. I'll find a way*, she thought, as she took off her apron and ran out of the house without looking in the mirror to see if her hair was neat or messy. She had to hurry. She had to get to the library and back while everyone was unaware that she was gone.

Running as fast as she could, all the way to the library, left Greta out of breath, and although it was chilly outside, by the time she arrived she was sweating. Not taking the time to wipe the perspiration from her face, she walked inside and went right up to the desk where Ruth was checking out books. When Ruth saw Greta there was a look of horror on Ruth's face.

A woman was standing at Ruth's desk while Ruth was checking out some books for her. Ruth continued to check out the books, but she couldn't take her eyes off Greta. When the woman was done, Greta stepped up to the counter. Ruth came out from behind the desk and walked over to Greta. Gently, she pushed back Greta's hair that lay plastered on her forehead with sweat. Greta was still breathing heavily.

"What happened to you?" Ruth asked gently.

“What do you mean?”

“Your face? You’re all bruised,” Ruth touched the dark bruise that had formed on Greta’s cheek as gently as a bird.

“That’s what I came to talk to you about,” Greta said. Then she broke down and started to cry. Then in a rush of emotion she ranted, “Ruth, I’m so sorry. I’m really sorry. I don’t know how you will ever forgive me. But I swear I will find a way to buy you a new one. I will. I promise you. No matter what I have to do. Please forgive me I couldn’t bear to lose your friendship. It’s all I have.”

“You needn’t worry about losing my friendship, that will never happen. But I don’t understand what you’re talking about. Forgive you for what?” Ruth asked.

Then, trembling, Greta told Ruth what happened the night before. “So, your dress is ruined. But I promise you, I will take in wash, or sewing, or something. Or I will go and clean the houses of rich people. I will somehow find a way to buy you a new dress as nice as the other one.”

“It’s all right,” Ruth said, stroking Greta’s back, “It’s only a dress. It wasn’t your fault. Don’t cry.” Then she wrapped her arms around her friend and hugged Greta. “It’s just a material thing. I hardly ever wear fancy clothes anyway. So, don’t you worry about it at all.”

“I really am so sorry.” Greta was sobbing so hard it, she was finding it hard to catch her breath.

“I know you are, and it’s not your fault. Besides, I have other dresses. And someday, I will go back to school and become a teacher. Then I will earn a good salary and buy us both nice dresses,” Ruth smiled at Greta.

“I wish you were my sister instead of Mary Beth,” Greta said.

“I wish I was too. I always wanted a sister,” Ruth admitted. Then she asked “So, you haven’t told me about the most important thing. How was the dance?” Ruth smiled. “Did you see the boy? Hermann was his name, yes? So, tell me. I am dying to know what happened!”

Greta’s face lit up. “I did see him. And yes, his name is Hermann. You would know him if you saw him, he has a fruit and vegetable stand in the market. Anyway, the dance was wonderful.” She took a long breath and stopped crying. Then smiling she whispered, “He was wonderful. I felt like Cinderella.” Greta giggled softly.

“Tell me everything. Did you dance?”

“Oh yes, we did.”

“Tell me more. But tell me quickly. I don’t want you to get in any more trouble, so I want you to get home before they realize you’re gone.”

“All right. I’ll tell you everything. And I’ll be very quick,” Greta said, and she did.

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CHAPTER 16

“**W**here have you been?” Greta’s mother asked when Greta walked into the house. “I had to clean up the dishes after lunch. Now it’s dinnertime and your sister isn’t home yet. Soon it will be dark.”

“I went for a walk,” Greta said.

“I know you scrubbed the floor, but did you wash all the clothes and the bedding, too?”

“Yes, they are hanging outside in the back yard.”

“And supper? I see that you didn’t prepare anything for supper. What is wrong with you, Greta? It seems like you’ve changed and you are not the responsible girl you once were.”

Greta felt herself shivering inside. How could she have forgotten to put up a stew for their supper? “I’m sorry mother. I don’t know what got into me. I forgot.”

“You forgot? How is that even possible? Where has your mind gone lately, Greta? You forgot to prepare the evening meal? I am afraid your father is right, you are becoming involved with boys and getting into trouble?”

“I’m not getting in trouble. I promise you. And I’m sorry, Mama. I didn’t feel well. I needed to take a walk.”

“That makes no sense to me. None at all.”

“I’ll cut up some potatoes and cabbage. We have some eggs. I can make a quick supper with those things,” Greta suggested.

“I’ll make supper. I want you to go to the farm next door and see about your sister. She has probably lost track of time. Bring her right home. I want

you both home before it gets dark. Do you understand me?”

“Yes, mother,” Greta said.

Greta hung her head and left the house. She walked quickly to the neighboring farm, but when she arrived, she was surprised to see the neighboring family all standing together outside. They were speaking in whispers. Greta’s eyes scanned the group, but she did not see Mary Beth. Greta approached the neighbors. She was about to ask them where her sister was when she looked down at the ground.

Greta let out a scream.

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CHAPTER 17

Mary Beth lay on the ground with a pool of blood circling her head, her golden curls stained red like a wicked fiery halo.

“Mary Beth?” Greta said softly as she fell to her knees beside Mary Beth’s body. But there was no answer from Mary Beth. Nervously Greta shook her sister’s shoulders. “Mary Beth?” she said, louder this time. Again, no answer. Greta turned to the others and asked, “What happened to my sister? Adelheid, you were playing together, you and Mary Beth. What happened here?”

Adelheid, a small blonde girl, with very large blue eyes, was weeping and hiding behind her mother. “Go on, tell her,” Adelheid’s mother said, with her hands resting on her daughter’s shoulders for support.

“Mary Beth wanted to ride our horse. I told her not to try it. I said my parents would be mad. Our horse can be very dangerous, especially if she doesn’t know you. Well, I told Mary Beth this, but she wouldn’t listen. The horse wasn’t even saddled or ready to ride. But when Mary Beth gets something in her mind, she won’t give up. I tried to hold her back, but she pulled away from me, and that was when she ran behind the horse. She was going to try to get to his other side so she could mount him. But like I said, our horse is very moody, and she didn’t know her. So, when Mary Beth ran fast behind her, the horse got spooked and kicked her in the head.”

“Dear God.” Greta gasped as she touched Mary Beth’s neck, feeling for a pulse. Guilt was swelling like an evil cancer in her stomach. “Is she...is she dead?” Greta looked at Adelheid’s parents for an answer.

“Yes,” Adelheid’s father said. “I’m sorry. I really am. But she shouldn’t have done that.”

Greta couldn't speak. Her throat was tight and dry. *I wished that she would die. And now she's dead. This is all my fault. Mary Beth is dead, and I willed it to happen. I am surely going to hell.*

"You should go home and tell your parents," Adelheid's mother said. "We were going to go over there and tell them, but it's probably best if it comes from you."

Greta nodded. Then she stood up and began to run home. The sight of Mary Beth lying dead on the ground was burned into her memory, and she doubted she would ever be able to erase it. Bile rose like a river of fire in her throat. And she vomited.

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CHAPTER 18

When Greta arrived home her mother was waiting for her. “Where is your sister? It’s time to eat. Your father is hungry. And the eggs are getting cold.” Her mother said in a demanding tone, but then she stopped speaking when she saw Greta’s tear-stained face. Her hands trembled, then in a soft voice she said, “Greta, what is going on? Where is Mary Beth?”

A river of tears came flooding down Greta’s dirty stained face. Then she looked into her mother’s eyes and told her what happened to Mary Beth at Adelheid’s house. Her mother began to tremble. She didn’t speak, but her hand went to her heart as she sunk down on to the floor where she sat staring out in a daze. For a few moments neither of them moved. Then her father walked into the kitchen from the bathroom. “What’s this?” he said, looking from his wife to his daughter.

Neither Greta nor her mother could bring themselves to tell him.

“What is this?” he asked again, more firmly this time.

Greta was shaking, and still crying, but she told him.

He didn’t say another word. He left the room. Greta followed him as he walked slowly into the living room and grabbed his rifle. Then without saying a word, he left the house. Greta ran after him, following him at a safe distance, all the way to the neighbor’s farm. When he arrived, he didn’t speak to anyone in the family. But Greta was watching him. She saw the look of utter distress on his face when he saw Mary Beth’s body. He let out a loud cry of anguish. Then he raised his rifle and shot the horse between the eyes.

“No! No! You can’t kill our horse. I need that animal to work our farm,” the neighbor was screaming. But it was too late. The horse dropped to the ground.

Then Greta’s father turned to the family. “I’ll be back with a wagon to collect my daughter’s body,” he said, straightening his shoulders as he left.

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CHAPTER 19

A dark cloud settled over Greta's family after her sister's death. Mary Beth was buried at the back of their property in the family graveyard. Her mother did not speak to Greta, and her father was a hard man who offered no comfort to anyone, not to his wife nor his daughter. However, even in his silence, Greta felt as if he blamed her. And from then on, he kept a keen eye on her, making it impossible for her to get away from the house even for an hour to go to the library. To punish Greta, her father forbade her to go to the market, insisting that his wife go instead.

Greta felt like a prisoner, and she longed to see Hermann again, but she had no idea how that could be possible. It was obvious her father didn't trust her at all. And as always, her mother did whatever her father told her to do. But a few weeks later Greta offered to accompany her mother to the market. "It will be easier for you if I come with you," Greta said. "I'll carry all of our purchases back home, so you don't have to."

Her mother considered this. Then she agreed. And Greta was thrilled she would be able to see Hermann again.

When they got to the market, it was very busy with women shopping for all sorts of food. The sounds of price negotiations could be heard on every corner. Greta turned to her mother and suggested, "Why don't I go and buy some potatoes and cabbage while you get the flour, Mama. That way we can finish faster," Greta knew her mother hated the market, especially when it was busy.

"Yes, that's a good idea. Hurry and get what you need. I want to go home." Her mother said, waving her hand at Greta and sending her off.

“Yes, Mama,” Greta said, as her mother turned and walked into the general store to buy flour. Once her mother had disappeared into the store, Greta quickly walked over to Hermann’s cart and began to pick through a pile of brown-skinned potatoes.

“You came back,” Hermann said joyfully. “I was hoping you would.”

She smiled but her lips began to tremble.

“What is it? What’s wrong?”

“My sister died in an accident.”

“Oh no. I am so sorry. Can I ask what happened?”

“She was playing with the girl who lives next door, and she got kicked in the head by a horse.”

“Oh Greta, that’s awful. What can I do to help you?”

She shook her head, “Nothing. There is nothing anyone can do. My parents are heartbroken. I feel terrible too.”

“I want to see you again. I want to come to your home and ask your father if I can take you out for a walk. Maybe even out to a restaurant for dinner. Would you like to go with me? To a restaurant I mean, with my leg and all,” he asked, looking at her, then looking down at his leg, and she could see in his eyes that he was afraid she would turn him down.

“Of course. I would love to go out with you. I would love to go anywhere with you. But right now is not a good time to talk to my father. He’s grieving. He doesn’t want me to go out with boys anyway. And right now, I can’t bring myself to talk to him about going out with a boy when he is in this state of mind. He would not even listen. He would get angry and say no. It’s better to wait until some time has passed and the wound of his loss is not so great. I hope you understand.”

“Of course, I do. And I don’t mind waiting. You are worth the wait. But I do hope that you will at least come by and see me here at the market. Then when the time is right you just say the word, and I’ll come to your house and talk to your father.”

“Yes, I will come as often as my parents will allow. But please, if my mother is with me, like she is today, don’t mention anything about this to her. At least not yet. You see, she would surely tell my father, and he would be furious with me.”

“I would never do anything to hurt you,” Hermann said sincerely.

“What is taking so long?” her mother walked over to Greta, carrying a bag filled with flour.

“I’m sorry,” Hermann said. “It was my fault. I had a difficult customer, and your daughter was forced to wait until I finished negotiating prices with her. Because I was so busy and it caused the two of you to be detained, I will give you a few extra potatoes and a head of cabbage as a gift from me,” Hermann said, smiling.

“That’s not necessary.” Her mother said firmly. “We don’t need charity.”

“I insist,” Hermann said, and he smiled even more warmly. Greta melted when she saw his dimple.

After that, Greta went to the market with her mother each week. These were the only bright moments in her life. She’d read and reread the two books she had at home: the one book that Ruth had given her, and the other one that she’d borrowed from the library, which was now overdue. She knew she had to take it back to the library, but she couldn’t see any way of getting out of her house.

Losing Mary Beth had only sent their mother into a deeper depression. Most of the time she would lie in bed and stare at the wall. And even though Greta was consumed with guilt and depressed as well, she tried as best she could to console her mother. But nothing Greta did made any difference, and her mother hardly spoke to her. Greta felt so lost and alone that she was desperately in need of her only friend, Ruth. But to see Ruth, she would have to sneak out of the house at night. If she were caught, her father would beat her again. Probably even worse this time. However, she could not go on this way. She had to take the risk.

So, one night when the moon was full like a giant silver ball shining brightly in a clear black sky, Greta took the library book from under the bed where she’d hidden it and climbed out the window of her room. She felt a little uncomfortable appearing at Ruth’s home in the evening without a prior invitation, but she knew that Ruth would understand. Once her feet touched the ground, Greta began running. Holding the book close to her chest, she ran all the way to Ruth’s house, and breathlessly she knocked on the door.

An old woman with thick silver hair that waved around her face opened the door. “Yes?” the old woman said. “Can I help you?”

“I’m Greta Zolner. I know it’s late to come calling, but, please, I would like to see Ruth.”

“Ahh, yes. I recognize your name. Ruth speaks of you often. Please, come in.” The old woman said, opening the door for Greta. “I’m Ruth’s

grandmother. Sit down, please.” She indicated a chair at the kitchen table. “I’ll be right back. I will let Ruth know you’re here.”

A few moments later, Ruth walked into the room. She was wearing a long white nightdress. “Greta! Are you all right? I haven’t seen you at the library in quite a long time.”

Greta nodded her head, “Yes, I know. I’m all right.” She said, but then she started to cry as she laid the book on the table. “It’s overdue and I don’t have the fee. I will have to owe it to the library. I know I can’t take any more books out until I pay it, but...I will pay it. I promise.”

Ruth stood up, looking puzzled. Then she wrapped Greta in her arms, “What’s wrong? What happened?”

Greta looked over at the old woman, then she looked back at Ruth. “Is it all right? Can I speak freely?”

“Of course. This is my Bubbie. You can say anything in front of her.”

“I killed my sister,” Greta said.

Bubbie gasped. “Oy, vey.” She said softly.

“I didn’t do it on purpose,” Greta explained. “I mean, I didn’t murder her. It wasn’t like that.”

“Go on,” Ruth said. “What happened, Greta?”

Greta trembled and wept as she told Ruth how she felt. “I cursed her. I willed her death to happen. I mean I didn’t think it really would but then it did. You see, I was so mad at her for what she did that night. I was so angry about your dress and about the beating. And even more so about the fact that it had become even more difficult for me to get out of the house. I wanted to punish her. But in truth, I really didn’t want her to die. I never really wanted this to happen. Oh Ruth, I feel so guilty.”

“It’s all right. You didn’t mean it. Sometimes people get mad and say things they don’t mean. You didn’t will it to happen, and it’s not your fault.”

“I’ll make some tea,” Bubbie said, standing up and filling a kettle with water.

There was silence until the whistle of the teakettle reverberated through the room. Then Bubbie poured them each a cup, then she said, “Nothing like a cup of tea to help you see things more clearly. This was an accident, child. It wasn’t your fault. You just aren’t that powerful. Only God decides who lives and who dies and he has his reasons. Now, drink that tea. It will make you feel better,” Bubbie said, smiling softly.

As the three women sipped the hot liquid, Greta told Ruth's grandmother all about Zeno. How he had been mentally delayed and her parents had sent him away. "They hated him for being born that way. But I didn't. I loved him. And I miss him every day," Greta whispered.

Bubbie listened quietly. "I can see it. I know that you loved your brother very much."

"I did. Zeno was like my own child. My mother left me in charge of him from the time he was born. So, I was with him most of the time, and I adored him. I don't know how they could send him away. He was a part of our family. But my parents couldn't even look at him after they found out that he was not going to grow up the same way as other children. And after Zeno was gone, my father insisted that I never tell anyone about Zeno's mental problems. If anyone asked about Zeno, I was just supposed to say that he came down with the flu and died. But he's not dead. He's alive somewhere, and I wish I could find him. I mean, I hope that he is. I hope that my father didn't do something horrible to him," she gulped.

"Don't think about it. And don't you worry. If either I or Ruth ever meet your parents, although I doubt we will, you can be sure that we will never utter a word of anything you say to us. Everything you say here in this house will be kept secret. That much I can promise you," Bubbie said, smiling at Greta.

"Thank you, Frau Bernstein. I felt like I was going to go out of my mind. I really needed to talk to someone. I've felt so alone and so horrible since this happened."

"Do you have a grandmother?"

"I never knew my father's mother—she passed away when I was very young. And my mother's mother died in childbirth with her younger brother. So, I never met either of them. In fact, I never met my grandfathers either."

"I could be your stand in grandmother, if you would like?"

"I would like that," Greta said. "I would like that very much."

"And, would you like to call me Bubbie instead of Frau Bernstein?"

Greta's face lit up for a moment. Then she looked away and frowned. "I couldn't."

"Why not?"

Greta glanced down at her shoes. She was ashamed of what she was about to say, but she couldn't find it in her heart to lie to this woman. "You

are Jewish. If anyone ever found out that I was coming here and talking to you they would tell everyone in town, and I would be ostracized,” she said, then she reached out and took the older woman’s hand. “I’m sorry. I hate that this is the way it is. I hate it that people don’t like Jews just because they are Jews. It’s wrong. But I know how they can be. And if my father ever found out, he would kill me.”

“I understand. But if you would like, you can be my secret grandchild. You can call me Bubbie in secret. No one needs to know anything about it. And you can come here to our house anytime you like. Ruth and I will welcome you as part of our family.”

Greta felt warm and glowing inside. For so long, she had yearned to be loved. She’d never really felt her family’s love, but here in this small kitchen she felt it. “I would like that so much. Bubbie,” she smiled. Then she reached over and patted Ruth’s hand. “Ruth has always been like a sister to me. More of a sister than Mary Beth ever was.” Then she hesitated for a moment. And with a shaky voice she asked, “Do you think God will punish me for not loving Mary Beth? I tried to love her. But she was always doing terrible things to get me into trouble. And I found myself cursing her even when I didn’t want to,” Greta admitted.

“No. I don’t believe God punishes young people for making mistakes. Besides, if you want to know the truth, I believe you loved Mary Beth as much as you could. She was just more difficult to love. Some children are like that. And they make us angry, so we find ourselves saying or thinking bad things that we don’t really mean. But God knows what is really in our hearts and he knows that we love these children even when we are upset or angry with them.”

“Do you really think God knows I didn’t mean it?”

“Of course he knows. And he loves and forgives you,” Bubbie said.

The three women sat together around the table, and Bubbie poured them each a second cup of tea. It was almost sunrise when Greta finally admitted that she had better be on her way home. “I had to sneak out tonight. My parents are angry with me for going to the dance, so they are watching my every move. Anyway, I am sorry that it’s so late and that I kept you both awake all night.”

“We were glad to have you. Nothing is more important than a friend. And, to have a friend, you first must be a friend,” Bubbie smiled at her, “And that means we are always here for you whenever you need us.”

"I am very lucky to have you and Ruth in my life," Greta hesitated for a moment, then she added, "Bubbie."

Bubbie smiled. "We are glad to have you as a part of our lives as well."

"I'd better go," Greta said, "soon my father will be getting up. I must have his breakfast ready when he gets out of bed. He is a farmer, so his day starts very early, before sunrise."

"We understand," Ruth said. "Come and see us again whenever you can."

"I will. I promise," Greta said as she got up and walked to the door. Bubbie stood up too, and hugged Greta.

"Be strong. God is with you always," Bubbie said.

Greta smiled and nodded. Then Ruth hugged her too and said, "I'm glad you came here tonight."

"So am I," Greta said. Then she glanced up and on the door frame she saw a shiny silver ornament that had been engraved with writing in a language she didn't recognize. Greta touched the ornament then she turned to Ruth and said, "That's so pretty. What is it?"

"It's called a mezuzah. Whenever we enter or leave a Jewish home, we kiss the mezuzah," Ruth said, "It's part of our religion."

"Why? What does it mean?"

"Well, you don't have time tonight or I would tell you the story of Passover. And since I know how much you like to hear stories I will tell you the next time I see you. It's a beautiful biblical tale. And once you hear the story, you will understand why we, the Jewish people, keep a mezuzah on our door."

"I wish I had time to hear it now," Greta said. "In fact, I wish I could stay here forever."

"Me too. I'd love to have you as a sister," Ruth sighed. "But I don't want your father to be angry and hurt you again. So, you had better hurry home."

"I know. You're right. Good night, Ruth. Good night, Bubbie." Greta said, closing the door to the warm home.

CHAPTER 20

The night air was cool with a soft breeze that rustled the leaves as Greta walked home that morning. She was ashamed to admit, even to herself, that joy was bubbling up inside her. *I should be sad. I should never be happy again, not after what happened to Mary Beth. But I am. I am happy to feel wanted. It was so wonderful to feel loved in Ruth's house.* Greta hummed softly to herself. It felt so good to know she had friends—Ruth and her Bubbie had made her feel so welcome in their home. This warm, delicious sensation was new to her. It made her want to giggle out loud. All her life, her parents had treated her like a burden, like an extra mouth they were forced to feed. For as long as she could remember, she had tried hard to be useful to her family, to earn her keep as best she could. However, no matter how many chores she did, there was always an underlying, unspoken knowledge that she was not the little girl her parents wished she could be. Her father watched her greedily every time she ate a morsel of his food. And sometimes he would even say something to let her know that it was his food she was eating, and his roof she was sleeping under. Greta had no doubt that she would never be adored by her parents the way they had adored her little sister. In fact, she was certain that if they had been given a choice of their children, which would live and which would die. Neither her father nor her mother would have chosen Greta to live. She knew that if it were possible, Mary Beth would have been playing in the sunshine and she, Greta, would be lying in the grave they dug for Mary Beth at the back of the family farm. *But this was not God's choice, she thought. So, maybe Bubbie is right, maybe God has a reason for keeping me alive, and for taking Mary Beth.*

When Greta arrived home, she quietly climbed through her bedroom window, which she'd left open just a crack, so it would be easier to open when she returned. But to her dismay, when she turned around, her father was sitting on the bed waiting for her. In his right hand he held a leather belt, which he slapped into his left hand rhythmically. Greta felt panic rise in her, and she wanted to run. But she knew her father was fast and very strong. If she tried to get away, he would punish her even worse. So, she stood in front of him trembling, but silent.

"Where were you all night?" The low growl in his voice warned Greta that the question was rhetorical. "I knew it. I knew you were running around with boys. Oh Greta, you are a stupid girl. These boys don't care what happens to you, they only want one thing from you. And then you are nothing to them. Nothing, do you hear? And should you get pregnant, you will bring such shame to our family. Turn around and lift your dress so your back is bare. You need this beating badly."

"No, please." She begged.

"Do as I say, now." He growled, then added in a whisper. "I can't believe my own daughter is nothing but a stupid schlampe, slut."

Greta's hands trembled as she pulled her dress up, exposing the backs of her thighs. Her father lifted the belt and brought it down on her legs. She let out a scream. White hot pain filled her entire body as she felt the leather slice through her tender flesh. "Please Papa, please stop. I wasn't doing forbidden things with a boy. I promise you. I wasn't. I swear it."

He ignored her and brought the belt down on to her once again. Greta fell to her knees. "Please, please, Papa," she was weeping. Tears streamed down her face. He kicked her so she fell forward and lay sprawled out on the floor, blood running down her thighs and calves.

"I must do something about you. I can't let you go on sneaking around. You've gone bad, Greta. I can't trust you anymore. Who knows what you are up to. For all I know, your behavior might have been responsible for your sister's death. You're an evil girl, Greta. I must take matters into my own hands with you. This whoring of yours must be stopped," her father said, as sweat began to bead on his brow. His entire body shook with rage as he raised the belt and brought it down, slicing it into her again. He was ranting at her. She heard him saying something about the church, something about the pastor having been in contact with him about a proposition. Her ears were pounding with her heartbeat. In the background she could hear

him ranting, but she couldn't understand what he said. His words were not clear. Her head was spinning. She felt blood pouring out of her and she cried out, overcome with agony. Then she fainted.

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CHAPTER 21

Greta tried to avoid speaking to Hermann the next time she went to the market with her mother. When he first spotted her, he smiled and waved at her, motioning for her to come over. But Greta ignored him and looked away. Then Hermann walked over to where she stood, leaving his cart unattended so he could speak to her. “Greta, why are you being so distant?”

“I don’t know what you are talking about. I’m here with my mother shopping.” Greta’s tone was cold and unfamiliar to him.

“You don’t come to me for vegetables? I saw you go and buy from my competitor instead. You know if it was a matter of cost, I would give them to you for free? Why Greta? Have I done something wrong?”

“No,” she pleaded, “you’ve done nothing wrong. I just think it’s best if we don’t spend any more time together.”

“But, why? Please tell me what happened. Tell me what I did wrong?” He begged her to answer.

Before she could answer, one of the other vendors called out, “Hermann! Some rotten boys just stole some apples off your cart.”

Hermann nodded. “All right,” he called back.

“You’d better go,” Greta suggested.

“No, I don’t care about the apples. I care about you. Please tell me what I did wrong.”

“Nothing. You did nothing. It’s my father. He’s forbidden me from speaking to any boys. I just think it’s best that we don’t talk anymore.”

“No, give me a chance. Let me speak to your father. I will tell him that my intentions are honorable. Please, can’t you just give me a chance?”

Just then, her mother came walking towards them. When Greta saw her, she said, "I have to go."

"Meet me by the lake tonight at eight thirty," he said, and her heart ached when she saw the hope light up in his eyes. "Please, Greta. Please just meet me."

"All right. I will. But go away now before my mother asks what we are talking about."

"I'll give you some potatoes. Just tell her we were negotiating on the price of potatoes."

She shook her head, "You are clever, aren't you?" She smiled but it was a sad smile.

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CHAPTER 22

Hermann was waiting for Greta under a weeping willow tree with heavy branches that hung gently over the lake. The stars reflected like tiny diamonds in the water. “Hermann...” she whispered his name as she walked towards him. “I’m here.”

“I’m glad. I was hoping you wouldn’t change your mind.”

“I wish I could make you understand that as much as I like you, anything between us is impossible. My father would never allow it.”

“But why not?” He pleaded with her.

“You really want to know?”

“Of course, I do.”

“He lies. He says he doesn’t want me to go out on dates because he is afraid some boy will take advantage of me. But that’s not the real reason. I know the real reason is because he needs me to take care of the house and help him with the farm. If I have a boyfriend, he is afraid I will get married and leave him. Then who will do my work?”

“But what about you? What about your happiness? Don’t you deserve to be happy too?”

She shrugged. “Probably not. Not after what happened to my sister.”

“What happened to your sister was an accident. Even you said that.”

“Yes, but...” Greta paused and looked down at the ground.

“But what, Greta? Accidents happen all the time.”

“I can’t say anything more about it. All I can say is I am weak. I wish I were stronger and that I could stand up to my father, but I can’t.”

“You can. You are not weak, Greta. You just have a good heart.”

“It’s nice that you see me that way,” she said, a small smile flickered across her face for a brief moment.

“Greta, I would like to someday see you as my wife,” he said.

The breath caught in her throat. She wished this more than anything, but she couldn’t express her feelings. And there was a part of her that wished she could show him the deep cuts that had begun to heal on the back of her legs. But she was afraid that if Hermann saw what her father had done to her, he might try to kill him.

“Say something, please.” Hermann took her hand in his.

She leaned over and kissed him. Then, in a soft voice, she said, “You are very dear to me.”

“Then let me talk to your father. Let me see if I can make him see that a marriage between us would be a good thing.”

“Not now. Not yet. Give him some time to calm down and get over my sister’s death. Then perhaps we will try.”

“I will give you all the time you need. I am just happy to know that you might want to be my wife someday.”

She looked into his maple-colored eyes, and her heart yearned for him. *You have no idea how much I want to marry you.*

He took her in his arms and kissed her. And for a moment all her worries disappeared. All she could see, feel, hear, taste, or smell was the beauty of this moment. In Hermann’s eyes, she saw every bit of the light that existed in the world. In his arms, she felt safe and secure. The sound of his voice was the comfort of the angels. The taste of his lips was more delicious than wine. And the fragrance of the grass, the trees, and night air made her heady. “Do you want to make love to me?” she said. This was the boldest thing she had ever done in her life.

“More than anything in the world,” he replied, his voice husky with passion.

“Then go ahead. Make love to me. My father is already accusing me of it, so I might as well make his accusations a reality.”

“No Greta, not here. Not like this. I respect you too much to do that. I want to make love to you on our wedding night. And if you will trust and believe in me, I know I can convince your father to trust me too.”

CHAPTER 23

BERLIN GERMANY
AUTUMN 1916

Ludwig Lang lay across the bed in the young prostitute's apartment. It smelled of cigarette smoke and the unwashed clothes that were scattered around the room. She was a pretty girl. Probably about twenty years old, with shiny blonde hair and soft brown eyes that were deep and soulful. But Ludwig hardly noticed any of this. Lately he had become bored with prostitutes. They were too easy; they posed no challenge to him. And he found that he was more attracted to the challenge of winning a woman's affection than he was to the actual act of sexual pleasure. He'd only gone back to this girl's room the night before because she lived right above the tavern, and he was very drunk and in no condition to try to walk home.

The girl lay naked, still sleeping beside him. Ludwig glanced over at her and sighed. Now that he saw her in the light, he realized that she was a lot younger than he'd originally thought. But then again, he had been too drunk the previous night to see her clearly, let alone determine her age. *Time to go*, he thought as he lifted his head from the pillow, but dropped it back down almost immediately. It felt like a hammer was pounding at his temples. And he suddenly felt sick to his stomach. Bile rose in his throat. *Where the hell is the toilet?* He didn't have much time to lose, so he shook her arm. "Where is your toilet?" he asked, holding in his vomit.

"Down the hall." She answered in a barely awake, raspy voice.

He cursed under his breath as he stood up, but before he could pull on his pants, he vomited on the floor. The girl's eyes were open. She was awake now, and she groaned when she saw what he had done.

"Sorry," he said, but his tone was unapologetic. "I'll leave a few extra Marks to cover the cleanup." Ludwig quickly got dressed, then without looking at her, he placed a wad of cash on the dresser to pay for the previous night.

But as he turned to go, she asked him in a small voice, "Will you come by to see me again tonight?"

He shrugged. "No, I don't think so," he said. Then he left the room, closing the door firmly behind him. He was dizzy, so he slowly descended the stairs to the main room. It was quiet except for Melvin, the house cat, who sat perched on top of the sofa. Ludwig nodded to the cat. He walked out the door and onto the street. The sun burned high in the sky, like a golden orb, and because of its placement, Ludwig decided it was around noon.

As Ludwig made his way towards his home in the more affluent area of town, his thoughts turned to his father. Whenever Ludwig thought of Herr Lang, he got a sick feeling in his stomach. His father considered him a disappointment. Ludwig had never wanted for material things, and he'd never worked. He'd been given a monthly allowance, and most of the time he gambled it away. He had never known poverty. Born into wealth, he'd always expected that money would flow easily to him, even though his father had told him that the Langs had not always been rich. It was his grandfather who had changed the fate of the family. In his youth, Ludwig's grandfather had never gone to school. His family needed money, and so he'd gone to work on an assembly line in a factory. Even though he was very young, he was ambitious, and he saved as much as he could. Never too proud to steal, connive, or manipulate to get ahead, he found a way to make that factory his own. And then, once he owned it, he worked tirelessly, and with driving ambition, he made his business wildly successful. Ludwig's father had forced Ludwig to listen to the story of his grandfather's rise to power a million times. But he found it boring, and he just didn't feel the same pride in his grandfather's success that his father felt. He just expected that he would have enough money, because it always had been that way for him. And he had no desire to work or succeed at anything.

Ludwig's greatest joy came from the excitement of gambling and the challenge of seducing women. Sometimes he won at the games, but often he lost. Ludwig knew that his father didn't approve of his lifestyle, but he didn't care. Even so, his father constantly cautioned him to stop running around and settle down. *That miserable old man has no joy in his life, and so he's always tried to ruin my life*, he thought, but he promised to try.

Herr Lang had grown up with his own father who had warned him about the horrors of poverty, and even though there was plenty, he was careful with their fortune. And although Herr Lang could have enjoyed a life of leisure, he chose to go to work at the factory every day. He tried to instill this sense of responsibility in Ludwig, but it didn't work. Instead, Ludwig resented his father for being so rigid and working so hard.

The Langs were wealthy people, and because of this Herr Lang had many opportunities to take a mistress. But as far as Ludwig knew, he never had a lover, even though Ludwig knew that his parents had a marriage of convenience rather than love. Herr and Frau Lang were respectful of each other, but Ludwig could not remember a time when he saw them embrace or kiss. In fact, he had never heard them speak tender words to each other.

As Ludwig walked the cobblestone street with the high sun beating down on him, and the brisk autumn air whipping against his face he didn't want to go straight home. The idea of seeing his father with his head aching from too much drink the night before seemed like an overwhelming prospect. So, he stopped at a small café. He was very nauseated, but because he'd been in this position so many times, he'd learned that sometimes a cup of strong coffee and a glass of water were helpful in easing his hangover.

A pretty, redheaded waitress smiled as she set a cup of steaming black coffee and a glass of water in front of him. "Thank you," he said, smiling suggestively. "You certainly look lovely this morning."

She blushed and smiled back coyly. And he knew if he'd asked her for a date, he was sure she would have accepted. And because she seemed too easy, he immediately lost interest. He laughed under his breath. Like so many other girls in her class, she probably saw his expensive clothes and pocket watch and assessed he would make a good husband. *Husband*. He shuddered at the very idea of getting married. It was quite repugnant to him. Quickly, he downed the entire glass of water and as soon as the coffee was cool enough, he drained his cup.

“My name is Renata,” the redhead said smiling as Ludwig paid the bill. “I hope you’ll come back and see me sometime soon.”

“Of course, I will,” he lied through his smile. Then he left the café and slowly started walking home.

The sun burned the back of Ludwig’s neck as he slowly ambled towards his house. *I am sure that my old man will be sitting in his favorite stuffed chair in the main living room, right in front of the fireplace, drumming his fingers angrily on the coffee table as he waits impatiently for me to come home. The thought of seeing him when I am in this condition turns my stomach. I’ve had more than enough of his questions and acquisitions. That self-righteous look on his old, wrinkled face is enough to take the joy out of what could be a lovely afternoon. Perhaps I won’t go straight home. I am feeling better since I stopped for a cup of coffee. I think instead of going home, I’ll stop at Feingold’s jewelry store. There’s a girl who works there that I find quite fascinating.* He licked his lips. *She is different, and she excites me. She’s a Jew. And I’ve never had a Jewish girl before. My father has been warning me against having anything to do with Jews for as long as I can remember. But I am not planning on marrying her, so I can do as I please, and there is no reason he would ever have to find out.* Ludwig bit his lower lip as he thought about the first time he’d laid eyes on that girl in the jewelry store. He and his best friend, Max, had been walking by the window of the shop. And it was Max who had pointed her out. “Would you look at that girl?” he said. “She sure is a beauty.”

Ludwig looked at the girl with her long dark hair and nodded, “She sure is. I wonder how she’d look without clothes?”

“Yeah. I would like to see that. But I hear that this store is owned and run by Jews. So, I bet she is one.”

“Let’s go in and meet her, even if she is a Jew. Are you game?” Ludwig challenged Max.

Max shrugged. “Sure. Why not?”

When they went inside, the girl was friendly, but she did not flirt with either Max or Ludwig, who were competing for her attention. She stood at the counter and behaved in a business-like fashion. She showed no romantic interest in Ludwig or Max.

“We both think you’re very beautiful and we’d like to take you to dinner,” Ludwig said, smiling. “It’s your choice. You can choose between us.”

“I’m flattered. But no thank you. I have a fiancé,” she refused respectfully.

“She’s an arrogant one,” Ludwig whispered to Max. “But I like that in a girl. It makes her harder to get.”

They both smiled at each other.

“Can I help you with a piece of jewelry?” she asked, pointing to the glass case in front of her.

Max shrugged. “Let me see those pearls,” he said, pointing to a pearl necklace.

Max and Ludwig were best friends. They were both handsome and well dressed. And it was easy to see they were both from wealthy families. They often competed for a girl’s attention. It was like a game to see which one of them a girl would choose. And the girls they met would lap up their attention like little dogs. But not this girl. She showed no interest in either of them. Ludwig looked at the girl’s frame as she turned around to grab something from the counter behind her. *I’d like to take her to bed. Not because I care for her, but to prove to Max that she would choose me and not him, he thought.* Then he let out a laugh. *Wouldn’t Max be jealous if I told him that I won her, that I took her to my bed? After all, I do wonder if that rumor my father told me, that Jews have tails, is true. I’d be rather keen to find out.*

But she had not gone to bed with him. In fact, after Max said he didn’t want the pearls, she asked if she could show either of them anything else. And when they said no, she excused herself and walked away. Max said he had to get home, and so they left with no items, just desire that flowed through Ludwig like hot molten lava.

Today, Ludwig was alone, and he was determined to win her so that he could go back and tell Max about his victory. So, he walked into the jewelry store and then headed directly up to the counter where she stood. “Good afternoon. Can I help you?” the girl smiled at Ludwig.

“You don’t remember me?” He was shocked that he hadn’t seemed to make any impression on her at all.

“I’m sorry, but I don’t. Should I?” she asked honestly.

“Of course, you should,” he gave her his most alluring smile. “I am the handsome young man who’s heart you broke.” There was a cavalier tone to his voice.

“I am sure you have me confused with someone else,” she said, then she looked in the direction of the back office and added. “Can I show you anything in the store?”

“How about a smile?” he asked.

“I mean, jewelry.” She answered.

“Ahhh, yes, jewelry.” He said, drumming his fingers on the glass counter.

“Well, can I help you with a piece of Jewelry today?” The girl was getting annoyed.

“I’d like to see the most expensive pearl necklace that you have,” he said, remembering that Max had thought the necklace he looked at was overpriced.

She nodded. “Of course. I’ll show you what I have,” she said. “Excuse me. I’ll be right back.” The girl returned in a few moments carrying a single strand of white pearls with a large diamond clasp. She lay a small swatch of black velvet onto the counter upon which she carefully placed the necklace.

“I must say, that is very nice,” Ludwig said as he picked up the necklace and held it close to his eyes, pretending he could tell what the quality was. “Do you own a strand of pearls like this?” Ludwig asked her.

She looked at him puzzled. “Do I own one?”

“Yes, that’s what I asked. Do you own a necklace like this?” he asked more firmly. This girl showed no sign of being interested in him. She did not flirt with him the way the other women he’d met always did. They would smile at him fetchingly and make small comments that alluded to the promise of a very satisfying sexual encounter.

“No, I don’t own a necklace like that,” she said curtly, feeling insulted, then she smiled and remembered she was trying to make a sale. “But it is lovely. And I am sure that the young lady you would be buying it for will agree.”

He laughed. “Do you think so? Well, let me tell you something. Since you think it is so nice, I would like to buy it as a gift for you.”

Her face grew pale. She shook her head, “I’m sorry. I don’t know you, and as kind and generous as that gesture is, I cannot accept a gift from a strange man.”

“Of course you can,” he said, looking deeply into her eyes.

She turned away.

A young man with dark wavy hair upon which he wore a blue satin yarmulke came out from the back office. He seemed to have overheard their conversation. When he came walking out, Ludwig could see that he was a tall, slender fellow. The girl looked at him with distress in her eyes. "Lily, is everything all right?" he asked as he walked over to the two of them.

"Yes, David. I'm fine. Really."

"So, your name is Lily. What a beautiful name." Ludwig said, ignoring the man completely.

"And this is David, my fiancé," Lily said, bravely gesturing towards the dark-haired man.

"Ahhh, nice to meet you, David," Ludwig said sarcastically. "I see by that little skull cap you're wearing that you're a Jew."

"Yes," David said. "That's right. Now, can we help you with anything as far as jewelry is concerned today?" David stood tall.

"I was just thinking about buying this pearl necklace for Lily, but it seems that Lily doesn't want it."

Lily looked at David with concern in her eyes.

"No, she doesn't want it." David shook his head.

"It would have been a nice sale for you," Ludwig said, taking a wad of Marks out from his pocket.

"Nevertheless, she doesn't want it," David said, shaking his head again.

"You can't blame a fellow for trying," Ludwig said as he shoved the money back into his pocket. Then he turned and walked out of the store.

Ludwig was annoyed. He had grown up to think of Jews as a group of lesser people, people who should never dare to stand up to a non-Jew. Ludwig was not only a non-Jew, but he was a wealthy, handsome young man. And every girl he'd ever met was more than willing to fall into his bed. *Those lousy Jews had the nerve to talk to me like I was a nobody. They both think that they are better than me. Well, I'll make it a point to find some young men and pay them to teach that Jew boy a lesson he won't forget. And I'll bet that after he suffers a beating from a bunch of thugs, Lily will see how weak he is, and she'll lose interest in him. That will open the door for me the next time I go there.*

CHAPTER 24

It was unusually hot outside for autumn, so Ludwig removed his jacket and slung it over his shoulder as he walked down the street. When he walked into his home, just as he suspected, his father was waiting for him. “Where were you all night?” His father asked in a quiet, but threatening voice, as Ludwig shut the front door behind him.

“I am a man, Father. I don’t have to answer to you every time I leave this house.”

“You need some form of discipline before you get into some trouble that I can’t get you out of,” Herr Lang shook his head. “The truth is, Ludwig, you should be working. I feel that you should come to the factory with me for a while so you can learn how it operates.”

“I know, father. I know that you want me to follow in the family business, but I don’t have any interest in the factory,” Ludwig said. “I would just make a mess of things there. It’s best that the place operates without me.”

“Well, I think you should come and learn the business. I can’t make you do it. But, if you aren’t going to come to work, at least you ought to be thinking about getting married and starting a family. So far you have caused me nothing but trouble. I’ve had to bail you out of gambling debts. I’ve been forced to pay women of ill repute to keep silent about their illicit affairs with you so that your associations with them would not soil our family name. And I know I’ve told you this before, but I am afraid that if people find out what kind of man you are, no decent family will allow you to marry their daughter.”

"I'm not worried about finding a wife. After all, we are rich. There have always been and will always be women who are willing to marry a man who is wealthy, regardless of his reputation."

"That very well might be true. But those women are not good women."

"You don't have anyone to keep silent. I don't care about my reputation. It doesn't matter to me."

"But I do. It matters a great deal to me. I want to avoid a scandal, son. We don't want people speaking badly about the Lang name. It's important that we remain held in the highest esteem among our neighbors. Besides, you are not a child, you should realize that at your age it is important to spend your time with women of quality. These whores you are playing around with are aware that you're from money, and so they take advantage of you, Ludwig. But for some reason you can't seem to see that. There have been times when I was afraid you might be daft," he sighed. "And I must admit, I am getting tired of your antics. You are twenty-five years old. It's time you realized that you are not a teenage boy anymore. I suppose it's my fault to some extent. I've indulged you far too long. What will happen to you, Ludwig, if you do get into some trouble that I can't get you out of? I should see if I can find a proper wife for you."

This was not the first time his father had said this to him, and Ludwig was tired of listening. *My parents are miserable in their lives, and my father wants me to be unhappy in mine too. Well, I refuse to marry and settle down with some girl who I have no desire to spend the rest of my life with.* "I know father. I know what you want of me. And I promise you father; I will start looking for the right girl," he said, hoping his words might assuage his father's anger. "But let me look for someone. I would rather that I find her for myself than you find her for me."

"You've been promising me that you would find a wife for a long time now. I've told you why this is so important to me, Ludwig. Our family is wealthy. Once I die, everything we have will belong to you, and you will not live forever either. You are going to need to have a son of your own to carry on our family name and our family fortune."

"Yes, I know. You've told me a thousand times. And I will do as you ask. I'll have a son. The Lang name will be carried on. It means a lot to me too that our name doesn't die with me. But first, I must find the right girl for myself."

“Have you ever even given a nice girl a chance? You get involved with these women who are either prostitutes or young girls who have bad reputations.”

“I don’t meet any other types,” he lied. “But I promise you, I will make an effort to find women with good family backgrounds.”

His father shook his head. “I wish I could believe you.” He said, “Now, go and get yourself cleaned up. Have one of the maids, Ella or Nora, run a bath for you. You smell atrocious.”

“Yes, sir.” Ludwig said, without much enthusiasm. He hated spending time talking to his father and was glad to get away from the old man’s critical gaze. *I’ll ask Nora to warm my bath water by the fire. She can wash my back, and it would be nice to have her warm body in my bed once I’ve finished.* Ludwig had been sleeping with Nora on and off for several months since she’d been hired by his father. He knew that she was developing feelings for him, but he had none for her. And although he knew that each time he took her to his bed it came across as a promise of more to her, he didn’t care if he was leading her on. Ludwig couldn’t see beyond his momentary desires. He had no conception of consequences.

Nora had been more than eager to run his bath. “Get undressed, I’ll make sure the water is the perfect temperature for you,” she said, smiling.

“Good. I’ll be there in a few minutes.”

As the warm water caressed his body, Ludwig contemplated his father’s words. The last thing he wanted was a wife and child to tie him down. He loved going out every evening and sleeping with different women. He enjoyed traveling with Max and gambling until the wee hours of the morning. If only things could remain this way forever. He breathed a sigh as Nora walked into the room with a towel and a bar of soap to wash and massage his back. “Lean forward just a bit so I can reach your lower back,” she said, placing her hand gently on his shoulder.

He nodded but didn’t speak. His mind was on his father’s words. There was no doubt that his father was right. It was imperative that he have a son. And his son must be a child born by a worthy woman. She needn’t be rich. But she must be respectable and from a good, solid family. This, he’d been told since he was a child, was something he owed to his family name. And he was sure that once he had produced a male heir to their fortune, his father would leave him alone. The old man would put all his focus on the infant, and that would mean he would be less inclined to try to stop

Ludwig's philandering. All Ludwig had to do was supply his father with a grandson, and then he would be free to live his life the way he wanted to: gambling, drinking, and womanizing.

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CHAPTER 25

After he finished his bath, Ludwig took Nora to his bed. Once he'd finished with her, he sent her away and took a long nap. Waking refreshed, Ludwig felt much better. In fact, he was hungry. He walked down to the kitchen and asked Ella, the cook, to prepare a late lunch for him. She nodded and told him she would take care of it right away. He ate half of a roasted chicken with relish and green salad, and once he'd finished, he slowly got dressed and then he left the house.

It was a long walk to the park where Ludwig knew that the thugs would be standing around smoking and drinking. He didn't mind the walk. It was nice to be outside, and it gave him time to think about what he was about to do.

I know these thugs would do anything to earn a few Marks. I've seen these men but never spoken with them before. The bartender at the tavern warned me to stay away from them. I remember him telling me, "Those boys are a treacherous lot. Loan Sharks. Stay away from them. They'd kill you in an instant without a second thought." And there were plenty of rumors that they had killed people who borrowed money and failed to pay it back. These are just the sort of boys that I need to take care of this problem. I'm sure they would be more than happy to take my money just to beat up on a Jew. And that will teach that diamond dealer that he had better show me respect next time.

As expected, there was a group of young men standing around when he entered the park. Ludwig walked up to them brazenly. "I need to pay you for an important service," he said.

“You a pervert?” one of the men winked as he asked Ludwig the question.

“No, it’s nothing like that,” Ludwig said. “I need to have someone taught a lesson. In other words, I need someone beaten up.”

“Sure. We can do that for you.” A young man said, and they all laughed.

Ludwig told him the name of the Jeweler was David. He described him and then gave the address of the Jewelry store.

“What time do they open and close?” The young man took a drag of a cigarette and then threw the rest on the ground and stepped on it.

“I don’t know. You will have to find that out yourself. That’s what I am paying you for,” Ludwig said curtly.

“How bad do you want him hurt?”

“I don’t want you to kill him,” Ludwig said. “I just want you to teach him a lesson. He is very arrogant for a Jew. And I want him to know that this lesson comes from me Ludwig Lang. You tell him that. All right?”

“Yeah, sure. But this is gonna cost you.”

“I expected as much,” Ludwig pulled a wad of Marks out of his pocket. He noticed that the young man’s clothes were expensive, but when the young thug went to light another cigarette, his hands were dirty.

“Nobody likes Jews. The police won’t care about a Jew getting thrashed. They aren’t going to pay much attention to it,” the thug said as he took a pile of bills from Ludwig’s hand. “So, I sure don’t mind taking care of this matter for you. Consider it done.”

Ludwig nodded. Then he turned and with his head held high, he began to walk home. He felt justified. The Jewish jeweler had offended him. *That lousy Jew should have known better. He should have known his place.*

CHAPTER 26

David, Lily, and her father were walking through the bustling streets of Berlin, back to the Jewish sector of town after they had closed the jewelry store for the day. It had been a long week, and it was finally Friday afternoon. This was a special day for them, and they were looking forward to the Sabbath that would start at sundown this evening and last all day Saturday until the following sundown. Lily knew her mother had spent the day braiding challah bread and making cholent, a Jewish stew, for their Shabbat dinner, and she could feel her mouth begin to salivate at the idea of her mother's wonderful cooking. The Sabbath was Lily's favorite time. All week she looked forward to Friday night; being surrounded by family made her feel a special kind of comfort, and she dreamed of the days when she and David would have a family of their own. As she noticed the golden hour of the sun slowly beginning, she thought to herself, *soon it will be my turn to be a wife and mother, and I will spend all day on Fridays preparing the Sabbath meal for our family.* A smile came over her face as she thought of Saturday. This upcoming day of rest was her favorite day of the week. Her family spent the entire Sabbath each week with David and his family. This had become a ritual since the couple got engaged. They shared Sabbath dinner and then went to the synagogue together. There was no work on Saturday. It was spent sharing time with loved ones, praying, talking, singing, and playing games. It was a wonderful day, Hashem's beautiful day of rest, and both families looked forward to it.

As the three of them walked past an alleyway between two apartment buildings, a young man came out of the alley and approached David. "You got a light?" He asked. An unlit cigarette hung out his mouth.

“No, I don’t smoke. I’m sorry,” David said, and the three of them, sensing danger, began to walk away quickly.

Lily walked beside David, but she took a glance back at the man. He was eyeing David with malice, and she felt a pang of fear run through her. This man didn’t belong here. She could tell by looking at him. He wasn’t dressed as the men from their Jewish neighborhood dress; he was not wearing a white shirt and long black coat. And on his head was a modern fedora, not the black hat or skull cap that the Jewish men wore, and Lily noticed that there was no fringe from tefillin hung from his waist. Lily shuddered. This man, with his fancy modern suit and cigarettes surely wasn’t one of the men who lived in the Jewish neighborhood. *What is he doing here?* She thought. But before she had a chance to consider her question, three more men who were dressed like the first one came rushing out of the alley. The three men attacked David. It all happened so quickly that all Lily could do was scream. Her father rushed to David’s aid. But he was not a young man, and he was certainly no match for four young, strong men. They pushed him out of the way. He fell to the ground and hit his head. Still, he tried to get up, but his ankle was twisted. Lily ran at the men and began pounding her fists on the one who stood over David with all her strength.

“Feisty little thing, aren’t you?” one of them said to Lily as he pushed her away. She fell against the building. Pain shot through her shoulder, but she got up and ran towards them again.

“This is a little gift for you from Ludwig Lang. I’m sure you know who that is,” he said to David as he kicked him hard in the chest.

Lily began pounding the hooligan again and screaming, “Leave him alone. Please just leave him alone.”

“Go Lily. Get out of here. Leave now before they hurt you. Go and get the police,” David said, his voice cracking with pain. “Hurry.”

“Police?” one of the attackers laughed. “You’re Jews. They don’t care what happens to you. Go and get them and you’ll see what they’ll do. They’ll probably help us beat the hell out of you.”

Another of the attackers said, laughing, “You Jews sure are stupid. We have an...well, you might call it...an arrangement with the police. They never arrest us. And in turn for their looking the other way, we make sure that their children have a chicken in the pot at least once a week. If you know what I mean.” He shook his head. “You seem like a real idiot. You

should never have disrespected a rich fellow like Ludwig. Men like him are used to getting what they want. And, let's face it, you're a nobody, and Jew too. You have no right to say no to a wealthy man like that."

Lily didn't answer. She was still pounding on the man who was still ignoring her for the moment. He was standing over David, completely unfazed by her fists.

He turned to her like she were a fly that needed swatting and punched her in the jaw. She dropped to the ground.

"Lily. Don't fight them. They'll hurt you. Go home. Go home and get help. Go to the houses of the other men on our street. Tell them what is happening. They will come back here with you. Just get away from here before you get hurt," David cried.

She tried to scramble to her feet, but she was feeling dizzy and fell back.

"In case you don't remember him, Ludwig Lang is that handsome rich German fellow who tried to be so kind as to buy you a necklace, pearls no less. He told me all about it. And you being an ungrateful Jew. You insulted him. You and your lousy Jew boyfriend." One of the men said as she finally got up and ran towards him. He caught her before she could strike him and flung her across the pavement like a rag doll. This time she fell to the ground on her knees. The men ignored her as they continued to kick and punch David. He fought back as best he could. Lily realized David was right; she needed help. Her father was unable to move, and she wasn't strong enough to fight them. Besides, she was afraid that if she stayed, one or all of them might decide to rape her. Scrambling to her feet, she began to run. She ran all the way to the street where she and David both lived. When she got there, she pounded on the door of her neighbor's home. They had two sons, Eli and Michael.

"What is it, Lily?" The mother of the family asked as she opened the door. Then she saw Lily's bleeding face, and the old woman put her hand to her heart, "Oy, vey. What happened to you? Kum areyn, come in" she said in Yiddish. "Sets, sit down."

Lily couldn't sit. She was shaking all over. "Are Michael and Eli at home? I need their help, quick."

"Why? tell me what is going on."

Just then Michael must have heard his name, and so he entered the kitchen. He was a large man with curly brown hair and warm brown eyes.

“Lily? Where’s David? What’s going on? Why are you bleeding?”

Lily tried to tell him as much as she could, as quickly as she was able to get the words out.

“I’ll be right back. I am going to my room to get Eli. We’ll come and help you.”

“Oy, no. Please, don’t get involved. This is not good. You boys will get hurt,” Michael and Eli’s mother said.

“We have to help David,” Michael said. “I am sorry Mother. But don’t worry. We’ll be all right.” He ran to the back of the house where the bedrooms were. When he returned, Eli was with him.

“Take us to the place where your papa and David are,” Eli said in a hurry.

Lily led them back to the place where she’d left her father and her betrothed. When they arrived, both David and her father were on the ground. The attackers were gone. Her father was conscious but in a lot of pain. But David was not conscious at all.

“I’ll get the doctor,” Lily said, and she took off running.

CHAPTER 27

Eli and Michael helped Herr Feingold to his feet. “Can you stand on your own?” they asked him softly.

Lily’s father nodded. “I’m all right. But I think David is hurt badly.”

Eli walked over to David and in a gentle voice he said, “David, can you hear me?”

There was no answer. Michael approached and knelt beside David. He glanced at Eli. Then he felt for a pulse. “He’s still alive,” he said, nodding at his brother.

“Thank God. Don’t move him. Let’s wait for the doctor.”

A short time later, the local doctor arrived with Lily at his side. He examined David. Then he said, “He has a head injury. I must get him to the hospital.”

“How bad is it?” Lily asked, tears flowing down her face, as she wrung her hands together.

“I won’t know until I can examine him further. Can you two boys help me carry him?”

“Of course,” Michael said.

Lily and her father walked behind the rest of them as they carried David to the hospital. Once they arrived, Lily’s father said, “I have to go home so I can tell your mother what is happening. She will be worried. It’s almost sundown on the Sabbath and we aren’t home. She’ll know something is wrong.”

“Yes, of course. You must go. I’ll stay with David,” Lily said.

“We will go with you, and make sure you get home safely.” Eli said, and Michael nodded.

“Lily, I will be okay, and I will return with your mother later tonight,” Her father said, as he rested an arm on each of the boys.

“All right, Papa.” Lily said, tears still running down her face.

As Lily sat in the sterile white waiting room, her mind drifted to David and all they had shared together over the years. They had been neighbors all her life. And then they’d been betrothed when David turned thirteen years old, right after his bar mitzvah. So, she knew from the time she was very young that someday she and David would marry. And although sometimes her friend’s arranged marriages had turned out to be unpleasant, her relationship with David was not like that. They had seen each other in the neighborhood and at the synagogue when they were children, but because it wasn’t customary for boys and girls to speak to each other, they had only glanced at each other from afar. She remembered how afraid she had been when she was only twelve, and her father told her that a young boy, who was a prospective marital match for her, along with his parents, would come to dinner. “His name is David Mendelshon. I know you have seen him in the neighborhood. He’s a nice-looking boy and he comes from a very good family. I’ve spoken with his father, and we agree that the two of you should meet.”

Lily had looked at her father skeptically, trying to hide the fear in her eyes. “I’m still young, Papa. I’m not ready to think about getting married.”

“Of course not. You’re far too young. So is he. But we think you might want to consider being betrothed for a few years.”

She shook her head. “I don’t know Papa. I have seen him. And you’re right he is nice looking, but I don’t really know anything about him. What if we don’t get along? What if we have nothing in common? What if he’s mean?” Lily said nervously.

“Nishtgedeiget, don’t worry,” her father said, gently patting her on the head. He observed the Jewish law that although he would choose the boys who he felt were worthy of his daughter’s hand in marriage, in the end Lily could agree or refuse to marry them. Many of Lily’s friends’ fathers did not follow this law as they were supposed to. They were far stricter, and when they chose a match for their daughters, their decision was final. “I am not asking you to agree to anything. Just meet him. Meet his family too. They would be your machatunim, your in-laws. It’s important that you get along

with them as well. You don't have to make any promises tonight, Lilaley, just meet him." He called her Lilaley, his pet name for her.

When he used her pet name, Lily felt a surge of warmth towards her father. She looked into his gentle gaze, and a smile crept over her face. He would never force her to do anything that she didn't want to do. So, why not meet this boy by the name of David Mendelshon. Why not see what she thought of him? "All right, Papa. I'll meet him," she smiled, then she went into her bedroom to get dressed.

Her mother followed her. "Can I help you select a dress for tonight?" she asked, thumbing through Lily's closet. "You should wear something pretty, but very modest."

"Yes, Mama," Lily said. She loved her parents. They had always been kind and nurturing.

"What about this one?" Her mother asked, taking a navy blue dress out of the closet.

Lily nodded. "All right, Mother," she said.

"Good. Now, let me make you a warm bath."

As Lily lay in the warm, scented water, she thought about how much she hoped she would like this boy, because she hated to disappoint her parents. Even so, she knew that they would not want her to become engaged to anyone she did not want to marry. Then a thought crossed her mind: *what if he doesn't like me? What if he thinks I am ugly? I am certainly far from beautiful. I'm too tall, and my legs are so long. I don't know if he is taller than me. I never noticed. Oh, how I wish I were more petite. And my hair is so curly that it's unruly. Of course, that won't matter if we do get married because my mother will shave my hair and I will wear a sheitel after we are wed. But until then, I hate my hair. It always looks like a giant lion's mane. It is so hard to keep it under control.*

Lily stayed in the bath until the water turned cold. She finally got out and walked into her bedroom where her mother had laid out the dress they had selected. She only wore the navy-blue satin frock with its starched white collar on high holidays. Quickly Lily put on her stockings and undergarments. Then she slipped the dress over her head. Next, Lily looked in the mirror. Her hair was a mass of curls. She groaned and then pulled her hair back on both sides with silver barrettes that her father had given her on her birthday. Now, at least, the explosion of onyx curls was not dwarfing

her face. She glanced in the mirror and smiled. *I don't look too bad.* She assured herself.

When David and his parents arrived at the house, Lily was still upstairs in her room. However, she had pulled back the drape just an inch and had been peeking through the window in her room when they came up the front walk. Lily assessed him. He was tall, taller than she was. She was relieved to see that, she had been afraid that he would be shorter than her. And not only was he taller, but now that she was really looking at him, she could see that he was rather handsome as well. Because they went to the same synagogue and lived in the same neighborhood, she knew that she and David were the same age and that he had just had his bar mitzvah. Her mother also said that he was very smart and that the Rabbi liked him very much. But this was all she knew about him. And she decided it wasn't much.

"Come, Lily. The guests are here," her mother said gently as she opened the door to Lily's room.

She couldn't procrastinate any longer. So she nodded. Then she began walking down the stairs. When their eyes met for the first time in a shy glance, everything changed. She knew that everything was going to be all right, and that David Mendelshon was her bashert, her destiny. Lily was no longer afraid. Her papa had chosen well. David was the man she would marry.

David and Lily sat across from each other at the table, each stealing side glances at the other until finally their eyes met for a second time, and David's face exploded into the most attractive, reassuring and heartwarming smile she'd ever seen. After dinner they sat across from each other in her parent's living room. At first it was difficult for her to speak. After all, she'd never spoken to a boy before, and she could tell it was just as hard for him. But he forced himself to speak, and once he got over his initial shyness, David was outgoing. Before long, they were chatting and laughing. And it was then that Lily's heart smiled. She felt sure that everything was going to be wonderful in her future. He was happy to listen to her opinions on biblical lessons, and from what she knew, most boys didn't discuss religious teachings with girls. And she found that even though their meeting was chaperoned, they were able to talk openly with each other. He had a brilliant and inquisitive mind that she found fascinating. David challenged her with stimulating questions that sometimes kept her up at night. She found herself

looking forward to their meetings. And from that day on, the families shared Shabbat dinners together, alternating between his home and hers. On nice days they took walks to the park, chaperoned of course, and although they were not permitted to touch, occasionally their hands brushed. When this happened, Lily tingled all over. She could hardly wait to marry her bashert and for her life with him to begin.

Over the next three years, Lily and David became close. They began to work together at her father's jewelry store, and it seemed to Lily that the more she got to know David, the better she liked him.

Finally, the time arrived to plan the wedding. They were both excited, and so were the families. Because the families were both so amicable, there were no arguments during the planning. Once it was all arranged, Lily could hardly sleep or eat; she was far too excited. Even her visit with the Kallah teacher, a specially trained woman who young Jewish brides were expected to take classes from, that prepared them for their wedding night, was not as frightening to her as it was to many young brides. The Kallah teacher explained what was expected of her on her wedding night. But Lily knew David; she'd seen how kind and gentle he was, and she was not afraid to lie with him.

She had envisioned it in her mind's eye so many times that it already felt like a reality. Lily was determined to be a good wife to David, and to make sure he had everything he needed. She knew how to make a kosher home. And her parents had been good examples, so she thought she would be a good mother. There was no doubt in her mind that David was going to be a warm and kind husband. And when she thought of the little house that her father had pledged to buy for them, she knew it would be filled with the laughter of children.

Lily was only one month away from her wedding, and the future of her dreams, on that fateful day when Ludwig came into her life. And today, because of that horrible man, her entire future hung in the balance. As she sat feeling small and alone in the hospital waiting room, wondering if David was alive or dead, her stomach ached. Lily bent over to endure the pain, and as she did, she couldn't help but whisper to God, "Why Hashem? Why?" Tears fell freely down her cheeks.

CHAPTER 28

For two endless hours she sat waiting for a word from the doctor. But no one came to speak to her. Then her and David's parents arrived together. David's mother's eyes were swollen and red from crying. Lily's mother ran over to her side and put her arms around her. But no one else spoke. They sunk down into the chairs and avoided looking at each other. Lily's father was limping from the beating, but he didn't complain. He sat silently.

"Oh, mayn kind, my child," her mother whispered, "I'm so sorry this happened." Lily could not answer. She felt like she was unable to speak. But she laid her head on her mother's chest and wept.

The two families sat in silence in the empty waiting room, watching, waiting, hoping for some sign that everything was going to be all right. It was almost midnight before a doctor came to speak to them.

Lily had known Doctor Eisenburg all her life. He lived in a modest home right down the street from her and David. He sometimes walked to the synagogue with her father on Saturday mornings. There had been times when someone in the family was ill, and Dr. Eisenburg had come to their home carrying his black leather bag. He brought medicine, promises of good health, and smiles. Lily also knew his daughter, Miriam, very well. They went to the same Jewish school for girls and had been friends since they were little. Lily had recently attended Miriam's wedding. She thought of how much happier they all were then. And so, now as she studied the deeply lined but familiar face of Doctor Eisenburg, Lily could tell that whatever the doctor was about to say, it was not good. She braced herself. Even so, she couldn't stop trembling. The old doctor shook his head, and

Lily felt the room go black. Her mother grabbed her so she didn't fall down. Lily was sure that David was dead. Everyone stood up. David's parents looked as if they'd aged twenty years as they waited for the doctor to speak.

"He is alive." Dr. Eisenburg said as he cleared his throat. He looked worn out as he pushed a shock of white hair back from his eyes. "Thanks be to Hashem."

David's mother let out a long sigh as she fell back into her chair.

"But I am afraid that the news is not all good," the doctor said, and Lily could see that the old man was struggling to get the words out. "David's spine was badly injured. He also took a terrible blow to the head. So, I'm afraid he will not be able to walk, and his brain function will be limited from now on."

"No," Lily cried out; she was weeping. Her body was trembling as she shook her head violently. "No, that's not possible. He will be all right. As long as he's still alive, he will be all right." She was crying hysterically. Her mother put her arm around Lily's shoulder. "You see Doctor, he must get well soon, because we are getting married next month. Remember? You are coming to our wedding. Miriam and her husband are coming too. This is just not possible." Lily was shaking her head.

"I'm sorry," Dr. Eisenburg said.

"When can we see him?" David's father asked.

"You can go into his room now. He is awake. The room is right down the hall, it's room seven," the doctor said, motioning his hand towards the hallway. Then, with his head hanging down, he walked out of the room.

"I want to see him." Lily said. "I need to see him."

"Maybe it's best you wait until tomorrow. Come, you'll go home and get some rest," her father said, putting his arm around her shoulder.

"No, Papa, no. Please. I will never be able to rest. I must go to him now. He needs me. I know that once he sees me, he'll be all right."

A frightened glance passed between her parents. But her father nodded and said, "It's all right with me. Is it all right with the two of you?" Her father asked David's parents.

They both nodded in agreement.

"I will go with you, Lily," her mother said.

Lily didn't answer, but her mother took her hand. And Lily, pale and stone faced, squeezed her mother's hand as they walked down the long white corridor together. Room seven was right across from the nurse's

station. Lily hesitated for a single moment. She sucked in a long breath, then entered the room. She gasped, unable to control the shock she felt at seeing David lying in the hospital bed. A bandage stained with dried blood circled his head. When David saw Lily, he smiled. "David..." she whispered his name.

"Lily..." he said, "I don't feel so good."

She let out a relieved laugh. *He's all right. He's just hurt. He'll be fine.* "I'm quite sure that you don't feel well at all. You went through a horrible ordeal."

"Ordeal? What's that?" he asked.

"You went through something very bad, David. Don't you remember?"

"No," he said.

And it was then that she saw that his eyes were blank. "You don't remember the beating?"

"I was beaten up?"

"Oh David," she said, and she wished that just this once she might break the rules of no touching before marriage and take his hand. He lay there looking so lost. "It's all right. There's no need to think about that now. Right now, you just have to get better."

"I hope I can. I hurt all over."

"Yes, I know. I know," she said.

"I hope I'll be all right by our wedding," he said.

He knows who I am. He remembers that we are having a wedding in a month. But how can we get married now? I don't know how we will survive as a couple. My father was counting on David's help in the store. And I was going to stay home and have children. He can't work in the store if his mind is weak and he can't walk.

Just then David's parents entered the room. "Oy, gut, Oh God," David's mother said. "What kind of a monster did this to my boy?"

"My head hurts," David said, rubbing his eyes. He hardly seemed to be aware of his parents. Then his voice changed slightly, and he sounded angry; his eyes darted around the room. "Who are you?" he asked. "What are you doing here? Where is my family?"

"We are your family," his father said gently and walked over to place his hand on David's.

"I want to go to sleep now. Why don't all of you go away."

The family all looked around at each other and silently made the agreement that it was time to leave. Lily's mother put her arm around her daughter and guided her out of the room. As they walked down the hall, Lily heard David's mother say, "He has no idea what is going on. First he knows us, then he doesn't. Got in himmel, God in Heaven, I am afraid for him."

"The doctor told us that his brain is damaged," David's father said, holding his wife's arm.

"But I didn't want to believe it, Hymie," David's mother cried, "he's so young and his whole life is in front of him. Gotteniu, oh God."

"I know, Mya."

"We can't expect Lily to marry him now, like this. How could we expect such a thing from her?"

"Let's give it time," David's father said, trying to calm her down. "Maybe he'll get better with time."

"Oy Hymie. How could this happen?"

Lily didn't hear anything more. Bile rose in her throat and she turned and ran to the bathroom down the hall barely making it there in time to vomit into the sink. Her mother followed her and ran over to hold back her hair, "Lily, what can I do for you?"

"Please Mama. Let me be alone. I need some time to myself."

CHAPTER 29

Each day, when she finished working at the Jewelry store, Lily went to the hospital to visit David. At first, she had hoped that with time his mind would return. But by the end of the week, she knew he would never be the same. His brilliant mind, which had been filled with ideas, was gone. And now he was like a willful and angry child.

After David spent two weeks in the hospital and there was nothing more that could be done for him, he was set to be released at the end of the week. The wedding date was growing nearer each day. And so far, everyone had avoided mentioning it. Finally, on the day before David was to return home, his parents appeared at Lily's front door.

"Come in Frau Mendelshon, Herr Mendelshon," Lily's mother said.

"We've come to speak to Lily," David's father said.

"Of course. Please won't you both sit down? I'll go and get her for you."

David's parents sat down on the living room sofa.

"Can I get you something? Some tea? Coffee perhaps? A piece of strudel?"

"No, thank you. We just need to speak with Lily," Hymie Mendelshon said seriously.

Lily's mother knocked softly on the door of Lily's room.

Lily opened the door. "David's parents are here to see you," her mother said.

Lily had been expecting this for a while. With everything that had happened, the future had to be reassessed. She had spent many sleepless nights considering the possibilities. It had taken some courage, but she had

made a decision. And now she was ready to speak to both her own parents and to David's about what she'd decided.

"Good afternoon, Herr Mendelshon, Frau Mendelshon," Lily said politely as she entered the living room. She immediately noticed that Frau Mendelshon's eyes were still red and her face was still swollen from crying.

"Lily," David's father said, his voice choked up. "Frau Mendelshon and I want you to know that we have always felt very honored to have you as our prospective daughter-in-law. We couldn't have asked for a better daughter, or a better wife for our only son, our only child," Herr Mendelshon said, then he cleared his throat. "But in light of what has happened, we feel it is our responsibility to free you from your commitment to marry our son. As much as we would love to have you in our family, we could not, in good conscience, expect you to go forward with your marriage to David. You're a good girl. A fine frum, religious girl, with a good family. You deserve a good husband. And I am more than sorry to have to say that my son cannot be that husband to you anymore."

Lily shuddered at hearing these words spoken out loud. She wished her father was at home, but he was still at work. He had to set some diamonds for a customer, so he stayed late. Lily glanced at her mother who returned her glance then she shook her head and in a soft and gentle tone her mother said, "I think that David's parents are right and maybe it's best for you to call the wedding off."

Lily nodded. She sucked in a deep breath, then she said, "I appreciate that you're offering to allow me to break this marriage contract. I know that you have my welfare in mind. And I am grateful for your kindness. However, when I accepted David's proposal I did so because I believed that David was my bashert. I still believe it to be true. And I always will. I know in my heart that he is my bashert, and I will not abandon him. I will marry him as planned, and I will take care of him."

"You will never have a normal life, Lilalei. You are such a beautiful girl. How can you do this to your life." Her mother said, using the families pet name for her daughter. "I don't think you will ever have children with him. You will spend all your days caring for a man who doesn't know what is happening around him." She said, then she turned to David's parents and said, "I'm sorry to have to say these things. I don't mean to offend you. But the rest of my daughter's life depends on what she does next."

Herr Mendelsohn nodded as he if he understood.

“It is my decision. And I have decided that I want to go through with the wedding as planned.”

“You are a good girl with a good heart,” Frau Mendelshon said, “I am glad you will be my son’s wife. I will do whatever I can to make your life easier.”

Lily smiled. Then she went to her room, closed the door, and wept.

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CHAPTER 30

The morning before she was to get married, Lily went to the Mikvah, the ritual bath, as was demanded of a bride on the day of her wedding. She carefully observed all the rituals that were expected of her. After cutting her nails, she submerged in the cool clear water, and prayers were spoken. Lily was alone in her bath feeling close to God as she closed her eyes. *Hashem, I don't know why you allowed this to happen, but I know that I am doing the right thing. Ani l'dodi, v'dodi li; I am my beloved's, and my beloved is mine.*

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CHAPTER 31

A wedding should have been a joyous occasion. This one wasn't. The bride's father had already purchased a home for them as a wedding gift. But when he announced it, many of the women had tears in their eyes. The guests were limited to close friends and neighbors, so they knew what had happened to David. Two of David's friends held him up as he stood under the white floral and organza covered chuppah—the canopy. They helped him to bring down his limp leg and break the glass with his foot, as was customary at the end of the ceremony. When the couple went off to their private room for a short time after the ceremony, David didn't speak. He sat quietly, more interested in eating chocolates than in holding Lily's hand. It broke her heart because she'd spent three years waiting for this moment. This was the first time since they'd met that they were permitted to be alone together. And she had always thought that this was going to be the moment of her first kiss. But there was no romantic kiss. Only a mindless smile on the face of the handsome young man she'd married as he stuffed his mouth with chocolates.

After a little while, the newlyweds returned to the reception. The guests were not enjoying themselves the way they should have. A dark umbrella of sadness hung over the party. And no one was surprised to see that the groom couldn't get up out of his chair to dance and that the bride didn't dance either. All night long, until the wedding was finally over, Lily broke the rules and instead of sitting with the women, she sat beside David and brought him food and wine.

After the guests left for the evening, Lily and David were alone. Only their parents remained. Since David couldn't walk, the two fathers carried

the chosson, the groom, to the new house that Lily's parents had given them. It was the night she'd dreamed of for three years, it was their wedding night. It was heartbreaking for Lily as she climbed into bed beside her bashert who seemed to have no idea of what was expected of him. He smiled at her calmly, but it was the smile of an innocent child, not the warm smile of desire that a man on his wedding night gives to his new bride. Lily reached out her hand to him. She knew that if the marriage was to be consummated, it was she who would have to initiate it. She put his hand on her breast. But he pulled away. "It's all right, David," she said, "we are married now."

"I can't. This is not right," he said moving quickly away from her.

"Don't be afraid. We can take our time with this. There is no hurry. You and I are husband and wife now and we have the rest of our lives to do this."

David fell into a peaceful slumber almost instantly. But Lily lay awake. As she watched David sleep, her heart was turning black with hatred for Ludwig Lang. Lily closed her eyes and gritted her teeth, as she thought to herself. *I know that you won't approve of this God, but I will make that Ludwig Lang pay for what he did. I will watch and I will wait until the time is right, but I vow this, I will ruin Ludwig Lang's life the way he has ruined mine.*

CHAPTER 32

The morning following a wedding it was customary for the religious group of which Lily and David were members, to expect Lily's mother to arrive at the home of the newlyweds. She would come to shave Lily's hair. Being a married woman, Lily would no longer show her hair in public. Instead, she would wear a scarf or a wig to cover her head.

There was a knock on the door at half past ten in the morning. Lily opened the door. Her mother stood smiling at her, but Lily could see the deep wrinkles and sadness in her mother's eyes. "I didn't want to come too early, Lilalee," she said.

"Your timing is perfect," Lily said trying to smile. If her wedding night had gone as planned, Lily and her mother would both be laughing and talking as her mother shaved her unruly hair. Because Lily and her mother had always been close, her mother would probably have made some good-natured, but mild sexual innuendos concerning the previous wedding night. She might even have alluded to the fact that Lily was now a married woman, and she now knew the secrets of married life. They would probably both have smiled as they discussed the grandchildren that were to come. But things being the way they were, Lily's mother did not say a word about any of this. And Lily assumed her mother might know the truth. That the marriage had not been consummated.

After they finished with the shaving of Lily's hair, Lily told her mother to sit down at the kitchen table. "You brought a freshly baked challah and a slab of butter for breakfast?" Lily asked as she unwrapped the package her mother had brought.

"Yes, of course."

“I’ll cut some slices and butter them,” Lily said. Then she called out to David, “My mama brought bread and butter for breakfast. I’ll bring you a couple of slices in a minute.”

“All right,” he shouted back from the bedroom.

She wished he could walk and sit down at the table with them. But instead, he was lying in bed and waiting for his food. When she brought two thick pieces of challah to David, he forgot to thank her, this was something he would never have done in the past when she brought him something. But now he was changed. This time he gobbled up his food like a hungry child. Lily sat on the bed beside him while he ate. She didn’t speak. She couldn’t speak. She was afraid if she did, she would start to cry. After he finished Lily saw that there was butter on his chin. Gently she wiped it away with a kitchen towel. David smiled, and when he did, he looked like a young boy. Lily’s mother, who had walked into the bedroom saw this and turned away. Then she said, “I have to get home, your papa will be waiting for me.”

“Yes, of course,” Lily said, and she saw that her mother had been crying.

Because of David’s injuries, everything had changed. The young couple and their families had to make new plans for the future. Two nights later, both Lily and David’s parents came to the home of the newlyweds for dinner. Lily had prepared a simple chicken soup with matzo balls and a vinegar and raisin strudel for dessert. David was excited to have visitors, and he was very animated. Lily watched him, ashamed to admit, even to herself, that she felt sick when she looked at him. He was only a shadow of the man he’d been, and it hurt her to see him this way.

“Nu,” her father-in-law said after dinner was finished, “David was planning to help you in the jewelry store. Now, of course, that’s impossible. And I would help you if I could, but I don’t have any spare time. I have my own business to run.”

“I could continue to help you Papa,” Lily said.

“But David is unable to walk. And his mind isn’t right. You can’t leave him alone in the house. He could get hurt,” Lily’s father said, “Don’t worry about me. I’ll manage on my own at the store.”

“No, that’s too much to ask. Besides a young woman can’t stay in the house all the time carrying for her husband. She will have to go to the market and so she might as well help you in the store too. You will need her.

So, I can come to the house during the day and take care of David,” David’s mother offered.

“We can do this together. How about we share the time? I will come on Tuesday, Thursday and Sunday,” Lily’s mother said.

“Then I will come on Monday, Wednesday, and Friday. And I’ll make Shabbos dinner for all of us on Friday. I think it’s best that we should have dinner here at David and Lily’s home. It would be too hard for us to bring David to my house. And of course, Lily will be at home with David on Saturday so I will make plenty of food so that there will be left over for David and Lily on Saturday.” David’s mother added.

“I think that sounds very good,” Lily’s mother said.

“So, you will come to the store each day?” Lily’s father asked her.

“Yes, Papa. I will.” Lily agreed. When their parents left, David fell asleep quickly. But as Lily lay in bed staring at the ceiling with her teeth clenched. She was angry that her and David’s families had to be inconvenienced like this. *He did this. He ruined our lives.* Night after night these thoughts would consume her mind. *Ludwig Lang ruined our lives.* The words became a mantra in her mind. *I vow to ruin his life the way he has ruined mine.* Lily thought of ways to physically hurt him; she could wring his neck or punch him in the stomach. But she knew she was not strong enough. *I must use my brain. I wonder how I can find out some information about him, so I can use it to hurt him the way he has hurt me?*

CHAPTER 33

With David's condition, there was no point in having a long honeymoon stage. And even though this should have been a special time for the couple to spend bonding and performing Sheva Brachot, a blessing that takes place every day for seven days following the wedding, Lily found she was eager to get out of the house. So, a few days later she went back to work at the jewelry store.

Working all day and then caring for David at night was taxing. He couldn't eat unless she brought him his food. And because he was unable to bathe himself, Lily would wash him down with cool, wet rags while he lay in bed. Once a week, Lily's father or her father-in-law would carry David to a chair where he would wait until clean linens were put on the bed. This was all very difficult for Lily, but the worst part of it was that she felt so lost without her friend. The David she once knew and loved was gone. She had chosen to marry him, but she hadn't realized at the time that he would never come back to the man he was. In fact, he was getting worse. And even though the doctor had warned her that David's brain damage was permanent, she refused to believe him. She had convinced herself that in time he would heal. Lily wished she could find someone to talk to about her feelings. If she told her parents how miserable she was, they would listen. They would share her pain, but Lily didn't want to put them through that. And she felt she could not talk about it with her in-laws, they were having a difficult enough time watching their once brilliant son slip away from them more each day. She considered going to speak to the Rebbetzin, the rabbi's wife. But she already knew what the woman would say. It was Lily's

obligation to take care of her husband no matter how difficult the task, and so each day, Lily did the best she could.

Some nights her mother or mother-in-law would prepare a simple dinner that Lily would serve her husband when she arrived home from the jewelry store. One night her mother made a stew with turnips in it. So, after her mother left for the day, she brought David a bowl of the hot, steaming stew. Lily forgot to tell him to wait for his food to cool off. Sometimes she was just too overwhelmed to remember that he needed extra care. So when he put the spoonful of stew in his mouth, it burned his tongue. Like a child, he spat the stew onto the bed where he lay. Then he threw the bowl against the wall. "I hate turnips!" he said in an angry, childlike voice. "And this terrible food burned me."

Lily glanced over at the mess. It had been a long day at work. She and her father faced several problems with customers, and now that she was finally home, Lily was exhausted and hungry. Her endurance was wearing thin, "Why did you do that, David?" She yelled at him. "Taking care of you is more than enough work without you adding extra."

His face fell. Her words had stung him, and she could see in his sad eyes that he was hurt. As soon as the words had left her lips, she was sorry she'd said them. But she was young and so miserable in her marriage. Lily began to cry. She couldn't be strong all the time, and yet the last thing she wanted to do was hurt David. And although she felt terrible about the way she'd behaved, this would not be the last time she would lose patience with her husband.

He was like a child. At night, after a full day's work, when she was finally done caring for David and longing to lay down in her bed and go to sleep, he begged her to read to him. She did this as often as she could bear it. And when she didn't, because she was just too tired, she was overcome with guilt.

Then on a sunny morning Lily climbed out of bed and went to wash herself and get ready to go to work. She had gotten up late and only had a half hour to prepare David's breakfast and be on her way to meet her father outside the house where he waited for her each morning. Lily put on a simple, modest dress. As she cut a thick slice of cheese into two halves, one for herself the other for David there was a knock on the door. She ran to open it. Her mother stood waiting outside.

“Come in Mama.” Lily said, hurrying her mother into the house. “I’m running behind. I got up late. Before I leave, I have to give David his breakfast.”

“Don’t worry about David, I’ll bring him his breakfast. Your father is outside waiting for you,” her mother said.

“Thank you, Mama.” Lily said as she took a hunk of cheese and put it in the pocket of her dress. Then she ran outside and joined her father. They began to walk to work together in silence, both too tired to carry on a conversation. But as they were about to turn the corner, Lily’s mother came running up behind them. The old woman was out of breath, and her face was red from running.

“Mama? What is it?” Lily asked, startled to see her mother.

She grabbed her daughter’s arm to steady herself. “It’s David. I brought him his breakfast, but he didn’t open his eyes. I shook him, but he doesn’t move. Oy Vey. What are we going to do? I don’t think he’s breathing.”

“Go and get Dr. Eisenberg,” Lily’s father told his wife.

She nodded.

Lily glanced over at her father with fear in her eyes.

“We must go back to the house,” her father said, seeing that his daughter needed guidance.

CHAPTER 34

Dr Eisenberg and Lily's mother arrived back at the house quickly, and the doctor went in to examine David. When he came out of the bedroom his gray hair was disheveled and his face was as white as parchment paper. "I'm so sorry, but David is dead."

"What happened?" Lily's father asked.

The doctor said that David had died in his sleep.

After a long moment of silence, Lily's father softly said, "I'll go to tell his parents." Then he put on his hat and left the house.

David's parents arrived back at the house with Lily's father. They were heartbroken. Lily would have been distraught too, had she not realized that David was already gone. She had lost him during that terrible attack. The man who died in her bed that day was not her David. It was only his shadow.

The funeral was scheduled for the following morning as it was Jewish law that a body must be buried within twenty-four hours of death.

Two women who were friends of Lily's mother from the sisterhood at the synagogue came to help to set up the shiva, a seven-day mourning period where friends and family could come and pay their respects to the family of the dead at Lily and David's home. All the mirrors in the house were covered, and food was prepared for the family of the deceased. Lily and her in-laws wore dark stockings and no shoes. They sat on wooden boxes. And David's mother wept softly as ten men, along with the rabbi with whom David had once studied the Torah, stood up and said the Kadish, the prayer for the dead.

"He was so young," David's mother said, softly sobbing to Lily.

She nodded. "Yes, he was far too young." But, deep down her feelings were mixed. It tore her up inside to know that David's young life had been taken for no reason, and she still believed in her heart that David had been her bashert. She missed him, she missed the man he used to be, not the childlike man who had died the day before. And although Lily was ashamed to admit it, she held a very hidden secret, there was an unspoken part of her that was relieved to be free of her obligation. She was relieved that now she could work with her father without coming home and enduring the draining task of caring for her husband at night. And as Lily sat on the uncomfortable wooden box, greeting guests who have come to pay their respects, her heart burned with bitter hatred for Ludwig Lang, and she vowed that she was far from done with him.

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CHAPTER 35

Several weeks had passed, and Ludwig forgot about his interest in Lily. He had put his mind at ease when he paid off the thugs to beat up her fiancé. And she would know she had made a mistake by treating him like he was just some fellow who was interested in her. He had proven to her that he was a wealthy and powerful man and that he did not take kindly to being treated as if he were less. However, all of that was in the past now because Ludwig had other problems. Ludwig was always finding himself in trouble. In a drunken state one night, he'd wanted to make an impression on a group of other gamblers. They had tricked him, and he had lost a lot of money in a poker game. Even as he was losing more and more, they made him feel certain that he could win back what he lost. But before he knew it, all the money he had was gone. He was angry and certain that if he could just get his hands on some more money, he could even the score. That night he went home and asked his father for money.

"I can win it back, all of it Father," Ludwig told his father.

His father shook his head and refused to give him anything. "This is why I set up the trust, Ludwig. So that you would only be allotted a certain amount each month. I know about your gambling problem. And I will not give you any additional access."

"You have plenty of money. I can't believe you won't help me," Ludwig demanded. "My allowance from the trust is hardly enough for a grown man. You expect me to live like a pauper."

"You lost your money in a poker game. How can you expect me to give you more? I would have to be an idiot." His father yelled at him.

“I don’t need you, Father,” Ludwig said as he stormed out of the house, slamming the door behind him. After walking the streets and thinking for over an hour, Ludwig remembered the thugs who he’d met in the park. He wondered if they would give him a loan. *I am sure I can win back everything I’ve lost and more*, he thought as he turned and headed over to the park.

Borrowing the money was easier than he thought it would be. The thug introduced himself, “I’m Fredrik Krause, and I’d be happy to make you a loan.”

Ludwig smiled. Then he remembered the previous transaction he’d had with this man. “Did you ever take care of that other business I paid you to take care of?”

“You mean the Jew?”

“Yes.”

“Of course.” Krause laughed. “We got him good. That was an easy job.”

“Well, that’s good.” Ludwig said. “He deserved it. Now, about that money. I need it as soon as possible.”

“Of course. And I will give it to you. But I expect to have it back by Friday with interest. That gives you three days,” Krause said, holding up three fingers on his hand.

“Three days.” Ludwig repeated. Then he thought, *three days should be plenty. There’s a card game tomorrow night. I’ll win back all the money. Afterwards, I’ll pay him what I owe him.* “I’ll get it back to you by Friday, plus interest.”

“Good. Make sure you do.”

Ludwig’s best friend, Max, was unable to attend the pochen game, or poker as it would come to be called, with Ludwig the following evening. Max’s uncle had come into town from Paris with his wife and son, so if he hadn’t owed Krause so much money, Ludwig might have waited for the next game, when Max was available to go with him. But he didn’t have time to wait. He had to win that money back as soon as possible so he could pay his debt on Friday. So, after dinner, Ludwig got dressed and went to the card game alone. As was expected, he entered the room to find the same group of men whom he’d played and lost to the other night. They were seated at a round table. The men were surrounded by several scantily dressed and over made-up women. At first glance, Ludwig had no interest in any of them. He knew they were prostitutes and could be had for a price.

On this night he was not looking for female companionship; he wanted to win back everything he'd lost. And he was sure that now that he had some cash, lady luck would kiss his hand, and the money would flow in his direction.

He went to the bar where he bought a bottle of schnapps. Then he sat down at the poker table and began drinking.

A man of about fifty years old, with deep set gray eyes that seemed like they looked right through Ludwig, began to shuffle the cards. His two thick eyebrows formed one long charcoal colored caterpillar as he dealt out the hands. Ludwig picked up his cards and had to keep from smiling. He had a good hand. But he must not show his excitement. When he won, he began to feel better. Soon he would have all the money he lost, as well as the money he owed to the loan sharks. Then he promised himself that he would leave. He continued to win and soon he was right. He'd won back enough for him to leave. However, he couldn't bring himself to get up from the table. Not in the middle of a winning streak. It was far too thrilling, and he got lost in the joy of it. Hand after hand, Ludwig took the pot. Until a handsome man sitting across from him challenged him to make an all-or-nothing bet. Being on a winning streak, the way he was, Ludwig couldn't resist such a challenge. If he won, he would double his winnings for the night. He couldn't even contemplate losing. Not with the way Lady Luck was kissing his every move. And so, he agreed to the challenge. In a few moments, the cards were dealt, and Ludwig felt his heart sink. He lost everything he'd won on that one poker hand. *It was a fluke.* He told himself. He would win the next hand; he was sure of it. Again, he lost. And again, he tried. This time things looked very bright—he was dealt a straight flush. This was his opportunity to win back everything he lost. But in order to do so, he would have to bet everything he had. Ludwig felt the sweat bead on his brow as he laid down his bet. His heart pounded as all but one of the players closed their hands and went out. Finally, the only player who remained in the game was a big-boned, overweight man with wavy salt and pepper hair. He wore a dark suit and tie with a white shirt. Once again, the two men placed their bets as they stared deep into each other's eyes. Ludwig was sure that the fat man was bluffing. But when it came time to reveal his hand, Ludwig saw that he had lost. The other man had a royal flush.

Ludwig's face turned crimson with rage. "You are a cheat! A man who deserves no respect from anyone. I saw you pull a card out from under the table. I know you cheated." He yelled, but it wasn't true. He had seen no evidence of cheating.

"I won't have any trouble in here," the dealer said in a warning voice. "This is my game, and I decide who stays and who goes. If you start a fight, you are both banned from coming back here."

The other player didn't respond to either the dealer or Ludwig. He didn't even acknowledge them. He just swept up the money he'd won, then he swept the rest of his money from the table and began to fold the bills so he could place them in his pocket.

One of the girls giggled. It was Mona, a well-known prostitute. She was an attractive woman who had no fear or respect for any of the men she serviced.

Ludwig glared at her. Then he turned to the man who had won all his money. "Do you not know who I am?" Ludwig was trembling with anger and humiliation. "I am Ludwig Lang. My family can buy and sell all the fellows in here on a whim. You can't cheat me like you did."

"Go home, Lang. You've had too much to drink. Sleep it off. Don't start trouble here tonight. I'm warning you." The dealer growled at him.

"But you must realize that he cheated." Ludwig pointed his finger at the man who was pocketing his cash. "He did not win fairly. I want my money back. I need it now." He demanded. Ludwig, who was used to having his own way, slammed his fist on the table. Right now, he was genuinely frightened because he knew that Krause's men would kill him if he didn't have their money for them by Friday.

The large-boned man slipped on his overcoat and headed for the door when a gun shot rang out. Everyone turned to see the heavy-set man fall to the ground as Ludwig stood over him, gun in hand. Ludwig stood shocked—he didn't know what had possessed him. He'd always carried a gun, but he had never used it before. And now a man lay on the floor dying, and everyone in the room knew that Ludwig was responsible. The gun dropped from Ludwig's hand as he heard the man wheezing. The bullet had hit him in the neck. He was dying, choking on his own blood.

"What did you do, Lang?" The dealer said, shaking his head as if he were talking to a child.

Ludwig bent down and touched the face of the dying man, as if he could not believe what was happening. His hands were trembling, and he was about to turn and run out of the room. If only he could get away from this place, he could put this behind him. But his feet were frozen to the floor. The sight before his eyes was too horrible to comprehend, and before he could find it in himself to will his feet to move, two police officers appeared. Someone had run out of the building and brought the police back with them. Very few people liked Ludwig, and so it was no surprise that no one even tried to cover for him. He was arrogant, and for years he'd made them all feel like he was better than they were. This had turned into an opportunity for one of the others to get back at him.

The officers asked what had happened. And the men told them.

"You're under arrest." One of the policemen said to Ludwig, grabbing his wrists behind his back and putting handcuffs on them.

"Someone get my father. Please, someone go to my house and tell him that I am in trouble," Ludwig said. But no one moved. He wished Max were with him. Max would have helped him. In fact, he would have probably made him quit before he lost all his money in the first place. Besides, the other fellows all liked Max. So even if Ludwig had lost his temper and made the mistake of shooting someone, Max might have been able to keep the others from bringing the law into this. But as it stood, the police took Ludwig down to the station.

CHAPTER 36

Ludwig sat alone in a dirty jail cell and watched a large spider spin a web in the corner of the ceiling. The cell smelled of urine and vomit, and Ludwig sat wringing his hands, which were covered in dried blood. The night passed slowly until a tiny window emitted just enough light to let him know that dawn was breaking. As the sun rose, his father walked into the police station. The old man was clearly distressed. He had always been meticulous about his appearance, but not today. Today his hair was uncombed, and his clothes were disheveled. “That man is my son,” he said, in a soft, broken voice as he pointed to Ludwig.

“Father, I am so glad to see you,” Ludwig said, standing up.

“What happened here?” Herr Lang said to the officer, ignoring Ludwig. “Why is my son in a jail cell?”

“He killed a man in a card game.”

“Ludwig, what have you done?” he asked. “You killed someone?” Herr Lang’s face turned white.

CHAPTER 37

Herr Lang took a large handful of Marks out of his pocket and handed them to the officer. Germany was suffering from hyperinflation, and so money wasn't worth what it had been in the past. Because of this, Herr Lang knew it was going to cost him a great deal to buy his son's freedom. And that was only if the police officer was shady enough to accept a bribe. But he had no choice. He knew he had to try. Even though Ludwig had always been a disappointment to him, he was Herr Lang's only son, his only child, and the heir to his grandfather's fortune. So, Herr Lang made a deal with the police officer. And without any further discussion about what had really happened, all the details about the shooting changed. The officer declared it to have been self-defense. The other man was trying to kill Ludwig, he wrote in his report, and because of this, Ludwig was declared an innocent man.

As Herr Lang and his son walked home, Herr Lang said, "You are a big problem for me, Ludwig. You have been getting into trouble for as long as I can remember and this time, I wasn't sure I would be able to bail you out. You are reckless. And you must be stopped. If not, the time will come, I am sure of it, that you will get into some kind of trouble that I won't be able to bail you out of."

Ludwig knew that the best thing to do was to agree with his father. Besides, he was going to need to ask his father to pay off his gambling debt, or he would face the consequences with Fredrik Krause. "You're right, Father. I know you're right. And I'll change. I promise. But I am in trouble right now and I need your help."

“I just gave you my help,” his father said, throwing his hands in the air. “You’re free. You killed a man and you won’t face any consequences. I am ashamed of you.”

“I know and I am sorry, Father. I am really sorry. But there was a reason that I got so angry.” Ludwig tried to reason with him.

“Oh, do tell me.” His father said sarcastically.

“Please Father, give me a chance. I am begging for your help. Just hear me out.”

“I’m listening.”

“You see the man I shot had cheated. And this wouldn’t have mattered so much if my life hadn’t depended upon me winning that money.”

“Your life? Oh Ludwig.” He shook his head. “What are you talking about now? What else have you done?”

Ludwig told his father about the loan. They had just arrived at the front door of their home when Ludwig finished his story.

“Why would you ever get involved with those people? They are loan sharks. Are you dim?”

“I know, and you’re right father. But I thought I could win back what I lost, and pay Krause back too. I never wanted to involve you in all of this.”

“Well,” he sighed. “I’ve told you a thousand times that a gambler never wins. But you don’t seem to learn, do you?”

“I’ve learned now, Father. Please help me. I hate to involve you. I really do. But if you don’t help me, they will kill me. I am sure of it.”

“Yes, so am I. And so, I am involved now. I will have to pay him. His name was Krause, you said?”

“Yes, Father. And thank you, Father.” Ludwig turned to go inside.

“Wait a minute, Ludwig. It’s not going to be that easy. I will help you this time. But this time I want something from you for my efforts,” Herr Lang demanded.

Ludwig turned around and faced his father. He looked his father directly in the eye. “Father, I promise you that I will stop gambling, and drinking too.”

His father sat down on a bench in front of the Lang residence. “Sit down, Ludwig,” he patted the seat beside him. “I am getting older and I won’t live forever. Now I know I’ve spoiled you, and it was a terrible mistake. I haven’t asked much of you all these years. Perhaps I should have asked for more. Perhaps that way you would have learned some

responsibility. I thought I was giving you a good life. But it seems to have backfired. And therefore, I am demanding the one thing that I must have from you.”

“What is it, Father? Anything you want. Please just pay Krause off and make this entire business disappear.”

“I need an heir. A grandson. But I don’t want a grandchild by one of these prostitutes. I want you to do the right thing. If I am to rescue you from this mess that you’ve made. Then you must marry a decent young lady and have a son with her.”

Ludwig thought to himself for a short moment. *Is this all I have to do? Find a wife. I can still do whatever I want on the side, and even so I’ll take my time finding the girl, so it won’t happen right away.* “I’ll do it. It will take me a little time to find the right girl. But I will do as you ask.”

“No, I will find the girl,” his father said sternly, knowing Ludwigs’s antics.

“Do you have someone in mind?” Ludwig shivered at the thought.

“I have been thinking about this for a long time, and I have decided that I want to find a girl who is innocent and untouched. In order to do this, I believe that I should leave the city and travel out to the country. There I will find a clean girl, a farmer’s daughter. That’s the kind of woman that would make a good wife for you. Since she did not grow up in Berlin, she would know nothing of your terrible reputation.”

“A farmer’s daughter?” Ludwig said, the idea was appalling to him.

“Yes. Exactly.”

“How would you find such a person?” Ludwig asked. “We don’t know anyone outside of Berlin.”

“I know that. So, you and I are going to go on a little trip out of town. We’ll go to a small village where I will speak to the pastor in the church. I will tell him that I am searching for a wife for my son. And I will be sure that he knows that the girl he chooses for you must be a good upstanding girl. In return for her virtue, she will be wed into a family of material wealth. Most of the farmers are poor so this will be an opportunity to escape a life of poverty. I believe we will find someone who is suitable this way.”

Ludwig nodded. *I have no choice. I need that loan paid. Besides, marriage won’t change anything. At least not for me. Let the old man have his way. I’ll marry the girl of his choice and give him a grandson. Hopefully, that will make him relax and give me less grief about my way of*

life. It might even make him more generous with my allowance if he thinks that I need money to care for my wife and son.

“I’ll make the arrangements, and we’ll plan to go out of town the beginning of next week. In the meantime, I’ll pay off your debt to that loan shark. But you must promise me that you will never have anything to do with those thugs again.”

“I promise,” Ludwig said.

His father hesitated. Then he cocked his head, “Ludwig. I am almost afraid to ask, but I must know. Have you ever had dealings with Krause and his gang before this?”

Ludwig thought of the Jewish girl and her fiancé. He dared not tell his father about what he’d done. It was not as if his father liked Jews—he didn’t. No one in their class really did. But Ludwig knew that his father would have been furious with him for arranging to have any man, even a Jew, attacked for no reason. And even worse, if his father ever found out that the reason he’d done it was because Ludwig had a romantic interest in a Jewish girl who wanted no part of him, he would be livid. *I won’t tell him anything about it. He doesn’t need to know. That business with Krause is long over and done,* Ludwig thought. He was oblivious to the terrible consequences of his actions.

True to his word, that afternoon Herr Lang went to the park, met with the loan sharks, and paid off Ludwig’s debt. Then he returned home and sent a telegram to a pastor at a small church in a country village that he’d once visited when he was a boy. In the telegram, he said he was looking for a nice, church going woman to be a good wife to his son. He promised that the young lady and her family would live a very comfortable life and that they would want for nothing.

He added that Ludwig was a handsome young man, and he purposely said nothing else about him.

CHAPTER 38

LATE AUTUMN 1916

Herr Lang was feeling optimistic when he and his son, Ludwig, left their house in Berlin to board a train that was heading to a quaint little village in the countryside on that bright summer morning. *This might be the solution to his problems*, he thought as he looked over at Ludwig and smiled.

Ludwig looked out the window with a grim look on his face.

He has been in far too much trouble already. So, before things escalate even more, he must settle down, Herr Lang thought to himself. *However, the quality of woman is very important. I would never accept a woman who was not a person of valor into our family. She must be a virgin, untouched by any other man. She will be the mother of my grandson, my bloodline.* He smiled when he thought of having a little boy born into their family. *Once this child is born, I can die in peace.* He breathed a sigh of relief. He knew he couldn't trust Ludwig to take care of his assets, but perhaps this boy would be more like him. Herr Lang needed someone like himself to be the heir to his dynasty. And although Ludwig did not know this at the time, as soon as he had a son, the entire family fortune would go to his grandson, and Ludwig would be left with nothing but his monthly allowance.

As a woman wearing a skirt that was slightly too tight walked past the two of them, Herr Lang saw Ludwig's eyes perk up. *I am sure that the women he was involved with in Berlin were all gold diggers. Of course, he never dared to bring any of them home, but I remember when I had him followed and found out that the women he dated were all prostitutes,*

drunks, and loose women. Herr Lang was glad that he'd put his fortune into a trust that Ludwig didn't have access to. He was sure that these wayward women thought of Ludwig as nothing but a fool, and they believed they could use him to escape from their lives of poverty. But Herr Lang was nothing like his son. He was no fool. He would never allow these low-class women to get their hands on the fortune his father had worked so hard to earn.

Herr Lang glanced over at his son, who sat beside him on the train, and studied him. It was easy to see that although Ludwig was not as smart as Herr Lang had hoped he would be, Ludwig was devastatingly handsome. He had a casual air about him that drove women mad with desire. And although he wore a tailor-made suit of the finest wool, he wore it in a way that made it seem as if he was entitled to only the finest of things. "Father," Ludwig said as he noticed his father watching him. "How long is this train ride?"

"Not long," his father answered.

"I hate sitting on trains."

"I know. I do too. But try to enjoy the scenery. We will be there soon." Herr Lang said, patting his son's knee.

"Did the pastor whom you wrote to ever answer your telegram? Is he expecting us?"

"Oh, yes. He answered and he is eager to meet you. In fact, he's assured me that he has several girls in mind for you to choose from. They are exactly the sort of women we are looking for. I'm quite encouraged by this."

"I am sure you are," Ludwig said without enthusiasm. "But if you would only allow me to get to know the girls first before I have to commit to getting married, I would be forever grateful," Ludwig said.

"Son. I cannot trust you, and I will not give you the opportunity to ruin an innocent woman. The girl's that this pastor has chosen for you are good girls. They go to his church. And once we decide on which girl we are going to pick, you are going to marry her. There will be no fooling around beforehand. Nothing that can detour you from our goal. Remember son, that this is what you agreed to when I paid off your debts and freed you from a life in prison."

Ludwig stared at his father, his eyes narrowed with anger.

“Oh, Father. I do think this whole idea is rather ridiculous. Why would you think it best for me to wed a farm girl when there are so many lovely young ladies right at home in Berlin? There are ladies in Berlin that come from good families.”

“Yes, and their families know of your bad reputation. They would not want you for a son-in-law.”

“But we are rich. Everyone wants their daughter to marry a wealthy fellow.”

“Perhaps. But this is the way I want things to be. And you did agree to it when we made our little deal.” Herr Lang smirked at his son.

“I did, but I wish you would be more reasonable, Father. A farm girl? What am I going to do with a farm girl for a wife?”

“Let’s face it, Ludwig, you don’t want to get married, and you are looking for a way out of this. Don’t you think I have realized that? But this was our agreement. And you should know that when a man makes an agreement, he must keep his promise. This is what integrity means. I should have taught you this long ago. I spoiled you far too much. I indulged in your every whim, and now you think that is what you deserve. However, it has hurt you more than helped you, son. And believe it or not, I am doing this for your own good.”

“If you are doing this for me, then don’t. I don’t want this. I will find someone on my own and in my own time,” Ludwig said crossing his arms over his chest.

Herr Lang was growing frustrated. He’d had enough of Ludwig’s attempts to slither out of his agreement. In a firm and direct manner, Herr Lang said, “We’ve been over this too many times before. You do as I say. You will marry a good clean girl from the country. A religious girl. And you will put all those wild whores out of your life and out of your mind. The time has come for the end of your wild antics.”

“What if I meet these women and I don’t like them?” Ludwig whined. “You wouldn’t expect me to marry someone I don’t like, now, would you?”

“I have made arrangements for you to meet several prospective brides at the church this afternoon. I’m sure that you will find one amongst them who you can tolerate, if not like.”

“Father, please. Don’t make me get married to some country bumpkin. I am not really the marrying kind. At least not yet. I will have a terrible time being faithful. I doubt I will be able to do so. Maybe when I get older, I will

be more inclined to want to settle down. But I am having too much fun right now, and I can't see spending my time at home with some farm girl."

"Enough!" Herr Lang said, his face red with anger now. "A promise is a promise. And you made a promise. This is the end of this conversation. You will meet the young ladies who this pastor has selected, and you will choose from among them. Then you will marry her. You will be faithful, and you will give me a grandson. That is all I have to say to you."

Ludwig knew that when his father became angry, it did no good to argue with him.

Then his father glared at him and said in a soft, but threatening voice, "If you try to break your promise to me, I will disown you. I swear it. You will not inherit a penny of the family fortune, and you will lose your monthly allowance. And face it Ludwig, without money, a man like you will perish."

Ludwig bowed his head. He could not meet his father's unwavering gaze as the two men sat side by side. Ludwig turned his head and gazed out the window. While his father sat straight and rigid.

Ludwig was defeated. There was nothing he could do but go along with his father's plan. His shoulders slumped and his head ached. He knew that no matter what he said or did, his father was not going to give in, and Ludwig was going to have to get married. He shut his eyes tightly and felt sorry for himself.

CHAPTER 39

Greta sat in the back of the church with her father seated by her side. As she looked around the pews, she saw several other girls and their parents as well. They were dressed in their Sunday dresses, with their hands folded in their laps, and Greta knew they were gathered in the church for the same reason her father had brought her there.

Her father had come to her one morning while she was cutting potatoes to fry for breakfast, and in a soft and kind voice he said that he needed to speak to her.

“Sit down for a minute, Greta,” he said sweetly.

It was rare for him to speak to her in such a manner, so she was confused. Yet, Greta did as she was told.

“I am getting older, Greta,” her father said. “And since I don’t have a son to help me, I can’t farm all our land alone anymore. I did it when I was younger, but it’s too hard for me now. My body aches and I sometimes feel weak.”

She felt compassion for him. She’d always wanted her parents’ love, more than anything, and he was speaking to her as if he loved her.

“I am finding it hard to feed our family, Greta. I know you do what you can, but you are only a girl. And it’s not enough,” he hung his head.

Greta looked away. She had done everything in her power to ease his workload. Then his voice changed, and she could hear that he was a little enthusiastic. He went on to say that he had spoken to the pastor at their church, and that the pastor suggested that Greta come to the church to meet a very special man. He told her father that the man was looking for a wife. He was wealthy and he would provide for her family as well as herself. Her

father was very excited about the possibilities. Greta thought of Hermann. But she was afraid that if she told her father how she felt about him and that she didn't want to meet anyone else, he would be angry.

"There will be other girls at the church. The pastor said that he is rounding up several prospective wives for the young man to choose from. Now, you aren't the prettiest girl, Greta. But even so, you have a chance, and that's because you do have a clean reputation. Only your mother and I know about you running out of the house in the middle of the night and doing things we don't want to speak of. Or that you have a Jew friend. You must be sure no one finds out about these things. They could ruin your chances."

She was relieved to hear that there would be other women for him to choose from. Greta knew she was not pretty, and for the first time in her life, she was glad. Being plain might save her from marriage to a man she didn't know or care for. It might be the only thing that gave her the opportunity to marry the man she really loved.

Now as she looked around the room at the other girls, a little voice in her head said, *they are all so pretty in their dresses. I am glad that they are prettier. I know that this will disappoint my family. My parents only see that this man is wealthy and that he has the means to help them through hard times. I wish I could tell them the truth: that my heart belongs to Hermann. But even if I told my father, he wouldn't care. He would probably beat me and tell me to forget Hermann. All I can do is hope that this wealthy fellow chooses one of the other girls. I don't care how poor Hermann is, I want to marry him. And I believe he is the first man to truly care about me. I would rather struggle at the side of a vegetable vendor than marry a man I don't love.* Her palms were wet and clammy with sweat. And although the pastor, whom she had known her entire life, had come over and reassured her that if she was chosen, this was a wonderful opportunity for a better life, she didn't want it. *I'm sure when he sees these other girls, he won't choose me. I have nothing to worry about.* Her heart pounded heavily in her chest as she tried to reassure herself. *Soon this will be over. Father and I will return to our farm. He will tell me how I failed him. And I will feel bad, but then I will see Hermann the next time I go to the market, and everything will be better. I wish we could just run away and elope,* she thought, but she knew she was only dreaming. She could never do such a thing. Greta was the kind of girl who cared too deeply about hurting others, especially her parents.

Her father needed her help on the farm. If she ran away with Hermann, he would have no help at all. She smoothed the flyaway hair that had escaped from her braid with her hand. And then she began to speak to God silently. *Please, dear God, make him choose someone else. Please, find a way to make my parents let me marry Hermann.*

“Come with me, child,” an old woman with flabby arms and a large wart on her chin, but kind and gentle eyes, said, as she patted Greta’s arm.

Shaken out of her own thoughts and trembling slightly, Greta forced herself to stand up. Then she forced her feet to follow behind the woman who led her to the back of the church where the pastor’s office was located. Her father followed close behind.

The door to the pastor’s office creaked as the old woman opened it and motioned for Greta to go inside. She entered a clean, but sparsely furnished room. Greta’s head was bowed, and her eyes were cast down at the floor.

“Sit down, Greta,” the old pastor said as he pointed to a chair across from his desk.

She did as he asked. Her father stood quietly in the corner. Then quickly, Greta’s eyes darted around the room where she saw a young, handsome man, and an older, distinguished gentleman sitting on the other side of the room. The older one appeared to be very stern. His hair was strikingly silver, and his blue eyes were like glass, completely emotionless, as he scrutinized her. When he saw her glance at him, he did not smile. The younger man’s eyes were soft, but he looked troubled. And when her eyes met his, he smiled briefly. But his eyes did not twinkle, and she thought he looked disappointed when he saw her. This did not surprise her. Greta knew he was disappointed that she was so plain. For a moment she allowed her mind to think of her sister, Mary Beth, and how pretty she had been. Even when she was just a baby, everyone who saw Mary Beth agreed she had been a true beauty. *It’s my fault she’s dead*, Greta thought. *If she were still alive, this wealthy man would be looking at her and not at me as a prospective wife. Even though she would’ve been too young; he probably would have betrothed himself to her until she was old enough for marriage. I doubt he would have looked at her the way he looked at me just now. Now I realize that my horrible thoughts about my sister ruined my parents’ chances of living a better life.*

“So, young lady. Tell us a little bit about yourself,” Herr Lang broke the silence in the room.

"I don't know what to tell you," Greta stammered. "I grew up on a farm."

"Do you enjoy cooking?"

"Oh yes, sir. I love to cook."

"Can you sew?"

"She can," Greta's father interjected.

"Let Greta answer," The pastor said to her father.

"How about cleaning?" Herr Lang asked, "Do you like to keep things nice and tidy?"

"I don't enjoy it, sir. But I realize that it is necessary."

"She keeps our house very clean," Greta's father interjected again. The pastor gave him a look of annoyance.

Herr Lang laughed, "Yes, it is, quite necessary. However, if you should be chosen as my son's future wife you won't be required to cook or clean. You can sew if you like, but only as a hobby. You see, we have a maid and a cook on staff. And I am sure you will enjoy having your dresses made for you."

She nodded and continued to look down at the ground.

"Doesn't that sound like a nice life?" Herr Lang asked gently.

"Yes, sir. Of course, it does. Every girl would like to work less and to have nice clothes," she said, then she noticed her father glaring at her.

"But Greta doesn't care about having fancy clothes. That's not why she's here. She's here to find a good husband. And I know that should you choose her, you'll find her well equipped to make any man a good wife," her father spoke out.

Herr Lang smiled at Greta. "My son can be difficult at times. Do you have the patience to put up with a husband like that?"

"She's very patient," her father said.

"I see," Herr Lang said, turning to Greta's father and politely but firmly he added, "It seems to me that you are a very proud father. However, I am speaking to Greta, and I would like to hear her answers, not yours."

"I suppose you could say I am patient. At least I try to be," Greta said honestly, looking at her father. Then she glanced over at the younger man. He was looking down at his nails, appearing bored with the entire situation. Greta felt a surge of relief. *I don't think he likes me. And if he doesn't, then I can go home and try to find a way to make my father accept Hermann as a son-in-law. That is if Hermann will still have me.*

“All right then. Thank you for your answers, Greta. You and your father may go into the other room and wait with the rest of the girls,” Herr Lang said. Then he turned to the pastor, “how many more are there waiting to be interviewed?”

Interviewed. The word left Greta feeling cold. *I’ve read far too many romantic books to see love and marriage as something one should be interviewed for.* But she kept her eyes down and said nothing.

“How many more are waiting?” The pastor asked the old woman who had escorted Greta into his office.

“Three more girls are waiting to meet Herr Lang and his son,” the old woman replied.

“So, three more and then we will make a decision,” Herr Lang nodded confidently and smiled.

Greta stood up. Her father took her arm and led her into another room across the hallway, where several young women waited excitedly for Herr Lang’s decision.

Greta slumped down in a chair in the corner of the room. The girls were speaking to each other in whispers. They straightened their hair and their dresses. When she glanced at them, Greta saw hope in their eyes. She looked away and stared out the window while her father twisted the fabric of his jacket anxiously, lost in thought.

CHAPTER 40

After they'd met the next three young ladies, the pastor and the old woman left Herr Lang and Ludwig alone in the office to discuss the situation.

"So, what did you think?" Herr Lang asked Ludwig.

"Of the girls? Not much. They are country bumpkins, all of them. They don't have any interests at all. They all cook. They all sew. And they all clean. What else do they do? Nothing. Can't you see Father, they are only interested in our family fortune."

"And the women you've been involved with? What are they interested in? At least these girls are clean and have values." His father barked.

Ludwig shrugged. "It doesn't matter because I have no desire to marry any of them. Or any of these girls either for that matter."

"Well, you are going to get married. And we will leave here with a new bride for you. So, there is nothing you can do to change my mind," he rumbled deeply.

"Oh Father, they were all so boring and ordinary. You don't want me to spend my life with a woman like this, do you?"

"Actually, yes, I do. It is my sincere hope that she will settle you down before you get into even more serious trouble," Herr Lang gave Ludwig a sharp look, then his eyes grew slightly softer. "You are my son, and I love you. But you are far from perfect. And as your father, it is my responsibility to do what I believe is best for you. Someday, when you have a son of your own, you will remember my words. Then you will better understand all that I am feeling."

Ludwig shook his head, but he didn't reply.

“Now,” his father said in an optimistic tone. “In my opinion, the quiet one, Greta, I believe her name was, seems to be the best suited for you. She seemed more honest, less eager to please. I didn’t feel like she was clawing to get into our family money. This is a good thing.”

“But she’s so plain. Not pretty at all. In fact, if you saw her walking down the street, you would hardly turn to look. Oh Father, not that one. Her breasts are so small. They are barely there. And she is such a small person, short and far too slim. Why, she looks more like a child than a woman.” Ludwig complained. “That one is really not my type at all,” he let out a long sigh. “Please Father, can’t we just go home, and I promise you that if you give me a chance, I will find a girl who is suitable. But I am begging you, please don’t force me to marry one of these ignorant country girls. I can’t imagine how a girl like Greta would ever get along in Berlin. If you can’t think of me, Father, at least think of her. It would be very difficult for her to make friends in Berlin. Can you imagine women of our class wanting to associate with her?”

“That’s where you come in, son. I am making it your responsibility to introduce your wife into polite society. You will make her transition possible.”

Ludwig glared at his father. “This whole thing is a mistake.”

But Herr Lang ignored him. He walked out of the room and walked over to where the pastor stood waiting for his decision. “I have chosen a young lady,” he said. “It is Greta. I don’t recall her last name.”

“Zolner. Greta Zolner?” the pastor asked.

“Yes, that’s the one.”

“Are you sure she’s the one? More importantly, are you sure you want to do this? Your son doesn’t seem as if he wants to get married,” the old pastor said. “And, well, you see, every girl that is here today is a girl I have known all her life. They are good girls from good families who have been members of my church. And I could not, in good conscience, condemn one of them to a life of misery.”

“A life of misery? How can you say that? The girl we’ve selected will never want for anything. She will never worry about dying of hunger or cold in the winter. Her life will be a comfortable life and to ease her mind I will make sure her family has plenty of food and never has to worry about the weather or the harvest again. Besides, just look at my son. Don’t you

think he's a handsome young man? It's not as if I am trying to marry off an ugly troll of a fellow," Herr Lang said, jutting his chest out with pride.

The old pastor glanced over at the old woman who worked for him. She stood quietly in the corner, listening to the conversation. "What do you think, Marta?" he asked.

"Well," the old woman drew a long breath, "you and I both know that these girls come from families who would benefit greatly by such a marriage. And I am sure that once Herr Lang's son is married and the children start coming, he will find he is happy to be a family man. Proverbs 3:5-6 Trust in the Lord with all your heart and lean not on your own understanding"

The pastor nodded, "I suppose you're right."

"All right then. It's settled," Herr Lang said. "I've chosen Greta Zolner."

"I'll go right away and let her and her father know that you've selected her," the old woman smiled, and the skin surrounding her blue eyes crinkled.

CHAPTER 41

Greta was still looking out the window when the old woman announced her name out loud, “Greta Zolner.” She said, “You’re our lucky girl today.”

“Me?” *Oh no. I was sure I would be spared. Why would he choose me? All these girls are so much prettier, and they all seem to want to marry this man. From what I can tell, I am the only one who doesn’t.*

Greta’s father stood up and clapped his hands. He was ecstatic as he bent down and nudged Greta’s shoulder with his elbow. “I don’t know how you did it, but you won them over,” he said, and Greta could hear the joy ringing like church bells on Christmas morning in his voice. “This is a wonderful day. Today you have proved to be the daughter I have always wanted. It is because of you that our family’s struggles are over. From now on, I won’t have to work so hard, and you know how hard it has been on me, don’t you?”

She nodded. Her feelings were mixed. A small light shimmered inside her illuminating her heart. Greta was happy to have her father’s love and acceptance for the first time in her life. But at the same time, she was going to have to give up the man she truly loved, and the only chance she’d ever had at happiness. Although she tried desperately to control them, tears flowed freely down her cheeks.

Herr Zolner misinterpreted Greta’s tears. He was ecstatic, and he couldn’t imagine her feeling any other way. So, he thought she was crying because she was so happy. “Can you imagine it, Greta? Your mother and I won’t have to wonder how we are going to get enough food to get us

through the winter. Besides that, I'll bet that once in a while, you will bring your mother a pretty dress, won't you?" Her father nudged her shoulder.

"Yes, father. Of course, I will." She nodded, but her heart ached, and she wished she could just lie down and die. *This is going to hurt Hermann. And he doesn't deserve it. He's the only person who has ever shown me true kindness.* Greta knew she couldn't tell her father what she was really feeling. She couldn't bear to disappoint him. *I wish my father would understand if I told him I don't want to marry that arrogant man in the other room. He might be rich, but he is not the man I want to spend my life with.* But I owe it to my parents to marry him, because if I hadn't willed my sister's death, then she would have married this wealthy man and been happy to do so. I am sure he would have loved her because she was so beautiful. My fate is all my fault. I brought this on myself. I didn't mean to do it, and if I could go back in time, I would change it. But there is no going back. Mary Beth is dead. My anger towards her alerted whatever demons were listening, and they grabbed her soul. Mary Beth had been robbed of her life. But Greta would pay too. She would pay with her future.

Greta's father was speaking to Marta, who was standing beside them now. But Greta had been so lost in thought that she missed most of the conversation.

"Herr Lang says that he wants Pastor Klein to marry Greta and Ludwig before they leave to return to Berlin. Therefore, there is no time for you to organize a big wedding. If you would like, you may invite a few people to the church tomorrow to witness the exchange of vows. Herr Lang has generously offered to have lunch brought in for everyone from the tavern down the road."

"How many people may I invite?" Greta's father asked, his face was beaming. Greta knew he was feeling very proud and wanted to show off to his family and friends that Greta was marrying a wealthy man.

"Five, maybe six. Not too many."

"All right. And what time should we be here at the church?"

"Eleven in the morning. By the way," Marta said, "Herr Lang gave me this to give to you." She handed Greta's father an envelope. "It's money for the girl to go into town to buy a dress to wear for the wedding tomorrow."

"Of course. A dress," Herr Zolner said. "I will see to it that she has a dress. Something appropriate, certainly."

As soon as the envelope was placed in her father's hand, Greta saw the smile appear on his face, and she knew that she would never see any of that money. Her father didn't care what she wore to her wedding. Money meant everything to him, and he would not see the value in buying a new dress, even if the money had been given to him for that very purpose. But Greta didn't care about the dress. Her mind was spinning. She had to get out of the house that night and go to see Ruth and Hermann. She felt she must tell them both what happened, and she needed to let them know that she was going away. She wondered if she would ever see Ruth again. *I will miss my dear friend. And what about Hermann? I don't know why, but I feel so close to him. Maybe it is because he and I are alike. Neither of us really fit in with the other people our age who live in this village. We are different from the others, and they never allowed us into their fold. For him, it was because of his leg. And for me, it was because of my shyness and looks. But I know he and I would have made a good couple, and we would have been happy together. That is why I must go to him and tell him I am being forced to marry. He deserves to find out from me and not to hear it from customers who come to his vegetable stand. As much as I would like to hide, I know it would be selfish of me not to tell him face to face.* When she thought about Ruth and Hermann, fresh tears ran down her cheeks.

As they walked home, her father never even noticed that Greta was really weeping. He was far too excited about the prospects of a more financially comfortable future. Herr Lang had promised him that he would make his life easier, and this gave Herr Zolner every reason to smile. Finally, he would not have to get up before dawn each morning and spend his days breaking his back in the fields. He would not have to share the profits of his farm with a laborer who was injured in the war, whom he was forced to hire because he was too old and weak to work the land alone. And he would no longer be a slave to the weather. There would be food on the table each night, and plenty of firewood in the winter. And as far as he was concerned, there was no reason that could justify his daughter being unhappy.

CHAPTER 42

That night, when enough time had passed since her parents went to their bedroom and she could hear her father snoring, Greta slipped out the window and ran all the way to Ruth's house. She knocked on the door, but there was no answer. She knocked again. Once again, there was no answer. *Where can they be?* She thought, as she turned to leave. Greta was walking away as the door creaked open. "Greta?" Ruth said in a soft voice, "Is that you?"

"Yes, it's me. I woke you, didn't I? I'm so sorry. But I must talk to you."

"It's all right. Please, come in."

Greta entered the house.

"Bubbie is sleeping so we should be quiet," Ruth said in a hushed voice.

"I am getting married," Greta blurted out the news.

"Mazel Tov." Ruth said. "When? Can I assume the lucky fellow is Hermann?"

"In the morning. And the man I am going to marry isn't Hermann."

"What? In the morning? Why so quickly? And who is the fellow? I thought you were keeping company with Hermann," Ruth said, confused.

Greta told Ruth everything. Then she wept in Ruth's tender embrace as the night slipped by. "And to make matters worse, I am leaving our village. I'm moving with my new husband to his home in Berlin."

"Berlin..." Ruth said gently as she patted Greta's back, "Let's try to be optimistic. Maybe you'll like living in the big city, and you'll be away from your father and his beatings."

"I don't want to leave here. I don't want to leave you. And...well, I was just starting to have strong feelings for Hermann. I liked him very much. He

liked me too. I don't even know Ludwig. And from what I could tell when I met him, he doesn't seem interested in getting married at all."

"Did you try to tell your father that you don't want to marry Ludwig?"

"It wouldn't do any good. My father only knows that Ludwig is rich. This is all that matters to him. He sees money and he goes blind to anything else."

"Maybe you should talk to your mother?"

"It won't do any good. She does whatever my father tells her to do. I have no doubt she would only see things the same way he would."

"Oh Greta, what can I do to help you?"

"There's nothing you or anyone else can do. I guess, I am just here to say goodbye," Greta hung her head solemnly.

"Let's not say goodbye. Let's say a prayer that you will have a chance to come and visit me. Or perhaps, maybe I will have an opportunity to come to Berlin. Meanwhile, we can write to each other. Yes?" Ruth said, trying to sound as encouraging as possible.

"Yes!" Greta stood up, feeling better about the situation. Then she looked at the cuckoo clock that hung on the wall, "I'd better leave now. I must go and say goodbye to Hermann."

Ruth stood up and put her arms around Greta. Then she hugged her tightly. "I will look forward to your letters," she said.

Greta was crying too hard to answer.

CHAPTER 43

Greta did not know where Hermann lived. They'd never discussed it, but she knew he would be setting up his stall in the marketplace before dawn. And although she was sure her father would be awake and searching for her, she didn't care. She had to see Hermann one last time before she left. So, as dawn broke, Greta walked to the market. The vendors were already setting up their carts when Hermann spotted her. She noticed the muscles rippling in his bare arms as he laid a large bushel of cabbages down on the ground. *I find him so handsome*, she thought, as he walked over to where she stood.

"You're early today, and alone," he said with a slightly confused look on his face, then he broke into a smile. "Not that I am complaining. I'm glad to see you."

She smiled, but her lips quivered as she forced back her tears. He looked into her eyes. "What's wrong, Greta?" he asked, reaching down and gently caressing her face.

"I have to tell you something," she said, then she blurted out the words, "I am getting married."

The shock on his face made her feel sick to her stomach. "Married? I didn't know you were seeing anyone. You never told me."

"I wasn't. You are the only boy in my life. This is all very hard to explain. It's a long story. My father found out that a wealthy man from Berlin was coming to our church to look for a wife. And..." She was shaking all over. "Can we sit down?" she asked.

"Of course," he said, taking her hand and leading her to a large weeping willow tree far from prying eyes, on the other side of the road. Hermann

took off his shirt and spread it down on the ground. "Sit here," he said, "I don't want you to get dirty."

She smiled. She liked the way he looked in his undershirt.

She sat down and he sat beside her on the ground. He took her hand and kissed it. Then he held it in his own and didn't let go as she told him the entire story, including the fact that she was going to be moving to Berlin.

"Do you want to marry this man?" Hermann cleared his throat. It was easy to see that he was very upset. Then in a soft voice he asked, "Is it that you want to be wealthy? I love you but you know that I will never earn enough to give you a life of luxury. Don't get me wrong, I would if I could. You deserve everything good and wonderful. And I would give you anything I have."

She shook her head. "I don't care about being wealthy. But I can't defy my father. I just can't."

"Do you want to marry this man? I must know the answer to this question, please tell me, Greta. If you say yes, I will walk away and never think of you again."

"I should lie to you and say yes. I should do that so that you can get on with your life without me. But the truth is, I don't want to marry him."

"Then don't. Tell your father you refuse."

"I can't tell him that. I just can't."

"Then run away with me." Hermann paused and looked her directly in the eyes. "Marry me, Greta. You know that I am in love with you. You have stolen my heart, and I promise you that I will work hard to give you the best of everything that I can give."

"You know I can't defy my father, Hermann. I wish I could." She sighed in anguish. "But I am worried about you. I think about this war constantly. If the war doesn't end you may be conscripted, and they will send you away to fight. I can't bear the thought of you being hurt." Greta was crying, thinking of him in battle.

"Greta, the truth is I doubt they would take me with my leg being the way it is." He looked down at his leg.

"But, if you are away at war and my family has disowned me for marrying you, where would I go? What would I do?"

"You would go to my family. My family would take care of you. You would be my wife."

"How long would you be gone?"

“My brother has been gone for two years. But with my leg being the way it is...” He paused, and looked away. She knew he felt ashamed. Greta touched his face and turned his cheek back, so he was looking directly at her.

“I love you, too.” Greta’s voice was soft and gentle. “Even if I can’t marry you. I always will. And, if your leg gets you out of going into the army, then I am glad for it. War is dangerous. Men die every day. I couldn’t bear to think of it happening to you.”

“Greta,” he said, then he kissed her, and she wished more than anything that she had the courage to run away with him. “All I know is that I want to be your husband. And if for some reason they do see fit to send me off to war, I don’t want to die not knowing your love.”

She couldn’t hold back her tears any longer, and they flowed like a river down her cheeks.

“Don’t cry, Greta. Please don’t cry.”

“I am crying for so many reasons, but mostly because after tomorrow I may never see you again.”

“Don’t go. Just don’t go.”

“I have to go. Just like you might have to go to war. And I will worry about that every day.”

“Don’t. I have often wished that they would take me so I could feel normal. I love my country. I am no different than any other German man. My heart is devoted to this land. And I hate that I have this twisted leg. I’ve always been ashamed of it.”

“Oh, Hermann. It’s hardly noticeable,” she lied.

He laughed bitterly, “You know, the first time I spoke to you I was afraid you might say that you didn’t want anything to do with me because of my leg.”

“I didn’t notice it. I thought you were very handsome. I still think so.”

He blushed, “I would happily serve in the army if it meant I was normal, like other boys. You know what I mean?”

“I understand. To be honest, they probably wouldn’t take you because I’ve heard that farmers are getting exemptions. After all, we need someone to grow our food.” She said, attempting to make him feel better.

“My older brother was given the choice to stay at home and work the farm, or to go to the army. He went, because he’s very brave,” he sighed.

“How did it happen?” She asked gingerly. Something came over her; she felt deep inside her stomach that this could be the last time the two of them would speak. She wanted to embrace everything about him, learn every story and save them like a secret in her heart. She yearned to hold on to every memory of him. “Your leg I mean. Were you born with it that way?” Greta reached down and gently touched the knee of his battered leg.

He shook his head. “It might be easier if I had been. But no. I was fine when I was born. It happened one afternoon when my cousin and his mother were staying with my family for the summer. I was eight years old, and my cousin was two years older. My parents had sent for him so that he could help on the farm each day. I had to work on the farm too. We hated it.” He smiled sadly. “So, you want to know about the day that changed my life?”

“Of course, I want to know. I want to remember everything about you,” she said looking into his maple-colored eyes.

“So, I’ll tell you then. We had an attic in our house and my cousin, who was always a little curious, wanted to see what was up there. He dared me to go up with him. I couldn’t look like I was afraid, so I agreed. My father would never have approved. In the middle of the night, I lit a single candle, and we climbed up this narrow and rickety staircase into the attic. It was dark. Quite scary, really,” he said. “I knew he was afraid too. But neither of us would admit it. There were spiders and webs all over the place. I felt something crawling on my arm, but when I looked down nothing was there. Then we heard a noise. A strange scratching noise. Looking back at it, I would guess that it was probably just a mouse. But it was enough to send us running out of there. As we tried to make our way back down the stairs, I fell all the way down and hit the ground with a loud enough thump to wake my parents. When my father saw me, he shook his head. But there was no time to worry about my twisted leg. The candle had started a knitted rug on fire, and the flames were already leaping through the room. My brother grabbed my hand and pulled me out of the house.”

“Did your house burn down?”

“No, my father, my brother, and my cousin put the fire out before the whole place was destroyed. But there was plenty of damage. And I was in such pain that I wasn’t surprised when I found out that my leg and ankle were broken. Problem was that we were poor and we had to put what was left of the house back together. So, I lied and told my father I’d be all right.

I knew that we had no money for doctors. So, I made the mistake of letting my leg heal on its own. And this," he pointed to his leg, "is the result."

"I'm sorry you have suffered so much. I don't know how you've managed to work the farm."

"I've adjusted to my situation, because I have had to. I must work on the farm. I just do what I can. And since I am not as capable as my father or brothers, I work at the stand at the market. In a poor family there is no place for a useless person." He said, shrugging his shoulders. "And until you came into my life, I was lonely. I thought I would be alone forever. But the moment I saw you, I knew that you and I were meant for each other. I think you are so beautiful, Greta. Please, don't leave. Don't marry this other fellow. Let me be your husband. I promise I will do everything I can to make you happy."

"I wish I could say yes," she said, looking away. "You are more handsome than you think. Any girl would be lucky to have you."

He leaned over, turned her face to meet his, and kissed her softly. "When I am with you, I feel safe, Greta. I feel like a real man. It's wonderful to know that you accept me just the way I am." He kissed her again, and she melted in his arms. His arms moved around her, and she let herself lie down. He lay down beside her and kissed her again, this time more passionately. The sun was just a sliver on the horizon, rising ever so slowly, and that morning she spent talking to Hermann, she felt as though the world had stopped turning, and for that moment it was just her and him. She felt her breath catch in her throat and she knew she was about to lose control. Quickly she sat up and straightened her dress.

"I must go. I really should get home. My father will be awake by now and when he sees that I am gone he'll be furious."

"So, please tell me that you have changed your mind. Please say you are not going to marry this man," he said, and she looked away from him. She tried to stand up, but he tugged on her sleeve and turned her around, so she was face to face with him. "Don't marry him, Greta. I'm begging you. There will never be anyone like you for me again. I love you. I don't know what else to say."

"I am sorry, Hermann. But I must do what my father says."

"Why? Just because your father demands it from you? Don't do it. Just don't do it. Stand up to him. I know you are stronger than you think you

are. Show him that he can't force you to do this. Or at least let me come to your house and talk to him. I will convince him. I know I can."

"I'm sorry," she said, "But it's best this way. If you came to talk to my father, it would not do any good. It would only make things worse."

He grabbed her and pulled her to him. Then he put his arms around her and kissed her passionately. "Please Greta. Please. Don't go home. Come and stay with me at my house. We'll get married before your parents can find you. Once they find out they might be angry for a while, but as soon as we have a child, they will have a change of heart. Once they see how good I treat you, they will know that you've made the right choice in being my wife. Don't marry him Greta..."

"I'm sorry," she choked out the words. Then she firmly broke free of his embrace and stood up. Greta turned away so he couldn't see her crying. Before he could say another word, she began to run. And she kept running until she got home.

When Greta arrived at her house, her father was awake and waiting for her in her room. He sat on her bed, his eyes razor sharp with anger. "Where have you been all night?" He didn't wait for an answer. He stood up and slapped her hard across the face. "If your future father-in-law knew that you are just an alley cat running around with boys all night, he would not want you in his family. And you would lose all that money for your mother and me."

Greta reached up and touched her cheek where the slap had stung her. Then she said, "I didn't do anything wrong. I just went to the library to return a book and then I sat outside under a tree, because I couldn't sleep."

"Liar," he growled. "Besides, I've told you before that you have no business reading. I've always said that women should not learn to read. What are you doing with books from a library? That's where you met that Jew girl, isn't it?"

She looked away. "I've returned the books," she said softly.

"That's where you met the Jew? Answer me."

"I don't know what you're talking about," she said, but she was shaking, anticipating another beating.

"Listen to me, and you listen good. You'd better make sure that you stay far away from that Jew, and that library. And if I should hear that you are acting like a slut in Berlin I will come there and beat you so badly you will wish you were dead. Do you understand me?"

She nodded, feeling a shiver running down her back.

“Answer me. I can’t hear you,” he said, slapping her again.

“Yes, Father.” Her voice cracked with fear.

“Louder.” His voice thundered through the bedroom.

“Yes, Father,” she shouted.

He looked at her and shook his head. “Now, it’s getting late. Clean yourself up and put on a decent dress. We have to get to the church. Herr Lang and his son will be waiting.”

“Yes, Father,” she said. Then, just because she was angry, she said, “What dress shall I wear Father? If I recall Herr Lang gave you money for me to buy a dress and since I don’t have anything nice enough for a wedding, I’m not sure what you want me to do.”

“You’ll wear your mother’s pink cotton dress,” he said. “Tell her I said to give it to you.”

“But mother cherishes that dress, father. If I wear it, I doubt I will have time to change before we leave for Berlin. I will have to take it with me.”

“Then your mother will just have to learn to live without it. Now, hurry up and get ready. You’re wasting time.”

“Father...” Greta trembled as she spoke.

“What do you want now?”

“Do I have to go through with this? Must I marry this man? I don’t want to. Please forgive me, but I don’t want to do this. I don’t want to leave this little village. It’s my home. I’ve always lived here. I am not a city girl.”

“You little idiot. Can’t you see how lucky you are to have an opportunity like this to help your family? This is how you behave? You are ungrateful. God will be angry with you for your lack of gratitude. I don’t want to hear another word from you. Hurry up and get dressed before I make you regret being so thankless.”

Greta knew she was on the precipice of a terrible beating. And she knew that no matter what happened, her father would win in the end. He always did.

CHAPTER 44

Herr Zolner had been told that he could bring five guests to the wedding. So, of course, he brought Greta's mother. But he also invited his younger brother, his brother's pretty young wife, and their two young sons to the ceremony. It was, after all, a free lunch and an opportunity for Herr Zolner to show off to his brother. The brother who he had always been jealous of because his brother had produced two healthy boys. And although they were still too young to work on his brother's farm, Greta's father knew that his brother felt superior to him. *He won't feel so important and special after today, he thought. My daughter is marrying into a wealthy family. What could be better than this? He may have two boys to help him work his farm, but because of my daughter, I won't have to work at all anymore. I just don't trust this daughter of mine. I am sure she goes out at night and fools around with the boys in town. I must hurry and get this wedding over with before Herr Lang gets wind of this.*

CHAPTER 45

The previous day Herr Lang had instructed Marta, the church caretaker to order food for the luncheon. “Make it as lavish as you can in a small village like this,” he said.

She nodded.

That morning, when Herr Lang entered the church hall, to his surprise, although it was far from lavish, it was a decent spread of fresh food. There was chicken schnitzel and pretzels with sauce for dipping. There were sauerbraten and sausages, and heaping bowls of potato salad and spaetzle. For dessert there was a modest but delicious vanilla cake, with the names of the bride and groom written on top in white icing.

“I know the cake is not fancy,” Marta said to Herr Lang, displaying it on the table, “But the local baker didn’t have enough time to prepare a larger, more intricate one. I hope this is all right.”

“It’s fine,” Herr Lang nodded.

CHAPTER 46

1916

Greta looked sweet and innocent in her mother's pink cotton dress as she carried the cardboard valise that contained everything she owned. Her hair was in a simple braid, just as it had been the day before when she met Ludwig for the first time.

Her eyes were swollen from crying, and her face flushed from the slap her father had given her that morning. Then everyone was seated. And with the rays of the sun gleaming through the stained-glass window, reflecting vibrant colors on the ground, she put her arm through her father's and began to walk slowly down the aisle of the church. Ludwig did not even look at her when she got to the front podium, and she put her arm through his. As the pastor began the ceremony, Greta closed her eyes.

Herr Lang had given the pastor instructions to keep the ceremony brief. "We will be on our way back to Berlin right after the wedding, and we have a train to catch," he said.

The pastor nodded, and so the ceremony had ended quickly. Then everyone sat down to eat. They all seemed to be enjoying the food, but Greta couldn't eat, not even a single bite. Her stomach was in knots. She took a sideways glance at Ludwig, who seemed unfazed by the fact that he'd just gotten married. He was busy eating and flirting shamelessly with Greta's pretty young aunt, who was giggling like a schoolgirl. Greta looked away.

After lunch Herr Lang, Greta, and Ludwig collected their baggage, which they had stored in the church office. "Why don't you carry your

wife's bag for her?" Herr Lang said to Ludwig, as he nudged him hard with his elbow. Then, with a note of sarcasm in his voice, Herr Lang went on to say, "Show her that you are a gentleman of good breeding."

Ludwig grudgingly took Greta's valise from her. Then the three of them walked down two streets to the train station and boarded the afternoon train to Berlin.

Ludwig slid into the seat and laid his head against the window. Greta sat nervously beside him with her hands folded in her lap. Herr Lang plopped right across from them and began reading a newspaper. Greta wished she had a book to escape into. She felt so alone and alienated with these two strange men, and she wondered how she was ever going to adjust to her new life. Then she got an idea. She thought that maybe she should try to talk to Ludwig; try to find something that they had in common. So, without trying to meet his eyes, she said in a soft voice, "I love to cook. What is your favorite thing to eat? Perhaps I could prepare it for you?"

Ludwig didn't answer. Greta looked over at him and saw he was asleep.

CHAPTER 47

When they arrived at the Lang home late that evening, they were greeted by a young dark-haired woman wearing a clean white maid's uniform. "Nora," said Herr Lang to the maid, "take Greta's things up to the room across from Ludwig's, then let Frau Lang know we are home."

"Yes, Herr Lang," Nora said. But a look of anger flashed across her face as she glanced over at Ludwig. He ignored her and turned away.

While they waited for Frau Lang to come and meet her new daughter-in-law, Ella, the cook, walked out of the kitchen. She was a hefty, red-faced woman of about fifty years. Her blonde hair was streaked with a considerable amount of gray. But Greta noticed that she had the kindest blue eyes. "Can I get the three of you some supper?" She asked Herr Lang.

"Yes, that would be very nice, Ella," he nodded. Then added, "By the way, this is Greta. She is Ludwig's new wife."

"Nice to meet you, Greta," Ella said. And Greta thought she saw pity in the cook's eyes.

Greta smiled. "Thank you. Nice to meet you too."

"I roasted some chickens for dinner. There's plenty left over. I'll warm the chicken and fry some potatoes to go with it. I'll have it all ready for you very shortly."

Herr Lang nodded.

Then Frau Lang walked into the room. She was a tall, elegant lady, and she carried herself like a queen. Age had given her lines around her eyes and mouth, but even so, Greta could see that she had once been exceptionally beautiful. "I'm Lydia Lang," she said, coldly studying Greta

up and down, “You must be the girl my husband brought back from the country.”

“She’s more than just some girl I brought back from the country. You do remember why I had to go to the countryside in the first place don’t you? Or do you ever listen to me when I speak to you? It seems your head is filled with nonsense. You never seem to worry about anything but the next charity auction, the next party, or who is sleeping with whom,” he clucked his tongue.

“I do listen when you speak to me. But I also have other interests.”

“Of course you do,” he said sarcastically. “Anyway, I don’t want to argue in front of our guest.” He smiled at Greta, then gave his wife a warning look. “Your daughter-in-law’s name is Greta. She and Ludwig were married this morning.”

“Without me there?” Lydia glared at her husband. “You had a wedding without the groom’s mother. I would have thought you would have been more considerate of my feelings, Wolfgang.”

This was the first time Greta had ever heard her father-in-law’s first name.

“The pastor is very protective. I highly doubt he would have allowed me to take a young innocent girl back to Berlin with me without the two of them having been wed first.”

“I see...” she shrugged. “Well, welcome then.” Lydia said to Greta as she sat down on a chair and lit a cigarette.

Ella poked her head into the living room and said, “Supper is served.”

“Why don’t you three go ahead and eat. I’ve already eaten,” Frau Lang said. “And I’m very tired. So, I’m going to go to bed.”

“Don’t you want to speak with Greta? Perhaps get to know your new daughter-in-law a little?” Herr Lang asked.

“I hosted a charity event for the women’s league this afternoon and I really am tired. So, I am sure Greta will understand. I will find time to have a nice chat with her tomorrow. How does that sound?” she asked Greta.

“Sounds good to me.” Ludwig interjected abruptly. “Go to bed mother. There’s no point in standing around talking about nothing. I’m starving,” Ludwig said, as he left his suitcase in the middle of the floor and began to follow the cook into the dining room. Out of the corner of her eye, Greta noticed that Nora, the maid, was standing on the stairs watching her closely.

They ate in silence for several minutes. The only sound was the clinking of the silverware on the china plates. Then the cook came in and asked, "Can I bring you anything else sir?"

"No, this is just fine," Herr Lang answered.

No one spoke to Greta, and she wondered if she would ever have another conversation with anyone. She shivered to think how lonely this life was going to be if things continued this way. And she was feeling very uneasy about the wedding night to come. The idea of taking her clothes off and lying in bed beside Ludwig was repugnant to her. For a single instant, she thought of Hermann. *How different our wedding night would have been.*

"Don't you like the food? Shall I ask the cook to bring you something else?" Herr Lang noticed that Greta was not eating.

"Oh no. This is very good. I'm just tired," she said.

"Not too tired, I hope. It is your wedding night, after all." Herr Lang made a crude joke. He gave a short laugh, enjoying his own humor, but he was the only one who laughed. Then he cleared his throat and said, "Perhaps you should be getting to bed then."

"Thank you for dinner," Greta said as she stood up. But then she realized she had no idea where she was going. "I'm rather embarrassed, but I don't where my room is."

Ludwig let out a short little giggle, but when his father turned a dark stare upon him, he immediately stifled it.

"Of course you don't. No one has had a chance to show you around the place yet." Herr Lang said. "We'll make sure you get a tour tomorrow. But tonight, I'll have Ella show you to your room," he smiled, then called out. "Ella, come in here please. Please show the new Frau Lang to her room."

Ella was wiping her hands on her apron when she entered the dining room. "Yes, sir." She said, then turning to Greta, "Follow me, dear." As Greta followed Ella towards the staircase, Ella turned to her, "Shall I call you Frau Lang?"

"I suppose that's my name now," Greta said. "But I would much rather be called just Greta."

"Greta it is then."

Greta followed the cook up a long winding staircase to the second floor of the house. They walked down a corridor until they came to a large wooden door. Ella opened it. On the floor sat Greta's cardboard suitcase. It looked out of place amongst the opulent furnishings. There was a large

mahogany fourposter bed with a thick white embroidered bedspread. A dresser of the same wood as the bed stood on the right side of the room, and a matching nightstand to the left. Heavy white curtains covered the window. And in the far corner was a small, round sitting area with a table and chair, both of which were made of mahogany too, but these had deer hand-carved upon them. "Do you like it?" Ella asked.

"Very much. It's beautiful. Far more elegant than any place I've ever been before."

"It is quite lovely," Ella agreed. "I hope you will be happy here."

Greta tried to smile, but even as she did, she felt her lips tremble. "I hope so," her voice cracked, then in a small voice she asked, "May I sit on the bed?"

"You can do as you like, this room is yours, my dear."

"Mine? What about Ludwig? Don't we share a room?"

"Oh no, dear, he has his own room across the hall. But don't worry. He will come and visit you."

"I wasn't worried about that," Greta said, her face pale. Then she slumped down on the bed.

"What is it? Are you feeling all right?"

Greta saw the kindness and concern in the cook's soft blue eyes, and she shook her head, "No, I'm not. I'm terrified. I have never been with a man before and I hardly know Ludwig. And to be honest, I am afraid that what I have to do tonight is going to hurt."

"May I sit on your bed beside you?" Ella asked.

Greta nodded. "It will be all right dear. Ludwig isn't a coarse man. I've known him all his life. Since he was a young child. That's when I started working for the Langs. Ludwig is far from perfect. I must admit that he's a bit arrogant, and he has some rather difficult qualities. However, I don't think he will be a rough lover. I doubt he will hurt you. But..."

"But?"

"Well, since you said you hardly know him, I'm assuming you're not in love with him."

"No, not at all."

"I am probably overstepping my boundaries here. And I hope you won't tell Herr or Frau Lang what I am about to say. But you seem like such a nice girl, I am going to say it anyway." She paused for a moment to make sure there were no footsteps approaching. "Don't allow yourself to fall in

love with him, my dear. He'll hurt you. He'll surely break your heart. You see, Ludwig has been known to be a womanizer. I don't know if he has it in him to return the true love of a good woman. And I would hate to see you get your heart broken."

Greta nodded. "I figured as much when I saw the way Nora looked at him. She's in love with him, isn't she?"

"Yes, she is. What a sharp eye you have. You don't miss a thing, do you?" Ella nudged Greta's shoulder and smiled.

"I wouldn't say that. But I do try to be observant."

"Well, that's a good quality to have. It will serve you well here in the Lang household."

Greta nodded.

"Anyway, I assume you will be wanting a bath after a long day's travels. So, the bathroom is right down the hall to your left with a big cast iron tub. I've already warmed the water for you while you were having dinner. So, go on and take a bath. It will help you relax." Ella smiled. "And don't be too nervous. It will all be all right." Ella said as she stood up. "I'd best get back to the kitchen now. There will be dishes to clear."

"Thank you. You are so kind. No one has ever prepared a bath for me before," Greta said.

"Get used to it. You've married into wealth. There are a lot of girls here in Berlin that wish they were in your position. You see, Greta dear, you are a lady of leisure now."

CHAPTER 48

The tub was so much larger than the makeshift washtub they had used for bathing in back on her parent's farm. This bathtub was wonderful and comfortable. Instead of having to bend her knees, she was able to stretch out and almost lie down. Greta felt so indulgent. Since preparing a bath took so much time and effort, as well as the use of precious water, Greta's family had limited bathing to once a week. But now she lay in the large tub until the bathwater turned cold. Only then did she force herself to get out and put on her floor length white cotton nightgown. First, she poured a small amount of Chlorodont Zahnpulver, a powdered form of toothpaste that she found on the counter in the bathroom, on to her wooden handled toothbrush that Ruth had given her as a gift. Greta brushed her teeth vigorously and rinsed her mouth. Next, she took the braid out of her hair and brushed it with the hairbrush that lay next to the Chlorodont Zahnpulver until her hair took on a healthy shine. After she'd finished, she plaited it again. Taking a long breath, she closed her eyes and wished she was going to her bed to be with Hermann, but she forced that thought out of her mind and walked slowly back to her room to wait for Ludwig. Greta lay in bed for a little over an hour, wishing she had a book to read while she waited. The longer she lay there, the more nervous she felt. After almost three hours of waiting, without Ludwig making an arrival, Greta began to calm down. She figured he was choosing not to come to her bed, and that was fine with her because she was exhausted, and she drifted off to sleep.

It was well past midnight when she felt a gentle hand nudge her shoulder. "Fell asleep?" It was Ludwig. He smelled of alcohol.

"Yes, I'm sorry," Greta's eyes flew open.

“It’s all right. I know you probably don’t want to do this anymore than I do.”

She didn’t answer. But she felt uncomfortable. If only she felt a little closer to him, she would have told him she was scared because she had not done this before. But instead, she lay on her back as stiff as a piece of wood.

“Well, we might as well get it over with, yes?” he said, and as he moved close to her, she felt a wave of nausea come over her from the strong odor of schnapps on his breath. Ludwig stood up and removed his clothes, which he dropped on the floor. Greta watched him. Although it was dark in the room, the light from the full moon outside trickled through the window, and she could see him clearly. There was no doubt that Ludwig was handsome. His body was lean and muscular. His facial features were chiseled, and his blond hair had just enough waves to frame his face.

Greta was shivering. She lay still, not knowing what was expected of her. He took little notice of what she did. He lay down beside her. And he began to touch her gently. He rubbed her upper arm, then he leaned over and kissed her. His touch felt awkward, and she gagged from the smell of sweat on his body and liquor on his breath. When he touched her nipples, she turned her head away in shame. And when it came time for him to enter her, although it was slightly painful, it was over quickly, and she was glad it was.

“Well, we did it,” he smiled. “We consummated the marriage.” It seemed almost like he was ready to congratulate her on their mutual accomplishment. Greta knew that this was nothing more to him than an act he was expected to perform. But for her it was something more. It was her first time, and she wished she had been able to share it with the man she loved. A single tear ran down her cheek. If Ludwig noticed, he never mentioned it. He yawned loudly and said, “Well, it’s done anyway. And I certainly am tired. I’m going to my room to bed now,” he left his clothes on the floor of her room and walked to the door. “Goodnight,” he said.

“Are you going to walk through the hall naked?” she asked boldly, because she couldn’t believe anyone would do such a thing.

“Sure. I do it all the time,” he said, then he added, “and by the way, try and eat a little bit more. You’re so terribly skinny. You have the body of an adolescent boy, instead of a woman.”

The insult stung her a little, but she couldn't say she was truly hurt as she watched him walk out of the room. She was glad he was gone.

Greta knew she wasn't a beauty, and it didn't matter that he didn't find her attractive, anyway. She certainly wasn't in love with him. The man whom she had really loved thought she was beautiful, and that was enough for her. Greta closed her eyes and tried to block out the events of the day and evening. But when she did, her thoughts went to Hermann, and her heart ached because she knew she had hurt him. And she knew they would never be husband and wife.

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CHAPTER 49

A few weeks later, when Greta had settled into her new home, she sat down at the small table in her room and wrote a letter to Ruth.

Dear Ruth,

I miss you so much. I wish I could come over to your house and visit with you and Bubbie. And of course, I have greatly missed visiting the library and enjoying the books you selected for me. I know you haven't been able to write to me until now because you didn't have an address. I am so sorry it's taken me so long to write. But it's been quite an adjustment living here. But you will have my address now. And I can't wait to hear from you!

Please tell me how you are doing. How is Bubbie? Is there anything new to tell?

Wait until you hear this. The other evening my father-in-law showed me his own personal library. I never even knew anyone had a personal library. It was a massive room filled with books. I thought I would die of joy to see such a thing. How wonderful it is to have so many books at one's fingertips. And you know what? He said I could read all of them whenever I would like. When I looked around at the shelves and shelves of books, I felt giddy and excited, like I might

faint. Does anyone actually faint from joy? I don't know. But I was quite overcome. The library is the best part of this arrangement. Because now I will have access to reading material all the time.

I suppose you would be wanting to know a little about my marriage. It's not heaven by any means. Ludwig is cold and he doesn't like me very much. He isn't rough or cruel, but I know the only reason he ever comes to my bed is because he knows his father expects him to produce a grandson to take over the family fortune. I am hoping to conceive quickly so that Ludwig stops coming to my bed. He says he is worried that I won't be able to give him a child because I am too skinny and underdeveloped. So, I have been forcing myself to eat more. I must admit, eating more is easy here in the Lang house. There is so much food. I've never seen so much food. Would you believe that they have rich, delicious cakes on their table every day? At home, I was lucky to get my hands on a piece of cake once a year at Christmas. Even so, I don't want to get big and fat. I think it would be hard to be pregnant if one were too fat. But what do I know? I know nothing about childbearing. My mother never discussed it with me.

By the way, I must ask you this. Please don't think badly of me, but I must know. Have you gone to the market lately? If so, did you happen to see the vegetable vendor? You know who I mean. The young man who stole my heart. The boy by the name of Hermann. I don't know why, but even though I am married and living here in Berlin and I should forget about him, I always wonder how he is doing. I think of him constantly. Oh Ruth, what am I going to do? I don't know if I'll ever get over him.

*Your friend forever,
Greta*

A week later Greta received an answer to her letter from Ruth.

Dear Greta,

I was so glad to receive your letter. I was afraid you had forgotten me. Bubbie and I are doing well. Although she is getting older and I worry about her health all the time. I don't know what I will do without her when her time comes to leave me. The thought of it gives me chills. But I never tell her as much because she would only laugh at me and say I was worrying for nothing. She would say that life and death are only natural.

Anyway, enough sadness and fear, I do have some good news! I started dating a young man from my synagogue last month. We were introduced to each other by a friend of Bubbie's. I didn't want to go out with him at first because I didn't think I was going to like him. But I was wrong! He is very nice, and I really do like him. His name is Leib, and he is a bookbinder. He does this for a living. However, he is also an artist. You should see the beautiful pictures he paints. And he just loves animals. I believe you would like him. Leib is very kind, and I know he would like you.

We both enjoy the same foods. Bubbie loves to cook for him because he has such a good appetite. I must admit he is built hefty, but I like him that way. Most of all, I love the fact that he is very well read. And because he is, we can discuss lots of different books. He's no Torah scholar, but then again, if he was, he wouldn't like me. No orthodox Jewish man would, they would think I am much too independent for a girl. However, he says he likes that I am a strong woman. He says he likes a girl who can think for herself. Besides everything else, I love that he was raised well. He is refined and always treats me like a lady.

I will keep you updated about our relationship as time goes on.

As far as Hermann is concerned, you must forget him, Greta. You have a husband now and a new life. But...yes, I went to the market for you, purposely to see him. I didn't tell him who I was. I just bought some potatoes from him. He seems to be doing all right. So, try not to worry about him.

*Always your friend,
Ruth*

Greta held the letter to her heart. She missed Ruth so much. It was wonderful to know that Ruth had met someone whom she liked. And even though she knew Ruth was right about Hermann, it was impossible to forget him completely. Greta doubted she would ever see him again. However, she knew he would always be in her dreams and in the back of her mind.

Later that day, after lunch, she sat down at the table and began to write.

Dear Ruth,

I am so happy for you. Leib sounds like an interesting person and a great match. I would love to hear more about your life. I wish I had more to tell you, but most of my days are spent alone. I suppose people would say I've been blessed with a wealthy husband, but the truth is that I want nothing material, and I spend my days longing for those I love. I miss you and our days together. And Hermann... how I miss Hermann, and what might have been.

Anyway, on a lighter note, my mother-in-law took me to have my hair done at a beauty shop! I am no longer a brunette. I now have golden blonde curls. And she had someone at the shop teach me how to wear cosmetics. You would laugh if you saw me. I feel sometimes like I am pretending to be glamorous. The truth is, it's an act. I am still the same old Greta.

And as always, your friend....

Greta posted the letter that afternoon. After writing to Ruth, she felt sad and tired. Ludwig had come to her the night before. He managed to make time to visit her bedroom at least once a week. And he made no secret of the fact that he was only having intercourse with her to give his family the grandson his father was constantly nagging about. She'd gotten used to sex, and it was no longer something she feared. But she couldn't say she liked it either. It was an obligation. Nothing more. She lay down on her soft-feather bed and closed her eyes. Drifting off to sleep, she dreamed of Hermann.

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CHAPTER 50

DECEMBER 1916

When Herr or Frau Lang's friends came to visit, Greta would overhear them discussing the war. They talked about the shortages. However, she saw no evidence of shortages in the Lang household. The house was decorated for the upcoming Christmas holiday. A large, healthy-looking Tannenbaum stood in the living room beside the roaring fire in the fireplace, its branches heavy with ornaments.

One afternoon, Greta asked the newly hired chauffeur to take her into town. Herr Lang had recently purchased an automobile. It was a Mercedes 28/95 PS, and Herr Lang was proud to say that he was one of the first gentlemen among his crowd of friends to own one. He would tell all his friends how only twenty-five of them were made before the war started, and now production was halted, so he was sure they couldn't get one. Greta wanted to purchase gifts for her husband, her in-laws, and something small to send to Ruth. But all around her she saw posters that read, "A Soldier's Christmas is a Noble One." This made her think of the sacrifices the soldiers on the front were making every day, and it also made her worry about Hermann and hope that he hadn't been conscripted.

She had hoped to enjoy a day of shopping, but found that there was a shortage of goods available for purchase in the stores.

In a small men's shop, she decided upon a tie for her father-in-law and a tie clip for Ludwig. Then she went down the street in search of a women's clothing store.

Greta walked into a lady's boutique where she asked a saleswoman if she might see some silk scarves.

"Yes ma'am, of course. I will show you what we have," the woman said, smiling. As the saleswoman walked Greta towards a table to show her what was available, she was surprised to see that the collar on the saleswoman's dress was frayed and the wool had tiny pills and looked well worn.

"Do you have any more?" Greta asked, scanning the sparsely covered table.

"Not really. But I might have a few from an exclusive collection in the back."

Greta nodded.

The saleswoman brought out a wooden box with a few scarves folded neatly inside. As Greta sorted through the scant inventory for something she thought her mother-in-law would like, the saleswoman began to cry. "I'm terribly sorry," she said, turning away. "Please forgive me. I could lose my job for this."

"Please don't worry. I would never report you for crying," Greta said kindly. "But are you all right? Is there something I can do for you?"

"No, I'm sorry. I'm not all right. I will never be all right again. My son was a soldier, conscripted into the army. He was so young. So very young," she gulped the air. "He has been killed in battle. I received the news this morning."

"You should go home."

"I can't. I need the money. Besides, I don't want to go home. If I did, I would be all alone in my apartment. This is hard enough to face while being around others. But alone it would be unbearable. You see, my husband is dead. He was a soldier too. He died in the war last year. And my other son, my Ralph, I haven't heard from him in months. I don't know where he is. But every day I pray he is still alive."

"I don't know what to say," Greta said, letting the scarf she had been holding fall from her fingers and land back on the countertop.

"There's nothing to say. I ask only that you please don't tell my boss that I burdened you with my problems. If you do, I will surely lose my job and now I am a widow all alone in the world. If I don't have a job, I will starve."

“I would never say a word to anyone. You needn’t worry,” Greta said, putting her hand on the woman’s shoulder to comfort her. She felt uncomfortable, but she bought the scarf because she thought it might keep the saleswoman’s boss happy. Then she grabbed a second scarf to send to Ruth and said, “I’ll take this one too.”

Greta had not meant to purchase a scarf for Ruth. This was too impersonal a gift for a best friend. However, her father-in-law told her that the women in the shops often worked on commission, and so she wanted to help the poor saleswoman in any way she could. She knew that Ruth would have agreed with her.

After Greta left the women’s clothing shop, she hurried over to the bookstore where she had hoped to find a book that she might send to Ruth. But when she saw a journal in the window with a burgundy leather cover, she knew she must purchase it. Because of the war, leather was scarce, and this made the journal expensive, but it didn’t matter. Greta had sacrificed Hermann’s love and her village, so now at least she had plenty of money. And so, to accompany the journal, just because she knew she could, she also purchased a gold pen. As far as her parents were concerned, she knew that the harvest had not been good. Most farmers were living on turnips these days, and if she had not married Ludwig, her family would have been in the same position. However, Herr Lang had been true to his word when he assured her he often sent food he purchased through the black market to her parents. Even so, it was Christmas, and she was feeling generous, so when she got home, she decided that she would ask Herr Lang if a Christmas Stollen, a traditional Christmas cake, might be sent to her parents.

An icy wind blew as Greta waited for the bus with several shopping bags in her hands. She sighed and realized that she was sorry that she’d told the chauffeur to return home after he dropped her off. It was just that she had not wanted to keep him all day, just in case Herr Lang needed a ride somewhere. It was so cold that she failed to notice a woman on the corner—in a ragged sweater, dirty skirt, and stockings full of holes—with a wretched looking little girl by her side. The woman took the child’s hand and walked over to where Greta waited for the bus. The wind ripped across the landscape mercilessly and penetrated the wool coat that Herr Lang had given Greta, freezing her bones. Greta was shivering and lost in thought when the homeless woman approached her, “Please Frau, have pity. My

child is cold and hungry. If you could be so kind as to spare a coin or two it would make all the difference in the world to us.”

Greta looked over at them and nodded. She couldn't believe that she hadn't seen them before. A sick feeling rotted in her stomach as she reached into her handbag and pulled out a few coins, which she placed into the woman's dirty hands. *I was so busy thinking of myself that I didn't even notice her. I think I am cold. What must it be like for her? Or even worse, for her little girl?*

“Thank you, God Bless you,” the woman said, bowing her head to Greta.

“God Bless you too,” Greta replied. She trembled as she watched the woman limp away. For a moment, she closed her eyes and remembered the times when she was poor, when she had lived on the farm. It seemed like a long time ago. And she had to admit; it was nice to own a warm coat and a thick wool scarf. Her belly was full, and she had a warm home with a real mattress to return to. These were the benefits of being married to a wealthy man, and she was grateful for them. But she knew in her heart she would have traded all these wonderful things for a life with Hermann beside her.

The bus arrived and Greta boarded, happy to be out of the wind. She slid into a window seat and sat looking out the glass, wondering if Ludwig had served in the army. *I doubt it. Herr Lang would have found a way to keep him out of the war. I'd love to know, but I can't ask him.* There was, she'd learned, a certain coldness about her in-laws that let her know without a word being spoken that there were questions she was forbidden to ask.

On Heiligabend—Christmas Eve—at his father's insistence, Ludwig, who would have much rather been out drinking with Max, joined the rest of the family for an early evening church service. Ludwig sat beside Greta, and he was clearly bored. He quickly fell asleep and slept through the entire Nativity play.

Once the play was over, the sermon began. A middle-aged pastor stood at the pulpit and welcomed everyone to his church. Then, in a caring and sympathetic voice, he said, “I know many of you have lost loved ones in the war, and that makes this season especially hard for you. But together, we must remain strong and faithful to our Fatherland. So that those who have perished in this terrible war would not have died in vain. And I know that you are hungry, we are all hungry. We must all make sacrifices due to the

shortages of everything right now. However, please remember that God is with us, and our faith is what will carry us through.”

The pastor droned on as Ludwig began to snore. Even Greta had stopped listening. But when she glanced over at her father-in-law, she saw that Herr Lang was nodding his head in agreement. Yet, although she'd heard about the shortages due to the British Naval blockade, she had never felt any form of lack in the Lang household. She thought back to earlier that day when she went to the kitchen to say good morning to Ella. She saw the cook preparing roasted goose, and heaping bowls of potato salad, spaetzle, baked pretzels, lebkuchen, and more than enough Stollen for a family of four plus the servants. Although she doubted that the servants would be invited to partake in the family's Christmas feast. She'd heard Herr Lang tell Ludwig that he planned to give each of the servants a cake to take home, along with their holiday bonus. He'd said that it was not going to be as generous as it had been in previous years. But of course, they would understand because of the war.

It's rather remarkable that my father-in-law is able to purchase as much flour, sugar, and everything else he needs while most people are scrounging for enough flour to bake a single loaf of bread. I suppose I shouldn't be surprised. He is wealthy, and money can buy a lot of things on the black market, she thought, as she remembered the ragged beggar woman at the bus stop. But I don't believe he actually needs to cut back on the Christmas bonuses for the employees because of the war. I think he has plenty of money. I truly believe that he is just using the war as an excuse to give them less.

At the end of the service, the pastor greeted Herr Lang and the rest of the family with a warm handshake and said, “Merry Christmas. I'm so glad you came.”

“Merry Christmas,” Herr Lang replied, “wonderful service.”

“Thank you.”

Then the Lang family walked over to the new motor car. The chauffeur opened the door, and they all climbed in. When they arrived home, Herr Lang told the servants to line up. He gave each of them an envelope and told them they could have the following day off. Then the family exchanged gifts, after which they sat down at the table and Ella served them their dinner.

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CHAPTER 51

The following day was Christmas. Greta awoke to a beautiful blanket of white snow covering the ground outside her window. All the servants had the day off, even Ella—which Frau Lang had expressed her disappointment over. However, Herr Lang insisted, and so Ella was permitted to spend the day with her family. Before Ella left, Greta had promised her that she would take care of the family’s meals on Christmas Day. “There is plenty left over from last night,” Ella assured her.

“I know. Don’t worry about us. I can cook. We will be fine. Go home and enjoy your Christmas,” Greta said.

Then Ella left.

Greta planned to keep her promise. So, she quickly washed her face and hands. Then she went downstairs to prepare breakfast. She had a sudden urge to go outside and enjoy the season. And she would, as soon as the morning meal was over. Greta dressed quickly. But even now, as she ran down the stairs, she could hear Ludwig in the kitchen complaining that he had nothing to eat. “I can’t believe you gave cook the day off, Father,” he said, annoyed.

“It is Christmas. And you can cut yourself a slice of bread. I know you are capable of that, at least,” Herr Lang said.

“Oh, Father,” Ludwig groaned.

“I’ll make us all some breakfast,” Greta said cheerfully as she walked into the dining room.

“Good, I’m starving,” Ludwig said dramatically.

“You don’t have to, my dear. It’s quite all right.”

“I insist,” Greta said. Then she went into the kitchen and began preparing boiled eggs, potatoes fried with onions, and thick slices of bread slathered with honey. When she brought out the tray of food, Ludwig’s eyes lit up. “I couldn’t find any coffee,” she said.

“I know. It’s the war. You see, I was unable to purchase any this week. However, I know that we do have some ersatz coffee. Why don’t we just use that today,” Herr Lang said.

“Ehh, that stuff is terrible. It’s made from acorns. It doesn’t even taste like coffee,” Ludwig grunted, greedily shoving a piece of bread into his mouth.

“Then don’t drink it, son,” Herr Lang snapped.

But when Greta brought out steaming cups of the ersatz coffee, everyone—including Ludwig—drank it gladly.

After breakfast, Greta cleared the table.

“You don’t have to wash the dishes, dear. You may leave them for Ella. She will be back to work tomorrow and she’ll wash them,” Frau Lang said to Greta.

“I don’t mind cleaning this up. I’d rather not leave it for Ella. Besides, it won’t take me very long,” Greta said.

“Do as you wish,” Frau Lang said to her.

CHAPTER 52

When she finished cleaning the kitchen, Greta put on her coat, and was headed outside when she saw Ludwig sulking in the living room. “Do you own a sled?”

“A what?”

“A sled.”

“I don’t think so, why?”

“There’s a hill just over there,” she pointed to the right. “I would love to go sledding. Would you like to join me?”

“Not really,” he said. “Besides, I don’t think I have a sled. Why don’t you ask Father. He’ll know if we have one or not. If we do, it’s very old. Probably from when he was a child.”

Greta found Herr Lang reading in the library. When she entered, he looked up. “Yes, dear?” he said to her, then, she asked her father-in-law if they owned a sled, and he said, “I believe we do. If I can recall, we put my old sled into the attic. You see I had one when I was a child.”

“May I use it?” she asked coyly.

“Certainly,” he smiled at her.

Greta found a dusty old sled and wiped it down. Then she took it outside and pulled it all the way to the top of the hill. She got on and slid down in a rush of wind and snow. Laughter escaped her lips as the wind flew by her with tiny flakes of snow flying into her face and landing on her shoulders and in her hair. When she got to the bottom of the hill, she saw Ludwig was smiling, and she smiled back at him. Then pulling the sled behind her, she went back up the hill and rode down again.

“Would you like to try it?” She called out to Ludwig, when she reached the bottom of the hill.

He shook his head. “I don’t think so.”

But he did not go back into the house. Instead, he stayed outside and watched her with curiosity. Greta was touched when she saw him smile as she enjoyed the simple pleasures of a snowy Christmas Day.

When Ludwig came to her room that night, Greta thought he seemed a little kinder, a little softer. And she wondered if perhaps they might come to be friends. She knew she would never fall in love with him; however, a friendship would be better than the cold existence they had thus far.

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CHAPTER 53

As the days passed, Greta tried to forge a friendship with Ludwig. But he had no interest in her. She had hoped that when he smiled at her on Christmas Day, he was beginning to like her. However, he had not changed at all. In fact, lately he had begun drinking more and staying out later. She overheard him fighting with his father. And although she could hear their raised, angry voices, she could not determine what they were saying.

Then, one night he came to her bed, very drunk and very angry. He was so inebriated that he was unable to maintain an erection. After several attempts, instead of leaving and going back to his room, he hit her. This was the first time he'd laid his hands on her in a violent way. However, it would not be the last.

CHAPTER 54

EARLY 1917

As the months passed, Ludwig grew angrier and more impatient. Sometimes he was able to perform sexually with Greta, other times he struggled. When he was incapable of sexual performance, he blamed her and this caused him to beat her. She knew his father was pressuring him for a grandson. So, when he began to ask her each month whether she had her menses, she knew he was frustrated. And when she had to admit that she had not conceived, he beat her again. Greta was afraid to let Herr Lang know that Ludwig was beating her. She was afraid that if he found out, he would be angry with Ludwig, and this would only cause Ludwig to be angrier with her. So, she hid her bruises and prayed that she might conceive soon.

The war was taking a heavy toll on the morale of the German people. Frau Lang often complained about the war, and how much of a sacrifice she was being forced to make. Greta listened as Frau Lang would rage about being unable to find good leather shoes to purchase in the shops, or how she was still distraught that there were no fireworks on New Year's Eve due to the shortages. Greta bit her tongue and said nothing, but she thought of the farmers who she had grown up with. She had seen poverty on the farms before. And from what she'd heard, things were even worse these days than any she'd seen. She longed to tell her mother-in-law how good her life was, even if her leather shoes were not new, but the older woman would never understand, so she remained silent.

One evening, when Greta was searching for a book in her father-in-law's library, she saw a pile of forged ration cards on his desk, *that's how he has been able to get so many unavailable goods*, she thought. *He must've found a forger who is making ration cards for him so that the Lang's would not have to change their way of life.*

TWO MONTHS LATER, Greta received a letter from her mother. When she first opened it, she thought it might be a thank you note for the cakes she'd sent for Christmas. But it wasn't.

Dear Greta,

I am in desperate need of your help. Your father has been conscripted into the army. I thought he was too old, but apparently, they've changed the rules and are now taking older men into a division which is called the Landsturm. He wrote me a letter telling me that he is guarding a POW camp. He said the job is not only difficult, but it's dangerous too. He wants to come home, but they won't let him. I am alone on the farm, and I don't have enough money to hire help. Can you please ask your father-in-law to intervene as soon as possible? He is a very influential man. He can probably use his influence to have your father released from his duties. If that is not possible, at least he might send money so I can hire help to work on the farm. Without help I will surely starve to death. I am counting on you, Greta.

I eagerly await your response.

Your mother.

Greta leaned back in her chair. She hadn't expected to hear that her father would be enlisted in the army. Although she had never been sure of

his exact age, she assumed he was about forty-five years old. And this, she thought, was too old. *They are taking old men. That means they've exhausted the supply of younger men*, she thought. A wave of guilt came over her as she realized that if her father died in the army, she would not feel as badly as she thought she should. Then she thought of her mother, and how her mother would be left all alone on the farm. This guilt made her want to do the right thing for her parents, despite her lack of feelings for them. They had not been good parents. Looking back on her childhood, she could see that now. However, she'd always been a good Christian girl, and because of this, she'd always been a dutiful daughter. So, if she had any way of ensuring her father's safety, she felt that it was her responsibility to make every effort to do so. And she would. Greta would speak to Herr Lang as soon as possible to see if he could help.

She reread her mother's letter. And then considered what Herr Lang had told her. He said that he had been sending money each month along with food. *So, why should my mother be in such dire straits?* In her youth, Greta would never have doubted the honesty of either of her parents. But she had never known Herr Lang to lie, and so she found herself skeptical of her mother's claim to be in desperate need of money and supplies.

If my father has been taken into the army, they might have taken Hermann too, regardless of his damaged leg. She shuddered with concern for him. *If only I could protect him*, she thought. *But how could I ever ask Herr Lang to protect the man that I truly love? The very idea of it is absurd. And yet, I would beg him to do so if I could.* Anger filled her, and she was suddenly overcome with resentment towards her parents for forcing her to marry Ludwig. If they had not been so selfish in wanting what the Langs could offer, she might be Hermann's wife right now. She crumbled the letter up in her fist and then threw it across the room. "Oh, Hermann," she whispered, "if only things had been different." A tear ran down her cheek. But then she thought about her mother and father. They were her parents, and they did give her life after all, and so she would ask Herr Lang for his help. Because if her father did die in the war, she would never forgive herself for not trying.

Greta spoke to her father-in-law that afternoon. Until now, he'd been so generous and always more than willing to give her whatever she asked for. However, when she asked him for his help, this time he looked into her eyes, and in a calm but disgusted voice that sounded like he wanted to spit,

he said, "You know, Greta, I am very disappointed in you." She was surprised to hear him say this. He'd never been critical of her before.

"I don't know what I did wrong, Herr Lang. But whatever it is, I am sorry."

Herr Lang nodded. Then he went on, "I have spoken to Ludwig about this matter too. And he's promised me that he is doing his best. He says he comes to your bed at least twice a week. You should have conceived by now." He cleared his throat as if he were embarrassed to be discussing this with her, but he had to make his point. "Do you recall that when you and Ludwig were married, I told you then that the Lang's need an heir? Greta, I am badly in need of a grandson. And it's been months, and still you show no signs of being pregnant."

"I..." she felt her face growing hot with embarrassment. "I don't resist when Ludwig comes to my bed."

"Well of course not, why would you? But then, tell me. Why are you not pregnant? I have fulfilled my part of the bargain. I've taken good care of you. I've sent food and money to your family. I don't ask much, Greta. I only ask that you produce a grandchild." He looked directly into her eyes. "It seems Ludwig is up to no good again. For a while he stopped going out at night, however, it seems he is back to his old behavior. I am quite certain he is going to get into trouble soon. Believe me, I know how he is. He's always been a bit of a wayward boy. I can't change him. But you can. So, it's you that I blame for his scandalous activities. After all, Greta, you are his wife. It's your job to keep a better watch over him."

She nodded, not knowing what to say. *How can he blame me for his son's bad behavior? Herr Lang must realize that Ludwig doesn't love me, so he won't do as I ask. I would never have expected that he would.*

"Well? What do you have to say for yourself? Why don't you try to do something to make yourself more appealing to Ludwig? Entice him somehow."

"I don't know what I am supposed to do," she said shyly, looking down at her feet. "I can't change Ludwig's mind about things. He does as he pleases."

"How often does Ludwig actually come to your bed? He says twice a week. But quite frankly, I don't believe him."

"He tries to come to me once a week. Most of the time he does. Sometimes not."

“As a woman it is your responsibility to find ways to lure him to want to spend the night with you even more often.”

She didn't know what he wanted her to do or say, so she just nodded.

“You really don't know how to excite a man, do you?” he said genuinely. “You really were an innocent virgin when you came here.”

“Yes, Herr Lang. I was.”

“I'm going to have Nora, one of the maids, speak to you. She's a wild one. She'll be able to advise you on this matter. Listen to what she says and do as she tells you. Do you understand?”

“Yes, Herr Lang.” Greta continued looking down at her shoes. Her face hot with embarrassment. *Nora is his lover, she thought. I doubt she's going to give me any tips on how to seduce him.*

“And as far as your parents are concerned, I will help them when you become pregnant. Until then, I've decided to cut off the money I have been sending to them. That should give you some incentive to give me what I want.” He took a deep breath, “Go on now. This little talk is over. Think about what I've said, Greta.”

Greta turned and quickly left Herr Lang sitting in his study. She ran back upstairs to her room and sat down on her bed. *If I fail Herr Lang, he might send me back home. That wouldn't be all bad. But I doubt Hermann would still want me now that I've been ruined. But I would also be close to Ruth again. Although she has her own life now with Leib.* She took a deep breath and tried to hold back tears. *But I know if I fail in this marriage, my father would be so disappointed in me. I doubt that he would allow me to even come back and live at home.* Her father could be vengeful like that. *So where would I go? What would I do without any money?* Getting up, she walked over to her desk, where she had left the book she was reading. But she was too distraught to read. Greta stared out the window for several hours, mulling over her life. When it came time for dinner, Ella knocked on her door. “Come downstairs dear. I have a lovely dinner planned,” she said gently.

“Thank you, but I am not very hungry,” she said, and that evening, she stayed alone in her room.

Later that night there was a knock on her door. She was expecting it to be Nora. And she was dreading this upcoming conversation. But when she opened the door, to her surprise it was Ella. “May I come in?” she asked.

“Yes, yes of course.”

Ella entered Greta's bedroom. "I'll start by saying that news travels fast in a house like this one. And from what I heard today you are expecting a visit from Nora. Is that right?"

Greta nodded.

"Now, I'm sure you are probably thinking I should mind my own business. But I can't because I see how hard you are trying to do what is expected of you here in this house. With the war raging and food shortages from the bad harvest as well as the British blockade, I can understand why you don't want to be sent back home. Is it true that your father's been conscripted into the army? I heard the master telling this to the mistress."

"Yes," Greta said, nodding her head, "it's true."

"So, your mother is alone on the farm without help and without money. Is that so?"

"Yes. That's right. She was receiving food and money from Herr Lang, but now he says he isn't going to send it anymore, because I haven't given him a grandchild." She turned her head so she could look up into the cook's gentle gaze, and something in Ella's kind eyes made Greta feel even sadder, and she began to cry.

"It's all right dear. You have done nothing wrong. I know what you are feeling. I understand. You love your mother very much and would do anything for her."

"I do love her. However, the truth is that my life at home, before I came here, wasn't wonderful. But in spite of their faults, I still do love my parents. For a long time, I resented them for sending me here. Sometimes I still do," Greta admitted. She was surprised that she'd opened up to this kindly old woman and revealed some of her deepest feelings.

"You didn't want to marry Ludwig?" Ella asked, surprised. "When that lad was single, he had girls lining up to marry him. After all, he's handsome and rich. What else could a girl want, huh?"

Greta looked away. "I wanted more. I wanted love," she said.

"Ahhh, yes. Love," the old cook's eyes glassed over. "Looking at me now, old and fat," she let out a sad laugh, "you would probably find it hard to believe, but I was once young and beautiful. And I too, was in love."

"What happened? Did you marry him?"

"No, we never married, unfortunately. But we did live together for a while, and our union produced a child. I gave him a son. Sadly, he was not the marrying type. In fact, he was a lot like Ludwig. He was terribly

handsome. And women couldn't resist him. I knew he ran around with other women. For a while I tried to look the other way. I hoped my love for him would somehow make him stop. But it didn't. His philandering only got worse. After a while, several of my girlfriends told me that they saw him keeping company with the same woman. A woman we all knew, who lived a few streets away. I was worried. I knew that this one was different than the others and I would have done anything to keep him. I asked him about the other girl and he denied everything. But then one day, he went off to work in the morning and never returned home."

"Did you ever find out what happened?"

"I went to his job to see if I could talk to him. But they said he had stopped coming to work. So, I went to talk to the other woman's mother. She told me that her daughter and my lover had gone off to Paris together. I don't know what happened to him after that."

"So, you have a son?"

"Yes, and a daughter in law...and a little grandson."

"Well, if the relationship didn't work out at least you have a grandchild to love."

"Yes, and I do love him. I love my son too. But I've already lost him. He was conscripted into the army, leaving my daughter-in-law and grandchild all alone. A few months after he left, I was informed that he was killed in battle. It was the hardest moment of my life. I wanted to give up. But I couldn't, because my grandson needed me. So, he and his mother moved in with me, because they couldn't afford to rent on their own. Together, my daughter-in-law and I support my grandson. He's still young and she can't leave him alone. So, she stays at home with him all week and takes in wash and sewing. On my day off, I go home and watch my grandson while she goes to work at a local tavern. It's been very hard on us."

"I can see how it would be hard for you."

"It is. But when I go home on my day off, and I see that little boy I know that it is worth all the hard work and effort."

"Yes, I am sure that the birth of a child can fulfill you like that," Greta said. "But may I ask you why you are telling me all of this? You hardly know me."

"Ahh, that's true. But I am going to tell you a little secret. You see, I have a gift. It is the gift of sight. Sometimes I can see the future. And

sometimes I can see a person's true character even though it is not visible to anyone else. And I see great strength in you, Greta. Don't you think I realize that by coming here to talk to you and by sharing secrets with you, I could lose my job? I know this. However, I trust you. From the first time I saw you, I knew you were someone special, someone I could trust."

"Me? Special?" Greta laughed and shook her head. "I'm afraid you have the wrong person. I'm weak, not strong. And I am ordinary at best. I'm just a girl who was selected to marry Ludwig," she sighed.

"But you would rather be at home in your village with the man you love, now, wouldn't you?"

Greta stared at Ella, wondering how she knew this. But she didn't say yes or no.

"It's all right. You don't have to admit anything to me. I see myself in you. Like I said, I have the gift of sight. And...I don't know how to tell you this, but I see things are going to be changing here in Germany very soon. Yes, Greta, change is coming." She hesitated. "I'm sorry to say that this change will not be for the better. Those who are strong among us will be forced to face it and stand up to true evil."

"I don't know what you are talking about."

"I realize this. It's all right. You will find out what I am talking about soon enough." Then Ella's face grew very serious. "But what you must know now is that what I have come to tell you will have very important consequences in the coming years."

"And what is it exactly that you've come to say? I'm sorry, but I have been listening to every word, and I don't know what you are trying to tell me."

"All right, I'll be blunt because you need to do what I am about to tell you to do."

Greta cocked her head and looked at Ella closely.

"Now, I have known Ludwig since he was born. And I realize that he is a difficult man. I am also aware that Nora is not the person to tell you how to capture his attention. She wouldn't tell you if she knew, because Ludwig has been sleeping with her for years, and if she had any idea of how to tie him down, she would be married to him instead of you. She is in love with him and would very much like to be rid of you. So, when she comes to speak to you, as Herr Lang has demanded that she do, just listen and nod,

but don't pay any attention to a word she says. Nora is not a person you can trust."

Greta nodded. She recalled the look on Nora's face the first time she saw her. "I can see by the way he looks at her that he doesn't love her."

"No, of course he doesn't. Ludwig loves two things, himself, and his inheritance. Women are disposable to him, like dish rags. He doesn't care for anyone. I don't even believe that he cares for his parents."

"Really?"

"I can't say for sure, because I don't know. But if he does care for them, he cares for himself far more. That is why you must give him a son. It is the only thing that will make his father happy, and ensure Ludwig inherits his family fortune. And in turn, it will secure your future."

"I know all of that. And believe me, I've tried."

"You must try harder. I have come here to speak to you at great risk to myself. But I believe in my heart that you will not betray me. I am going to repeat this, because it's important that you don't forget it. What I plan to say could easily get me fired from my job and that would put me out on the street without any income and as I've told you, I am the main support for my grandson. However, I must take this risk, because I can see that in the future, it is going to be important that you remain here at the Lang house, and that you have access to the Lang's good name and to their fortune. You will need it to save lives."

"Save lives? Who's life? And who will this be important to? Ludwig? My parents? The Langs? I still don't understand what you are trying to tell me."

"It is going to be important to many people. You will be needed in ways you never could conceive of."

"What people? You're talking in riddles, Ella. I just don't understand what you are talking about."

"I realize that. And you won't understand any of this for many years. But when the time comes, you will realize that I was right."

"Let us assume you are right. I still don't see what I can do to make Ludwig visit me more. How can I make him want to sleep with me more often? I can't see any way to make this possible."

"Oh child, you will never win Ludwig's love. That is surely impossible."

"Then what is it you want me to do? I don't know what else to do."

“From what you said about love a few minutes ago, I have the feeling that you have been in love at some time in your life.”

Greta looked away.

“Can I ask you who it was?” Ella said.

“I’d rather not say. It’s in the past, after all,” Greta said wistfully. “Besides nothing ever came of it. We were never lovers. It was just a childhood crush, I suppose.”

“I don’t believe that for a minute.”

“What don’t you believe? I tell you I was innocent when I married Ludwig. He was my first man.”

“Oh, don’t get me wrong, I believe that to be true. But I think you were in love with someone. I think it was more than just a childhood crush. And...” she smiled knowingly, “I believe you are still in love with him. Love doesn’t just go away, Greta. It’s not something that can be forgotten. It stays with you forever.”

Greta nodded. Then she looked away. Greta liked the old cook, and she had grown up among superstitious people, so she had no qualms about believing that the woman was a seer, but it still felt uncomfortable to talk to her about Hermann.

“It’s all right, Greta. I want you to know that you can tell me anything and everything. Face it, you need a friend. And so do I. Believe me, all I want to do is to help you. Because I know in my soul that a time will come in the future, when you are going to help me and a lot of other people too.”

Greta saw the sincerity shining like a beacon in Ella’s eyes, and she smiled. Then, in a soft voice, she admitted, “Yes, it’s true. I was in love with someone. Although I never slept with my lover, you are correct, I have never stopped loving him. Even now, I think of him sometimes. And I feel so sad.”

There was a long silence during which Ella fixed her eyes on Greta. Ella’s stare was so strong that it felt like something almost tangible. She was studying Greta to make sure she had assessed her correctly. Then, after a long while, Ella let out a sigh and said, “I am about to say something that could possibly put my very life in danger. But I know that I can trust you. Even so, I want you to swear to me that you will never repeat what I am about to say.”

“I swear it,” Greta said, grabbing Ella’s hand.

Ella smiled and nodded. "I believe you," she said. "I believe that Ludwig is unable to father a child. The word for this, I think, is infertile. I have known him since he was a child. And I know he's had many lovers. However, not one of the women he's been with has ever become pregnant. If he were fertile, I believe he would have a slew of illegitimate children all over Berlin. Because I doubt that Ludwig would have been careful, or clever enough to prevent such a thing from happening. Do you understand what I am trying to say to you?"

"I do understand. And if you're right, then what will happen once his father comes to realize this? I assume that eventually Herr Lang will see the evidence just as you have. Then, I assume he will tell Ludwig that he doesn't have to come to my bed anymore. And Ludwig will probably request his father's permission to divorce me or to have the marriage annulled. Don't you agree?"

"Yes, I do. And when this happens, Herr Lang will probably send you back to your family's farm. He would not send any more food or money, so you and your family would be forced to live out the rest of your days in poverty. And should that happen, not only would you suffer, but your family would suffer too. Not to mention a lot of other people who are going to come into our lives and be in desperate need of your help one day very soon."

"I wish I could understand what you mean when you say that there will be people who will need my help. Who are they? And why would they need my help?"

"I don't know who they are or why they need your help. All I know is what I see when I look into the future. And this is all I see. So, it's all I can tell you. I'm sorry, I wish I could be clearer. But this is all I have to say about it," Ella said.

"Can't you try to look deeper and tell me more?"

"I would, if I could. But this information is all I have. My gift of sight is not something I can manipulate. Visions come to me, and I see them as they appear. I don't always know how they will play out, or what the visions mean, exactly."

"So, tell me what I should do?" Greta said, "I don't know what to do."

"I am going to tell you exactly what you must do. Are you ready?"

"Yes."

"Then listen closely..." Ella pulled her in closer and began to whisper.

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CHAPTER 55

“**H**ere is the plan,” Ella said in a whisper. “You must make sure no one knows that you are leaving the house. Do you understand?”

“Yes, I understand.”

Ella took Greta’s shoulders, and in a firm voice she explained that no one must ever know what she was about to do. Ludwig, his family, or her own family must never learn the truth. “Now, tomorrow night you will leave the house right after dark. You will not be needing any baggage, because you will be returning the next day.”

Greta nodded. “Go on,” she said skeptically.

“Don’t worry about what goes on here at the house. I will tell everyone that you are in your room and will not be coming out because you are feeling ill. I will make sure they know that you’ve asked to be left alone. However, you needn’t worry, the family will respect your wishes. They are afraid of disease, so they won’t even try to go near you. This will work for your benefit. However, you must not waste time. There is no time to dawdle. Just make the trip and do what you need to do. Then return quickly.”

“I will do as you say, but what is it I am going to be doing?” Greta was losing patience.

“I want you to go and visit this man. Then I want you to lie with him. I can see in my vision, that you will conceive a child. We will tell Ludwig that the child is his. His father will be content. And so will Ludwig.”

“What about Hermann? Don’t you think it would only be fair that I tell him why I’ve come, and what I am trying to do?”

“No, he must not know, or he will not lie with you. This is for certain. Tell him nothing of our plan.”

“Hermann has always been good to me. And I feel terrible about lying to him. He doesn’t deserve this.”

“Well, I understand how you feel. But you don’t see what I see, and this must be done. It is for the greater good.”

Greta shook her head, “I don’t know...”

“I know. And you must trust me, Greta. Do as I tell you. It is the only way you will be able to stay here,” Ella sucked in a deep breath. “Now, when was your last menses? We need to make sure that you are ready. However, I know in my heart that you are. Even so, I will do the calculations, because we may not have a second chance.”

Carefully, Ella calculated Greta’s fertility. “It’s as I thought. You will go tomorrow.” Ella said, then she touched Greta’s forehead and said, “Although you don’t know it yet, your destiny is a very important one. You will save many people from death. And one of those people will be important in changing the future of the world. Now, I realize that all of this is hard for you because you see yourself as a little mouse. But you are not a mouse, Greta. You have the heart of a lion beating in your chest. And the day will come when you will see how many people you saved because of it.”

“Before I agree to any of this, I must tell you that I plan to go and visit my best friend. I simply can’t return to my village without seeing her.”

“That’s all right. If you must see her, then do so. Just don’t lose track of time. You must not stay too long. And make sure that you do not go to see your family. They cannot be trusted. They sent you here for their own benefit. Now that you’re here, we must make the best of things. Just do as I say and stay far away from your family.”

“All right. I won’t see them.” Greta agreed.

Then Ella got up and said, “Get some rest now, Greta.” And she left the room.

Greta lay in bed staring at the moon outside her window. She couldn’t sleep. There was so little time to prepare for her journey. *I wish I had longer to think all this through, but perhaps it’s better this way. If I spend too much time thinking about it, I won’t have the courage to do it.* She didn’t know why she trusted Ella, but she did. Somehow, she knew Ella was telling her the truth, and her destiny was tied to this strange plan. So, the

following morning, Greta took the bus into town where she bought the prettiest, most expensive dress she could find. Then she went home and folded the dress, carefully putting it into her handbag.

Greta could not eat the entire day. Her nerves were on edge, and when she tried to eat, the food stuck in her throat. She tried to take a nap, but she couldn't sleep. Each time she closed her eyes, she saw demons condemning her. Even so, she knew she must go through with this mission. At nightfall, Ella came to Greta's room after the family had all retired to their beds for the night. Nora and the other staff had gone home for the day, and the house was quiet. Ludwig was out with Max. "What if he and Max are in town, and I see him when I go to the train station? Even worse, what if I don't see him but he follows me?" Greta asked Ella nervously.

"Don't worry. He's probably playing cards at some gambling house. Either that or he is with some woman of ill repute. You will be all right. Just follow our plan. You can do this, Greta. I have faith in you."

Greta nodded. Then she followed Ella down the back stairs of the house that were reserved for the help. As she walked towards the back door, she glanced into Ella's room. It was a terrible contrast to the opulent rooms where the family resided. The walls had once been white, but now they were gray because they badly needed painting. The furniture was old, and the bed was small. But the room was spotless.

Ella noticed Greta's face, "The maid's go home at night. However, since I manage the house, I am required to stay. It's not as bad as it sounds. At least I get paid a little more. But as you can see by my room, the Langs don't treat their help very well."

Greta did not answer. She just nodded. When they got to the back door, Ella put her hand on Greta's shoulder. "Remember what I told you. Now go and be quick. I will say a prayer for you."

Greta nodded again. Then she walked out into the night.

CHAPTER 56

Only a few stragglers were at the train station that evening waiting for the arrival of their trains. When she entered, Greta quickly glanced around the room. She was relieved that she didn't see anyone she knew. So, she got in line behind an old man to buy a ticket from the ticket seller.

After she bought her ticket, Greta turned to walk over to the seats to sit down and wait for her train. As she looked around, she noticed that the girl who had been in line behind her was watching her. She was an exceptionally pretty young woman, tall and slender with long dark hair that was covered by a gray scarf. When the woman's eyes met Greta's for a single moment, Greta felt the hair on the back of her neck stand up, and she wondered why. But the girl looked away as she purchased her ticket at the counter. Suddenly a train whistle blew loudly, and Greta knew it was time.

CHAPTER 57

Lily was a good daughter. A dutiful daughter who went to work with her father early each morning and stayed at the jewelry store to help him until late in the evening. She never mentioned David or the pain she carried in her heart. And even though no one knew about her vow to find a way to punish Ludwig Lang, she never lost sight of it. Every night as she lay in bed, she thought of Ludwig, and how he had taken the man she loved from her for no reason at all. Neither she, nor David, had ever done anything to hurt anyone, especially not Ludwig Lang. And so, Lily decided that he deserved to suffer for ruining her life, and she was going to find a way to make that happen.

One afternoon several weeks ago, while waiting for customers, she sat behind the counter of the jewelry case reading the society page, being that the Lang family was so prominent, she easily learned about events that took place in their life. The day he got married, there was an article written all about the affair, including the name of his new bride. Ruining Ludwig had become her obsession. Every night, except for Friday night because she spent that evening with her parents, as soon as she finished working at the jewelry store, she walked over to the large sprawling estate where Ludwig Lang and his new wife lived. Lily waited outside, hoping she would have an opportunity to see Greta Zolner, the girl from the country whom Ludwig had married. She was surprised that he'd married a country girl. She thought he would have fallen in love with some beautiful socialite. But it didn't matter who Ludwig married. Once she saw the girl and could identify her, she planned to use her to destroy Ludwig. A full two weeks slid by, and still Lily did not see anyone come out of the house who looked like they

might be Ludwig's wife. The only women she saw leave were an older woman, who Lily assumed was Ludwig's mother, and a couple of girls wearing maid's uniforms. But she was determined. And rather than go home and rest, or have something to eat after work, she waited in the trees behind the house. Finally, one evening just after dark, a young woman walked outside and began to walk quickly towards downtown. Lily followed her as she hurried away from the house and walked all the way to the train station. The young woman glanced around nervously. Then she got in line to purchase a ticket. Lily quickly got in line behind her so that she might hear where the woman was headed. Lily listened as the girl purchased her ticket and when it was Lily's turn to be at the front of the line, she bought a ticket to the same destination.

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CHAPTER 58

Greta sat quietly as the train rambled along the tracks. She'd never done anything this dissembled before, and she hated the feeling of being deceitful, especially to Hermann. But even if Ella was wrong and Greta didn't have any miraculous destiny, she still knew she had to conceive. And so, she closed her eyes and said a swift apology to God. Then she leaned her head on the window and tried to steady her mind until she arrived at her destination. When it was time, Greta quickly stepped off the train. She felt as if someone were watching her, as she glanced around nervously, looking for anyone who might be following her. Then she walked swiftly out of the station. Once she was sheltered by the darkness, she began to run. She ran all the way to Ruth's house. It was late at night, and she felt strange appearing at Ruth's house without informing her or Bubbie that she was coming. But this was the only time Greta could see her best friend, and she knew Ruth would understand. Ruth was always kind, and she would be kind even if Greta woke her and her grandmother. A strange tingle ran down her spine. Quickly she spun around and tried to see whatever she could in the darkness. But there was no evidence of anyone being there. Leaning against the trunk of a sturdy oak tree, she reasoned with herself, *Ludwig would never have bothered to follow me. And although Herr Lang might have had me followed if he knew I was going somewhere, he had no idea.* Even so, it felt like the trees that surrounded her had eyes. And when she got to the open field near Ruth's home, she felt eyes bearing down on her from heaven. Guilt and fear swept through her. But she knew she could not turn back. She must go forward with this plan. There was no other solution. This was her only choice. And there was still a chance that it

may not work. It was possible that Ella was not really a seer. It was possible that she was just an old lady who, although she was kind, was little more than a cook and housekeeper. Greta tried not to think about this possibility. If she didn't get pregnant soon, Herr Lang was going to find another girl for Ludwig. Then she would be sent home a ruined woman. Everyone, including Hermann, would know that she was no longer a virgin, and people would gossip and say bad things about her and why her husband had wanted to be rid of her. They would make up damaging stories and tell them to everyone in town, even if they weren't true. It was doubtful that her parents would let her return home. Greta knew that they would be ashamed of her. And it was even more doubtful to her that Hermann would still want to marry her. *I must go through with this*, she thought as she approached the door to Ruth's house and knocked. It was several moments before Ruth came to the door. Her long hair was braided, and she wore a white night dress. When she looked through the peephole, she flung the door open and yelled, "Greta!" In her hands she held a single lamp with a lit candle inside.

Greta was so overcome with emotion she couldn't speak. She put her arms around her dearest friend and held her close.

"Come in. Come in," Ruth said, holding the door open.

Just then Ruth's grandmother walked out of the bedroom, "Greta? Is that you, dear child?"

"It's me, Bubbie," Greta said, tears of joy were spilling down her face. It felt so warm and wonderful to be back here in this little house surrounded by her dearest friends.

"You must be hungry, nu? Let me get you something to eat. Sit, sit. Please."

"I'm sorry I woke you. I would have come earlier if I could. But I couldn't get away. I had no choice but to come late at night."

"Is everyone all right?" Bubbie asked. "At your home?"

"Yes, at least I think so," Greta said.

"So, why did you have to come late at night?"

"Bubbie, don't question her so. I don't care why you came late at night. I am just glad you're here," Ruth said, grabbing Greta's hands in her own.

"Yes, me too." Bubbie smiled as she put a pot of water on the stove for tea. Then she lit the wood fire and took some freshly baked challah out of her cupboard. Turning back, Bubbie winked at Greta, "Wait until you taste my challah. I think you'll love it."

Greta smiled. She was hungry. She hadn't eaten all day, and she finally felt a little relief from her nerves.

"Come on. Don't be shy. Eat, please. Eat. It will make me happy," Bubbie said.

Greta broke off a piece of the bread and nibbled on it. Even with all the wonderful food she'd eaten at Lang's home, she found she was enjoying Bubbie's challah far more. "This is so delicious," Greta said, smiling.

Bubbie nodded and smiled. "I'm glad you're enjoying it," she said as the kettle began to whistle. Carefully, she poured three cups of tea.

Just then, a tiny ball of gray fur with large yellow eyes came strutting into the kitchen. The kitten let out a loud meow.

"When did you get a cat?" Greta asked curiously as she bent down to pet the kitten.

"She was a gift from Lieb. He found her outside his shop, all alone and starving. So, he brought her home. But he works all day, so he wasn't sure how he was going to take care of her. Then Bubbie suggested that we let her live here with us. Even though I work all day at the library, Bubbie is home and the kitten keeps her company."

"She's so pretty. What's her name?"

"Mishka. It means little bear in Yiddish." Ruth bent over and gently picked up the kitten and handed her to Greta.

"Aww, that's such a cute name," Greta said as Mishka began to purr in her arms.

"We love her. In fact, Bubbie and I can't imagine how we ever got along before she came into our lives."

Bubbie placed the cups of tea in front of everyone, then sat down. And when she did, Mishka left Greta and jumped into Bubbie's lap and curled up into a ball.

They sipped the tea and ate the bread for several minutes.

"Would you like to see one of Leib's paintings? He painted a picture of me with Mishka and Bubbie, and he insisted on hanging it right in the middle of our living room. The painting is good, but I feel funny seeing a painting of myself hanging on the wall like that," Ruth said, standing up from her chair.

"I like Lieb. He's a good boy. And a talented boy. Golden hands, he has," Bubbie said, nodding.

"I'd love to see it," Greta got up.

“Come with me.”

Greta followed Ruth into the living room, where a large, beautiful painting hung over the sofa. “You’re right, this painting is very good,” Greta said honestly.

“He asked me to marry him,” Ruth blurted out. “I haven’t told Bubbie yet. But I know how much she likes him, and so I know she’ll be happy for us.”

“That reminds me of something,” Greta said, “I’ll be right back.” She ran into the kitchen and got her handbag. Then she brought it into the living room and placed it on the sofa.

Bubbie followed Greta into the living room, and stood in the doorway watching.

“I’m sure you must remember the dress you loaned me for that dance. The one that my father destroyed?”

“I haven’t given it a second thought to be quite honest with you,” Ruth admitted.

“Well, I have given it a great deal of thought. And so, once Herr Lang started giving me an allowance, I knew that the day would come when I would repay you for your kindness. So, I brought you a dress to replace the other one.”

“Greta, that wasn’t necessary. I never cared about the dress. Your friendship always meant far more to me.”

Greta pulled a magnificent satin gown in cornflower blue out of her suitcase and held it up. The satin shimmered in the light from the candle.

“Oh! It’s beautiful,” Ruth said, beaming at the gown.

“It really is,” Bubbie added.

“I’m glad you like it. I was hoping you would.”

Ruth hugged Greta. “I have missed you so much.”

“I’ve missed you too. But I can’t stay, Ruth. I must go.”

“Are you going back home so soon? Perhaps you can stay here for the night and leave in the morning.”

“I can’t. There is something I must do before I leave.”

“What is it?”

“I can’t say.”

“Is it dangerous?” Ruth could sense something was off.

“You just have to trust me.” Greta hugged her friend tightly.

“Of course I trust you, Greta. I don’t know what you are up to, but please be careful.”

“I will.”

There were a few moments of silence.

“Will you come back here for my wedding?” Ruth asked.

“Wedding, nu? You never said anything to me about a wedding,” Bubbie said.

“I forgot that you were listening. Well, I suppose you know now,” Ruth said, smiling at Bubbie, then she turned and winked at Greta. “Leib and I were going to tell you at Shabbos dinner this week. So, for his sake pretend to be surprised, all right? I don’t want to ruin it for him.”

Bubbie let out a laugh. “Mazel tov. I am so happy.” She let out a joyful cry. “And I promise I will appear to be so surprised that you will think that I am such a good actress that I belong in the silent movies.”

They all laughed.

Then, slowly, Greta closed her handbag. She hugged Bubbie first, and then Ruth. “I will try to come for the wedding. But I can’t promise that I will be able to get away.”

“Try really hard. I would love for you to meet Leib,” Ruth said. “I’ve told him so much about you.”

“I must go,” Greta said. “Goodbye for now, my dear friend. Please don’t stop writing.”

“I won’t. You don’t stop writing to me either.”

“I promise.”

Greta walked back outside into the darkness. Her heart was full of love, but also aching at the same time. She wished she could stay with Ruth and her Bubbie forever.

CHAPTER 59

JULY 1917

It was late-July, and the night air was cool on her face as Greta waited for dawn, when the market would open. *It wouldn't be long now*, she thought to herself, as she sat against a tree waiting. She felt foolish for not having given any thought to where she might find Hermann until she arrived back in her village. Greta had never known where he lived. But she knew, if he hadn't been conscripted into the army, that he would be coming to the market to set up his stand very soon. This put a slight damper on her original plans, and she was going to be delayed. Greta had hoped to be able to return before noon the following day. However, if she were to see Hermann, this was the only way she would be able to see him. She told herself that it would be all right because Ella was clever, and Ella would find a way to cover for her until she was able to return. Greta wished she'd been able to ask Herr Lang for permission to visit her home, instead of sneaking away in the night, but Ella was adamant that she not mention anything to Herr Lang. "You would have to tell him that you were going to see your parents. And I don't want your parents to know that you've even gone to the village. I told you that before. Now, think about this. If you did ask Herr Lang for permission, you'd be giving him an opportunity to say no. And right now, he isn't very happy with you. He blames you for not conceiving. So, he would not want to make you happy. Once he's said no to your request, he will make sure you cannot get away. I know Herr Lang very well. He will watch you more closely, and then you will never be able to escape," Ella had said.

And so, this was the only way to carry out her plan.

The sun peeked through the clouds as day began to dawn. As she looked around the small marketplace, her mind was flooded with memories. She recalled coming to shop for food with her mother, and then with Zeno. *Poor little Zeno*. She prayed he was all right and living with someone who loved him. Finally, in her mind's eye, she saw Mary Beth, beautiful Mary Beth, sitting under the tree where she now stood. A shiver passed through her, and she felt almost as if her little sister was watching from somewhere on the other side.

It was only a few minutes later that she saw Hermann pushing his cart up the hill towards the market. *He's here. He hasn't been sent to the army. He's alive*. Her heartbeat faster as she watched him. Then he turned, and his eyes caught sight of hers. His face lit up. "Greta," he said her name. She wanted to run away because she couldn't stand the fact that she was about to deceive him. But his eyes were like magnets. As he stared at her, she felt like she still wanted to run, but now she didn't want to run away; she wanted to run into his arms.

"Hermann," she said, as a big smile came across her face.

He set his cart down, and even though it contained all his wares, he left it and began to walk over to her.

She could see that he was trembling.

"What has brought you home? Are you all right?" He asked, and the genuine concern in his eyes made her wish she could stay with him forever.

He touched her arm for a second. "Greta? Please tell me what's brought you home?"

"Can we walk?" She said, "I can't talk to you here. But I have something to say, and I need to speak to you alone."

He glanced at his cart, and for a moment, she thought he might refuse to leave his goods unattended. The old wooden cart was filled with potatoes, cabbages, and carrots. This, if he sold all of it, would be at least a week's wage. She watched him and her heart ached. What she was about to do would hurt him. And she never wanted to do that. "Perhaps I should just be on my way. I should never have come here." She said as she turned to go. But before she could get away, he reached up and held her arm, "Please, tell me why you've come back. I haven't stopped thinking about you, Greta. I need to know what it is that's brought you home. And...are you staying?"

She couldn't lie to him. "I'm not staying, Hermann. I've just come to see you. And now I must get out of here. The other vendors are setting up their shops already, and soon the customers will arrive. It is best if no one sees me. But perhaps you should not leave your cart. Your vegetables could be stolen."

He shook his head. "I don't care about the vegetables. You've come to talk to me and I want to hear what you have to say. Come, let's walk," he said to her, taking her hand.

She nodded. Then they began to walk away from the spot where the other vendors had begun to set up their wares.

For several moments neither of them spoke. Then he smiled, but his lips quivered as he said, "You look different. You've changed your hair. I see that you are a blonde now."

"Yes," she said, touching the hair that hung past her shoulders. "Do you like it?"

"Oh Greta. I guess you don't realize what you mean to me. To me you are beautiful, the color of your hair doesn't matter. I must admit though, I liked it better before. But only because it was natural. And you are a natural beauty, Greta. You don't need fancy clothes or colored hair. The true essence of your beauty shines from your soul. I saw it the first time I laid eyes on you when we were at school. Even before we spoke a word to each other, I thought you were the prettiest girl I'd ever seen."

"You always say the kindest things," she blushed.

"The things I say to you are true."

She stopped walking for a moment and looked up into his eyes. He was much taller than her. Boldly, she admitted, "I never stopped thinking of you either."

"Greta," he said wistfully. "Why did you go?"

She shook her head. "I had to Hermann. I had to."

He turned away for a moment and wiped his face with the back of his hand. She knew he was crying. Reaching over, she touched his hand. "I don't know how to ask you this question."

"Ask Greta. If I can do something to help you, I will. You should know that. And you should know that no matter what it is, you can ask me anything."

"I want you to make love to me."

He froze. She felt his hand freeze in hers. His eyes shone as he looked at her. "I...I..."

"I won't lie to you. I can't stay here with you. I will have to return to my home and to my husband. But if we could just have this one time together, it would be something I would cherish for the rest of my life," she said, and it was true. She knew that if this were to happen, she would cherish the memory of his lovemaking forever. But she couldn't tell him the other reason she wanted him to make love to her. *How can I explain that I need his seed to have a child? A child he will never know. A child he will never raise.*

"I want that more than anything, Greta, but because I love you and I always will, I cannot lie to you."

At that moment she hated herself for not being totally honest with him. But if she told him the truth, and he refused her, then what would she do?

Hermann cleared his throat and went on. "I am married now, Greta. When you left me, I was miserable. I couldn't eat or sleep. Finally, my best friend introduced me to someone. At first, I had no interest in pursuing her. But she was so kind. She came to see me a few times each week and brought me things that she baked for me. The more I got to know her, the better I liked her. And slowly, as time passed, I came back to life. We were married a couple of months ago."

"Oh." Greta said, the words stinging her like a wasp. She was hurt, but she knew she had no right to be. After all, she too was married. "So, you are refusing me then?"

"To make love to you?"

"Yes."

He looked into her eyes. Then he kissed her passionately. "I can't refuse you, Greta. I want you like I have never wanted anything else in my life. I feel bad because of my wife. But I can't say no to you. If I do, I will regret it forever. This one time will be just for us. A secret that we will both keep locked away deep in our hearts."

They were alone. Hidden by trees and shrubs. He pulled her to him and kissed her again. Then he took off his shirt and laid it on the ground so she wouldn't get dirty. After he helped her to lie down, he made love to her and her entire body sang in harmony with his. *I feel as if this was my first time. Making love felt so different from before. It was never like this with Ludwig.*

When it was over, she lay in his arms. Softly he said, "Greta, it could have been like this every night of our lives. Why? Why did you marry him? Was it the money?"

"Not at first. At first it was because I was afraid to say no to my father. And there was another reason."

"Tell me, please. Was it my leg? Were you afraid I would be unable to support you?"

"It had nothing to do with you. If I tell you, you will think badly of me."

He shook his head. "Never. No matter what you say, I could never think badly of you."

"My sister. It was because I felt guilty about my sister. There were times when..." her voice dropped, and she began to cry. He held her tenderly and stroked her hair. "There were times I wished she would die. I never told you this, but the night after the dance, she told my father that I snuck out of the house." She sucked in a deep breath. "And he beat me. He beat me so badly I could barely walk. And I secretly wished she would die for telling on me, and well, for everything she did." She was weeping hard now. "And then, then she did die." She gulped for air. "I know I caused her death. My parents loved her. And my selfish wishes took her away from them."

"Greta, you mustn't believe that. It was an accident that caused Mary Beth's death. Not you. Not your wishes. You can't go on blaming yourself. This is not your fault."

She shrugged. "I know you believe that. But I can't. I feel so guilty."

"Shhhh, darling. Shhhh. It's all right."

"Do you forgive me?" She looked into his eyes. "I know I hurt you. And I never meant to."

"Of course I forgive you." He kissed her forehead. "And yes, you hurt me. But you have also brought me the greatest joy in my life. I will always love you, Greta. And if you can't be mine, at least it comforts me to know that you have married into wealth. I don't worry about you going hungry. You see, I love you more than I love myself."

"I love you too. And I will never forget today. Never, but I must go now," she said.

"Greta," Hermann took her in his arms. "I wish I could change things. But it's too late and I too, must return to my life. I took a vow to another woman, and I must keep my promise to her. So, I am asking you... no, I am begging you not to come back to see me ever again. I can't resist you,

Greta. So, for my sake. If you care for me at all, don't come back. What happened between us today was not right. We both know that. Even so, I will cherish it. However, we must make sure that it never happens again."

She nodded. She knew he was right. And yet, if he had asked her to run away with him and leave her comfortable life behind, at this moment in time she would agree. But he didn't ask. Hermann bent down and kissed Greta's lips gently. His lips were still warm with the passion of their love. "I am going, now. I must set up my cart. The customers will be coming soon. It hurts me more than I can ever express to say goodbye to you. But I must, Greta. I owe it to my wife." He stood up and helped her to her feet. She handed him his shirt, which he put on. Then he turned and walked away. When she could no longer see him, she sank back down to the ground, put her head in her hands, and wept.

Greta was sick with grief. But somehow, she felt a stirring in her womb, and she knew she would carry Hermann's child. She curled up and held her womb, wishing that she didn't have to return to Berlin. Greta was so caught up in her heartbreak that she never saw the young woman who was hiding and watching her as she wept.

It was almost nine am by the time Greta boarded a train heading back to Berlin. She had combed her hair and straightened her lipstick in the bathroom at the train station. And as the train whistle blew, she stared out the window and tried not to think of all she'd lost.

CHAPTER 60

It was after three o'clock that afternoon when Greta walked up the back stairs by the servant's quarters. Nora, who was on her way down, gave Greta a curious stare. "Ella said you weren't feeling well. She said you were in your room. So, why are you back here in the servant's quarters?"

Greta was stunned. She couldn't think of an answer quickly enough, so she didn't answer at all. She just pushed past Nora and continued up the stairs to her room.

Ella entered Greta's room a few minutes later. "You are very late," she said. "I thought you'd be back in earlier."

"I know. I'm sorry. Is everything all right here?" Greta asked nervously.

"Yes, I told the Lang's that you were sick and they believed me. Hurry and get undressed. Put on your nightdress quickly."

"Did anyone see you come in?"

"Nora saw me," Greta admitted rolling her eyes.

"Nosey thing that she is," Ella groaned. "Well, I am going to have to take care of her."

"What do you mean?"

"Never mind. Leave it to me. Right now, just get out of those clothes and put on your nightdress. Remember, if anyone asks how you are feeling, you tell them that you are ill. I'll bring you some food."

"Thank you," Greta said.

CHAPTER 61

Nora did not return to work the following day. “Will she be coming back?” Greta asked Ella.

“No,” Ella said bluntly.

“And what about Ludwig? Is he asking about her?”

Ella shook her head. “Ludwig has plenty of girls who are just like Nora. He doesn’t care if he has one more, or less.”

“What happened to her?”

“Don’t ask me questions, child. Just know that she is gone now and it is for the best.”

Greta looked at Ella and nodded. She wondered what Ella had said or done to make Nora leave her job. But she knew better than to ask again.

It was difficult not to think about Hermann. Sometimes, as Greta went through her daily activities, some small thing would remind her of him, and she would feel tears well in her eyes. Since her return from her visit with Hermann, she decided that she needed to do something to take her mind off her misery. She remembered when she was a little girl, she’d heard the pastor in her church say that the way to find happiness was in helping others who were less fortunate. So, she began volunteering at charities for the poor. And she found that what the pastor had said was true. Although the work was sometimes very hard, both physically and emotionally, she found it gave her a feeling of satisfaction. But she received no encouragement from her husband or in-laws. They treated her coldly until the following month, when she missed her period, and she told them she was pregnant. Next, she told Ella. Ella smiled, closing her eyes and laying

her hand on Greta's belly. "You're right, you are with child," she said. Then she opened her eyes, and her eyes met Greta's. "And it's a boy."

Herr Lang was overjoyed when he heard the news, and he immediately used his influence to have Greta's father released from the armed services and sent home. However, Herr Lang stopped Greta from going out of the house needlessly. "I don't want to risk accidents or disease," he said firmly. "I find your volunteer work with the poor to be quite admirable. However, the poor are usually quite dirty, and they carry disease. So, this work must stop."

She looked at him with fear in her eyes. *Does he plan to keep me a prisoner in this house?*

Herr Lang saw the look on Greta's face and said in a kind voice, "Just until the child is born. Then, of course, you can do as you like. However, you will be far too busy with your child to be bothered by volunteering. I feel it best that you don't spend time with the poor. We wouldn't want to bring disease into the house, especially when we have a young child living among us. I am sure you can find other things to do."

Although he said she could do as she pleased, Greta knew that was not the case. Herr Lang controlled everyone around him. Even so, he was unusually kind and very accommodating during her pregnancy. Her every wish was indulged. Even Ludwig was attentive to her as he'd never been before.

CHAPTER 62

DECEMBER 1917

Greta was allowed to go into town with the family chauffeur to buy Christmas gifts for her family and Ruth. She found that a dark cloud of misery and shame shrouded the city. There was very little inventory in the stores, and the usual enthusiasm that the German people had for the holiday season was nowhere to be found.

Early in her pregnancy, Greta woke up very sick each morning, vomiting and unable to eat. She was secretly terrified that something might be wrong with the baby. She thought of Zeno and shivered because she'd heard that his condition might run in families. She told Ella of her fears, but Ella reassured her that her nausea was quite normal and that it would pass.

Herr Lang heard her vomiting in the bathroom one morning and was terrified that she would miscarry. He told her to go right to bed and then called in a doctor who assured him she was fine, just pregnant. And as time passed, her belly rounded, and she began to feel much better. She was no longer sick to her stomach, and soon her cheeks blossomed with a healthy blush. By Christmas, she looked every bit the part of a very happy, pregnant wife.

Correspondence between Ruth and Greta continued. Except for the excitement of her coming child, Greta found Ruth's letters to be the greatest joy in her life. Greta told Ruth that she was pregnant, and Ruth was thrilled for her. However, Greta could not bring herself to tell Ruth that the child was not Ludwig's. She was ashamed of what she'd done. Greta explained that she would be close to giving birth and her father-in-law would never

allow her to travel; therefore, she would not be able to come to Ruth's wedding, which was planned for January. However, both she and Ruth knew that even if she were not pregnant, her father-in-law would never have allowed her to attend a Jewish wedding.

Greta had been taking short walks around the grounds each day to get some fresh air and exercise. But, as the weather grew colder and snow and ice covered the ground, Herr Lang, not wanting to risk her taking a fall, began to restrict Greta from going outside at all. She wanted to resist, but she had no energy. Greta was tired all the time anyway, and it was far easier to go to bed than it was to argue with Herr Lang.

Greta would often overhear Herr Lang talking with friends who came to visit. Most of the time they were discussing the fact that Germany had lost the war. She had been starved out by the British, they said. Greta knew that things were bad in her country, especially now that Germany was losing the war, but she had never really felt the effects in the Lang household. Although she knew that this was because of her father-in-law's connections with the black market, she still wished that she could ask Herr Lang what the future would bring. She wanted to know how her unborn child would be affected. But when she tried to discuss it with him, he told her that it was none of her concern. "This is men's business," he said in a firm, masculine voice, "you needn't worry about it. Your only job is to bring forth a healthy baby boy." Then he glared at her impatiently, "Now don't be thinking about the state of the world. Nothing, and I mean nothing, must get in the way of the birth of my grandson. My son's, son," he said proudly. "How I have waited for this."

Greta nodded. She closed her eyes and touched her belly. I pray that Ella is right, and that this child is a boy. I don't know what will happen if it's a little girl.

CHAPTER 63

APRIL 1918

Greta already loved the child that she felt growing quietly in her belly. It was a different kind of love than she'd ever known before. It wasn't the passionate, all-consuming, sexual love she'd felt for Hermann, or even the childlike love she felt for her brother Zeno. This was different. This was a protective love. For the first time, she felt that no sacrifice was too great for her little one. And since she became pregnant, she no longer felt alone. She talked to the baby often, giving the child a promise that no matter if it was a girl or a boy, she would always love it with all her heart. She vowed to never be like her parents and to make sure this baby knew love, no matter what. And even if she had a little girl and her father-in-law, or her husband, were disappointed and sent her away, she would never abandon her child. She would find a way to take care of this baby.

After a long, cold winter, spring finally arrived and the snow and ice melted. Herr Lang decided that since fresh air was good for the unborn child, he would permit Greta to take short walks outside once more. She was pleased. The air was fresh and brisk, and she felt rejuvenated by the tiny sprigs of grass that were peeking through the defrosting ground. A feeling of wellbeing consumed her. Soon her child would be born, and even though she would never have Hermann, and never again know the love of a man, she would devote her life to her offspring. Hermann's child. And she knew, she just knew, that this would be enough. Greta would love her baby so much that it would take the place of her parents, and even of Hermann.

April brought spring rains. The trees began to flower, and fresh green leaves unfurled on branches. Greta had always loved the season of spring the most, because it seemed that the earth was coming back to life. However, this spring was different. This spring a dark, unforeseen menace lurked beneath the beauty of the newborn foliage. A horrific, life-threatening disease had quietly begun to make its way through the town. People had begun showing signs of illness. Signs of flu. At first, Herr Lang chose to ignore the flu. When asked about it, he said it was a poor man's disease brought on by lack of proper nutrition. But his friend, who was a doctor, suggested that he forbid Greta from going into town while she was pregnant. "If you need anything from town, just send someone to get it for you. Meanwhile, stay at home until the child is born." She obliged, but she hated the fact that Herr Lang held so much power over her. But she had to agree. Nothing was more important to her than the baby she was carrying. And so, she stayed at home.

Tiny wildflowers bloomed all around the grounds of the Lang Estate. Greta's belly grew larger. And she became uncomfortable in the heat of the day. Then, on an exceptionally hot day in April, Greta went to bed in the afternoon to escape the heat. Sometime in her sleep she'd kicked the blankets off her, and even without them she lay sweating as the sun's rays filtered through her bedroom window. In her sleep, she began to feel a dull, aching pain. At first, she turned over and tried to ignore it. It stopped. Then, a little while later, it returned. This time the pain came on even stronger. It forced her to awaken. Ella had explained labor pains to her previously, so she knew what to expect, and she knew the time had come for the baby to arrive. Greta had been calm about the birth until now. Now she was suddenly frightened. She quickly got out of bed and went down the back stairs to Ella's room. "Ella, I am having pain. I think the baby is coming," she said as she knocked on the door to Ella's bedroom.

Ella didn't answer. Greta knocked louder, and in a desperate voice she cried out, "Ella, I need you. I think the baby is coming." Again, there was no answer. Then Greta realized that it was almost time for supper, and Ella would be in the kitchen, not in her room. She felt another pain come on and had to sit down on the floor and wait for it to pass. She let out a scream. For several moments she remained on the floor, breathing heavily as she waited for the pain to subside. Ella must have heard her scream because she came rushing down the stairs. "Oh dear," she said, "it looks like the baby's ready

to come into the world. Come on, dear, let's get you back to your room and I'll send for the doctor," she said as calmly as she could. Then she put her arm around Greta and helped her walk back to her bedroom.

"I'm scared," Greta admitted, squeezing Ella's shoulder. "It hurts so much."

"I know. Everyone is scared the first time. And yes, I know it hurts. However, when I was giving birth to my son, my mother told me that after he was born, I would forget the pain. I didn't believe her, but it was true. Once your child is born you will forget all the pain," Ella said, then reassuringly she added, "Don't be afraid. I'll be here with you. You are going to be just fine, and the baby is going to be fine too."

"What if something is wrong with my child?"

"Your child is going to be perfect. He'll be strong and healthy. You'll see."

"What if you're wrong about it being a boy? I am worried about what Herr Lang might do if the baby is a girl. Do you think he would hurt my little girl while I am still too weak to do anything to protect her?"

"First off, I told you the child is not a girl. It's a boy, and Herr Lang will be very happy. But just to reassure you, I promise you that if, somehow, I am wrong and it is a girl, I will protect her with my life until you are strong enough to take over. Does that make you feel better?"

Greta nodded as they walked into her bedroom.

"Good. Now lie down and stop worrying. I'm going to send for the doctor," Ella said as she helped Greta into bed.

"Don't leave me," Greta moaned and reached out to Ella.

"I'll be right back," Ella promised. "I have to send for the doctor."

Greta closed her eyes. In her mind's eye, she saw Hermann. How she wished he were her husband, and that he was sitting in the other room waiting for the birth of his child. A tear slid down her cheek. If Hermann were her husband instead of Ludwig, there would be no doctor. She would be lucky to afford a midwife. But even so, she would have had Hermann. *Someday his wife will labor like I am doing now, and he will be there worrying about her, loving her. Waiting for the birth of their child. He will never know that he has another child, and that I am that child's mother. This is a secret that I must take to my grave. At least I know that if Ella is right and I have a little boy, my son will live a good life as the son of a Lang. He will never go hungry or work so hard that it breaks his back. This will be*

my gift to him. I only pray to God that it is a boy, so at least he will know the love of a family, she thought. Suddenly she felt very sad and began to weep. But then Ella entered the room. She sat down at the end of the bed and took Greta's clammy hand in both of hers. "The doctor will be here soon."

Greta was an emotional wreck. "I can't stop thinking about Hermann," she whispered

"I know. I expected as much. But you must never question your choice. Hermann is married now. He has another life. He cannot be a father to your child."

"How do you know that Hermann is married. I know that I never told you?"

"Did you forget, Greta? I am a seer. I knew it all along."

Suddenly Greta began to believe everything Ella had told her about being a seer. And scared, but certain she needed to know the answer, she asked. "Ella, will I ever see Hermann again?"

But before Ella could answer, a tall, slim, white-haired doctor carrying a black leather bag entered the room. "Hello Greta," he said, smiling. Then, in an authoritative voice, he turned to Ella and said, "Go and get me a bowl with cool water and a rag. I want you to keep on washing the sweat from her brow."

Ella nodded. She gently freed her hand from Greta's grip. "I'll be right back," she promised.

Greta groaned. She heard Herr Lang speaking to Ella as she walked out of the room. "Is the baby all right?" he asked. "Has it been born yet?"

"Not yet," Ella said. "But I assure you that everything is fine, sir. Just go and sit down. The baby will come very soon," Ella reassured him.

Greta didn't hear Ludwig's voice or her mother-in-law's, and she knew that neither of them was outside the room waiting for the birth. Only Herr Lang waited.

Ella returned and gently sponged Greta's face as the harsh heat of the day and the pain caused her to sweat profusely. She labored for hours until she finally said she was too weak to go on. And it was just as she was about to give in to the pain, the doctor said in an encouraging tone, "Come on Greta. You can do this. The baby is coming. Get ready to push when I tell you to push."

"I can't, I'm too tired," Greta cried.

“Push, now,” the doctor said, “Come on. You are strong. Push.”

Greta moaned and tried to push.

“You must push harder,” Ella said, giving her hand to Greta. “Hold my hand and squeeze it as tightly as you can, and then with all of your strength, push.”

GRETA WAS TREMBLING from the effort. A bead of sweat dripped from her forehead onto the pillow, but she did as Ella told her. A cry of anguish and exhaustion escaped Greta’s lips. But she didn’t stop pushing. She pushed harder.

“Wait,” the doctor said.

Now the urge to push grew strong.

“All right. Ready? Now, push as hard as you can. The baby’s head is right here. It needs your help.”

“Ella, I don’t know if I can do this.” Greta cried out.

“You are strong, Greta. You can do this.” Ella insisted, wiping the sweat from her own brow with the back of her hand.

Greta gritted her teeth and pushed. Then she felt a rush of liquid like a river flow from her body, and on that river the baby floated into the world.

The doctor lifted the newborn, who was covered in mucus and blood. Then he held the child high in the air. Greta could hardly breathe; she was trembling from nerves, and she was still in pain. For a moment, a silence came over the room. *Is the baby alive? Had it been born dead?* Then she heard the doctor slap the baby’s bottom, and the infant let out a lusty cry.

“Congratulations, Frau Lang. You have a son!” the doctor said. He carefully cut the umbilical cord, and then he handed the tiny child to Greta.

She looked at the small, scrunched-up face, and she felt a strong wave of love come over her. Then, she turned her head to look up at Ella, who still sat beside her, and she said, “You were right. It’s a boy.”

Ella nodded as she quickly cleaned up the placenta, wrapping it in a towel to dispose of it outside the room. “And what a beautiful little boy he is.”

“Yes, he is, isn’t he?” Greta said proudly.

“I am going to go and tell Herr Lang the good news. Then I will return and take the child so I can give him a bath.”

“All right,” Greta smiled as the doctor began putting his equipment back into his black leather bag.

“Come with me doctor. Herr Lang will pay the remainder of your fee,” Ella led the doctor out of the room.

“I’ll be right back, Greta. I’ll stay with you for a little while to make sure everything is alright before I go.”

Greta was alone with her son for the first time. She marveled at the miracle of him, and tears of love and joy filled her eyes. “I love you, little one,” she whispered, as she gazed at him. “I promise that I will put you first before anyone or anything else in my life. I will give you the love my parents never gave me. And I will always shield you from harm, no matter what it may cost me.”

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CHAPTER 64

Herr Lang wanted the child to be named Siegfried for his father. Ludwig didn't care, and Greta, not minding the name at all, agreed. And very soon the name was shortened to Ziggy, which suited the child very well.

Each day, it became increasingly apparent that Herr Lang truly adored little Ziggy. And because Herr Lang was so happy that Greta had given him the grandchild he wanted so badly, he was exceptionally kind to her. Ludwig was as kind as he could be, but the truth was that he was not around much. However, when he was at home, he made an effort to show an interest in his son. One afternoon, as Ludwig and Greta sat on the patio having tea, Ludwig said, "I've never cared much for babies. They're so small and helpless. It makes me uneasy, because you must be so careful with them."

Just as he said that, Ella walked outside carrying a plate of cookies. She overheard the conversation. "Why don't you try to hold him, sir?" she said to Ludwig.

Greta nodded, "Yes, would you like to try?"

Ludwig shrugged. "I suppose," he said.

Greta handed Ziggy to his father, and the baby began to wail. This was unusual for the boy, because Ziggy was generally a happy infant. He adored his grandfather, who carried him around the house. And he loved Ella as if she were his grandmother, rather than Frau Lang. And he even tolerated Frau Lang. But anyone could see that Ziggy favored his mother. He loved her best. When Greta held him, the look on his tiny face was so filled with

contentment that nothing she was lacking in her life mattered. The only thing that mattered now was Ziggy.

For the rest of her days on earth, Greta would remember that summer as the best time of her life. She had never felt so much love, and not only her own love directed towards Ziggy, but his love sent back to her. She spent many blissful hours sitting outside, holding her tiny son with Herr Lang and Ella at her side. When Ludwig was around, he was kind and happy because he was pleased that she'd finally fulfilled his father's wish. Since Ziggy's birth, Herr Lang had given up on trying to change Ludwig. He put all his time and attention into his grandson. He no longer fought with Ludwig because Ludwig stayed out all night, and he no longer complained about Ludwig's excessive drinking or his gambling. Ludwig was glad to be free of his father's constant displeasure, and he showed his gratitude to Greta by treating her far more kindly than he had in the past. Although now that there was a child, he no longer came to her bed. Another wife may have been disappointed, but Greta was relieved. She knew that because of Ziggy, her position in the Lang household was secure.

The flu that had come earlier that year seemed to be disappearing; however, the fear it had brought was still lingering. But as fewer people fell ill, the terror began to subside. Wealthy people who had been able to hide in the safety of their homes now began to go out more. For the poor, nothing changed, as they had never had that luxury. Each day was a struggle just to survive.

Herr Lang commanded Ella to begin making her weekly trips to the market once again. He said he preferred the produce she chose rather than the produce that was brought by the others he'd sent to shop for the family. Ella didn't mind. Since the flu had begun, she'd been forbidden to go home and see her family. Herr Lang still had not yet given his permission for her to take a day off. However, now that she was able to get out, she could go home and see them, if only for a short time. Ella told Greta what she was doing. And Greta vowed she would cover for her. "No one will ever know," she told Ella, who smiled in gratitude. All was well. Until September, when the pestilence struck Berlin again like a bolt of lightning. Only this time the strain was much worse. This time, there were so many fatalities that even the mention of the flu sent terror through the hearts of the citizens of Berlin. Once again, Herr Lang stopped Ella from going to the market. He still

allowed Greta and the baby to go outside, but they were ordered never to leave the grounds.

Frau Lang hated being confined to the house. She had put up with it for several months, but when the flu all but disappeared, she immediately began to go out and socialize again. Then, when the flu returned, she fought with Herr Lang when he tried to restrict her from her social life. She refused to be restricted. Greta heard them fighting. Frau Lang declared that she would rather die than be a prisoner in the house again. In response, Herr Lang became incensed. Greta thought she heard him slap Frau Lang. Then Herr Lang told his wife that she was putting their grandson at risk, and she had better not defy his wishes.

She did not listen to her husband. Frau Lang didn't take orders from anyone. She did as she pleased. And one day when she returned from a benefit luncheon, she had a severe headache. Greta and Ella were in the kitchen when Frau Lang entered the room. "Ella I am going to lie down. Wake me when dinner is ready," she said, her face flush.

A look of worry passed between Ella and Greta. "I hope she's not sick," Greta said. She was thinking of her little boy and how young and vulnerable he was.

"She's sick, Greta. She has the flu," Ella said.

"Are you sure? I'm worried about Ziggy."

"He'll be all right."

When the food was on the table, Ella knocked on the door to Frau Lang's bedroom. But she refused to come out to eat. And by the time night fell, she was running a high fever. Herr Lang was furious with her. But he sent for a doctor. Then he sent for a woman who was willing to stay with her and nurse her.

"How is she?" Greta asked, when the woman who was nursing Frau Lang came out to get some water.

"She's very ill. Her body is trembling, and she says she's got the chills."

The nurse had left the door to the bedroom cracked a little and Greta could see Frau Lang laying on the bed. Her skin was very pale and blood trickled from her nose and mouth. Herr Lang called for the doctor, who returned quickly.

"What should I do with my wife?" he asked the doctor. "I am not worried so much about myself. I am an old man. I've lived a good life. But

my grandson is still just a baby. I don't want to lose him to this terrible disease."

The doctor nodded "Yes, I can understand, this flu is very contagious," he warned.

"Damn that woman, she should have listened to me! What can I do to protect the baby? I am terribly worried about him."

The doctor nodded. "I understand your fears. And you are right to have them," he said, clearing his throat, "Your grandchild is very young and that makes him very vulnerable. It seems that this disease is affecting very young children as well as the young adults the hardest. I don't think your wife will die, because she is older and the mortality rate with older people is not as bad. So, I think perhaps it's best that you send your wife to the country, somewhere clean and quiet, where she can recover and not expose your grandson to this terrible illness. Find a family that you can pay to take her in. Then close off the house. No one should be permitted to come in or to leave the house. If it were me, I would give my servants the choice of whether they want to stay here or go home for the duration of the disease. But they must not come and go. There is too great a chance that they will bring it back here."

"I've heard it said that this flu may last forever. It may never end. Is that really true? I didn't really believe it when it first started earlier in the spring. I thought it was just another flu. And then when it passed, I thought it was over. Now, I hear about death and disease running rampant and I am afraid that this might be the end of the world. A lot of people are saying that it is."

"People are scared. However, no one really knows what will happen. As a medical professional, I believe that this flu will pass. However, I also think there will be a great deal of death before it does. So, do as I say. Don't allow anyone to go out or come into your home. Even if they show no signs of illness, they could be carriers," The doctor said, then he put on his hat and left.

CHAPTER 65

Herr Lang did as the doctor ordered. It was not difficult to find a family who, for a substantial fee, would allow his wife to stay with them in the country. People were poor, and they were starving. So, they were willing to take the risk of being exposed to the flu. Once Ludwig's mother was on her way to the country, Herr Lang forbade everyone, including Ludwig, from leaving the house. Ludwig became angry and refused to adhere to his father's demands. "I can't risk you bringing that disease into this house. I want you to leave here and go and stay with your cousin in Munich. I can't trust you, and I won't let you put Ziggy in danger."

Ludwig shrugged. Then he told Greta that he preferred to stay with his cousin. He said that they were very much alike, and he knew he would enjoy his time in Munich. She didn't mind. She was grateful to Herr Lang for protecting her son.

But she felt bad for Ella, who was distraught that once again she was going to be unable to go home on her day off. "I don't know how I am going to survive this again. I could go home and stay there, but you need me here too. I just don't know what to do. As I've told you, I sometimes take food home with me on my day off. Now my family will have to do without that as well."

"I don't know if this helps, but if you decide that you want to go home, I will do my best to sneak food out to you each week. We could meet somewhere at the edge of the grounds, and I will give you the food."

"I can't let you do that. By meeting with me, you would be putting your son in danger, because once I am outside of this house I will be exposed to

the virus. I can't do that to you or to Ziggy," she said, "However, you've given me an idea."

"Tell me."

"What if we smuggle some food out and leave it at the end of the yard. I will send my daughter-in-law a letter telling her where to find it. At least that will help them to have enough to eat. Maybe we can do that for them."

"I'll help you," Greta promised.

And so, each day, they put some food away, not enough to be missed. Just enough to make a difference in Ella's family's life. A little flour, a couple of potatoes, a cabbage, and a few carrots. They stored them in a small box in a hiding place under the floor. Once a week, they wrapped the food in a large towel and left it at the edge of the property. Then, late at night, while the Lang family slept, Ella's daughter-in-law collected the package. Ella told Greta that she received a letter from her daughter-in-law thanking her for the food. But it also stated that since Ella could not provide any money, her daughter-in-law had gotten a job so she could pay the rent. This meant that she was out working, which gave her even more exposure to the virus. "What can I do? I suppose I could leave my wages with the package each week."

"That might be a good idea," Greta agreed.

Ella wrote to her daughter-in-law telling her that she planned to leave her wages in the package of food that she left for her each week. Then Ella waited for an answer. But she did not receive a letter in return. And that week the package was never retrieved.

"Something is terribly wrong," Ella said, her voice shaking.

"You're a seer, can't you see what is happening?" Greta asked.

"I wish I could use my gift at will, but it isn't like that. I get messages but I cannot ask questions," Ella said, shaking her head. Then she turned and looked firmly into Greta's eyes, "I'm sorry, my dear, but I must go home. I must see what is happening there. If I don't return, you will have to go on without me."

"I understand," Greta said, but she was shaking. She was terrified for Ella. The disease had an iron grip on the city, and people were dropping like rag dolls in the streets. "Don't worry," Greta offered Ella reassurance. "I'll cover for you. I'll tell my father-in-law that you are ill and staying in your room, so you don't infect the rest of us. I will offer to do all the cooking to make things easier for him. That way you will be able to come back."

“You can’t tell him I am ill. He will want me to get out of this house immediately if he thinks I am sick. You must not tell him that. He is terrified of this plague that is going around the city. I think it’s best if we tell him that I hurt myself in the kitchen. Say I burned my hand badly and am unable to cook and that you would like to do the cooking for a while. I don’t think he will argue with you. This way, if all is well at home, I will return and he won’t lock me out, because he won’t know I was ever gone.”

“Good idea,” Greta said.

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CHAPTER 66

12TH NOVEMBER 1918

The following morning, the German people were dealt a blow. It was official now; Germany had lost the war. One morning, her father-in-law sat reading the newspaper. Greta sat down at the kitchen table to join him for breakfast, and with a solemn look on his face he turned to Greta and said, “This is a terrible day for our Fatherland,” he put the paper down on the table, and he hung his head.

She leaned forward and read the headlines on the front of the paper. Then she read them again, just to be sure she’d read them correctly. The war was over. For this, she was glad. However, things had not turned out well for Germany.

“May I see this?” she asked, as she pointed to the newspaper.

“By all means,” he replied. She picked up the paper and read that an armistice had been signed in France, and now the fighting was over. The soldiers would soon begin to return home. She was glad that the fighting was over, but sorry to hear that her country had suffered a defeat. For a moment Greta thanked God that Hermann had not been conscripted—the thought made her shiver. *What if he had been killed in battle?* She knew he wanted to serve because he had never wanted his leg to stop him from doing things he felt were normal, and besides that, she knew that he loved his country. So, if he had been asked to serve, she was sure he would have gone.

CHAPTER 67

Herr Lang was not disappointed by Ella's absence. In fact, he raved to Greta about her cooking. "Nothing like the cooking of a farm girl," he said, flattering her.

"I am glad you are enjoying it," she said.

"I am," he nodded, smiling.

Two days passed, and no one asked how Ella was doing. It amazed Greta to see how easily Ella was forgotten in the Lang household. She knew that her husband's family thought of their servants as dispensable. But Ella had been with the family for such a long time that Greta thought they would have cared more for Ella. Greta had come to care for Ella a great deal, and she was worried about her.

One night, in the wee hours when the family slept, almost a week since Ella had gone home, there was a knock on Greta's bedroom door. It woke Greta almost immediately. "Who is it?" she whispered, hoping Ludwig had not returned.

"It's me, Ella."

Greta flung the door open. "Come in, quickly," she said. "Are you all right?"

"I am all right. But there have been some changes at my home. My daughter-in-law had the flu and, God rest her soul, she has passed on."

"Oh, I am terribly sorry. Is your grandson all right?"

"Yes, thanks be to God. He was spared. He didn't get the flu. But of course, he is distraught at losing his mother."

"Of course he is," Greta said. "I am so sorry. What will you do now?"

“Well, I must work, because there is no money for food or rent if I don’t. So, I had to leave him alone and come back.”

Greta shook her head. “How old did you say he was?”

“Eight.”

“He’s too young to be left alone. Anything could happen. I have an idea,” Greta said. “Bring him here to the house and hide him in your room. I will go down and see him each day. I will help you with the cooking, so you can spend time with him. This way you won’t need to continue paying your rent. You will have a place to live, and no one will notice that a little extra food is missing. What do you think?”

“If we get caught, Herr Lang will be furious at both of us,” Ella said, contemplating the plan.

“That only means that we must not get caught. Now, go and get your grandson. Hurry and bring him back here with you. When you have returned, come back to my room and let me know that you’re back and he’s with you,” Greta said.

“All right. I’ll hurry.”

“Yes, make sure you return before dawn.”

“I will,” Ella said, then she hugged her. “Thank you, Greta.”

CHAPTER 68

There was a small knock at her bedroom door, and Greta got up and opened it carefully.

“Come downstairs.” Ella whispered to Greta.

Greta followed Ella to her room, and when they opened the door, there sat a small boy.

“This is Wilhelm.” Ella said as she introduced Greta to her grandson.

“Hello Wilhelm. I’m Greta,” Greta said as gently as possible. “I’m going to do my best to assure that you are happy here.”

Ella and Greta were standing in Ella’s room. Wilhelm sat on the bed, looking down at the floor. He didn’t speak, he just looked up at her and nodded.

Greta looked into the wizened eyes of a very somber eight-year-old boy. She felt sorry for Wilhelm, who was a quiet child. She hoped that his morose nature was only because he had just suffered a terrible loss and that as time passed, he would come out of his shell and be less withdrawn. And although she didn’t mention her fears to Ella, she was secretly worried that Ella or Wilhelm might have brought the fever into the house.

True to her word, Greta helped Ella with the cooking. Which gave Ella time to visit with Wilhelm. Greta also made time each day to visit Wilhelm, who remained quiet and very withdrawn. She assumed he must be bored. The child was unable to go outside. He had no one to play with. Not only had he lost both of his parents, but he’d been torn away from his home and his friends. Greta looked to help him. She knew loneliness. And since Greta loved to read, and it helped her when she was young, she thought that reading might be the escape he needed. The next time she went to see him,

she brought a few books with her. "Can you read?" Greta kindly asked Wilhelm.

"No, I never learned. I never went to school."

"Would you like me to teach you?" Greta asked, smiling. "I promise you that reading will open a whole new wonderful world for you. It did just that for me."

Wilhelm shrugged. "I don't need to learn," he said sullenly. "I'm not really interested."

"I understand. But I have an idea," Greta winked. "Why don't we start this way, I'll read to you. And you can see how you like it. Then if you do, I'll find books for you that you will enjoy. Come on Wilhelm, I would be happy to teach you."

He nodded unenthusiastically.

At least he agreed to let me read to him. That is a start. Greta thought.

When the person who went to the market for the family arrived at the beginning of the following week, Greta gave him money and handed him a list of three books she wanted him to purchase at the bookstore for her. "Can you read them to me?" he asked.

"Of course," she said. These were books that were not available in Herr Lang's library. But Greta had read them, and she thought that Wilhelm would like them. "The Merry Adventures of Robin Hood, Robinson Crusoe, and The Count of Monte Cristo," she said.

He repeated the titles, and she realized he couldn't read either, he'd memorized them. Then he asked, "You want all of them?"

"Yes," Greta said. "If you can get them."

He nodded. "I'll do my best."

When he returned later that day, Greta was thrilled to see that he had all three of her selections. She was quite sure that Wilhelm would enjoy them.

The following afternoon, while Ella prepared the evening meal in the kitchen, upstairs Greta began reading Robinson Crusoe to Wilhelm. At first, he was disinterested, but she noticed as she turned the fifth page of the book, he had begun listening intently. And so began Wilhelm's love of literature. By the time Greta had finished reading all three books to Wilhelm, he was eager to learn to read. She began teaching him and found him to be a bright and eager student.

Two weeks after Wilhelm's arrival, Herr Lang gathered the servants, as well as Greta and Siegfried, into the main hall.

“I have some rather bad news to deliver,” he said. “I am afraid that Frau Lang will not be returning. She has succumbed to the virus.” Greta hardly knew her mother-in-law. They had barely spoken to one another. Yet she felt bad to hear that the woman had passed away. However, her father-in-law didn’t seem heartbroken at all as he delivered his message. He just took a deep breath, then went on to say, “So, as you can see, this disease is quite dangerous. We must now be even more careful not to bring this terrible pestilence into our home.”

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CHAPTER 69

JANUARY 1919

Once again, the flu seemed to go away almost as quickly as it had arrived. There were fewer cases. And this time, people were convinced that it was gone for good. Herr Lang longed to believe it, and so he began to relax his restraints on the staff. However, Ella and Wilhelm did not move out of the Lang's home. No one, not even the other servants, no one but Greta, knew that Wilhelm was staying with them. Ella and Greta had discussed it, and they decided that it was far less expensive if Ella did not have to pay rent. And they were both glad that Wilhelm would not be home alone all week. There were so few cases of the flu that Herr Lang decided it was safe for him to begin to travel again. He even returned to his visits to the exclusive men's club where he was a member. Consequently, he was not home as often as he had been during the pandemic. This gave Wilhelm an opportunity to leave the servants' quarters and go outside for some fresh air. However, it was cold, so he did not stay out long. He told Greta that he preferred to stay inside and read.

It was an uneventful year. And after the terror of the flu, Greta was glad to be experiencing a more peaceful time. Ludwig did not return from Munich, and Greta didn't miss him. He was always troubled, and so she was relieved to have him gone.

It had been a while since Greta had received a letter from Ruth. This worried her. She hoped Ruth had survived the pandemic. The idea of Ruth dying was so devastating, she couldn't bear to think of it. But Greta had to know if Ruth was alright, so she sat down and wrote to her. A return letter

arrived a couple of weeks later. Ruth explained that she'd been very busy. They had all been sick with the flu at various times. Even so, she and Lieb had gotten married as planned. And, before they contracted the disease, Ruth had gotten pregnant. But she was very sorry to have to tell Greta that she'd lost the baby. And even worse, Ruth explained why she had avoided writing; she said it because she had terrible news and didn't know how to tell Greta. Bubbie had gotten the flu, and she passed away. Greta's hands shook as she stood there holding the letter. Then she lay down in bed and wept until her eyes hurt and she fell asleep. And that night she dreamed of the old woman and remembered how Bubbie had made her feel loved and wanted, the way her parents had failed to do. It took Greta several days before she could bring herself to write back to Ruth. She expressed how sorry she was to hear about Bubbie. "I loved her," she said. "I really loved her."

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CHAPTER 70

APRIL 1919

On a dark, rainy, and windy afternoon, Herr Lang walked into the house after returning from a visit with a friend. Unsuccessfully, he tried to shake the rainwater off his coat, but he had very little energy. Greta greeted him at the door and felt a chill run down her spine when she saw that his skin was a shade of light gray.

“Are you alright, sir?” she asked.

“Of course,” he assured her, “I’m just tired. I’m going to my room to lie down for a bit. Don’t worry about me,” he smiled, but she thought she saw pain in his eyes. That evening he did not come to the dining room for dinner. Greta asked Ella if she could please bring a tray of food up to Herr Lang.

“I did,” Ella said. “He thanked me. But when I returned to see if he needed anything, he had not touched a bite.”

Greta was concerned. Very softly, so as not to disturb him if he was asleep, she knocked on the door to Herr Lang’s room. “Herr Lang. Father,” she didn’t call him that often, but for some reason she felt compelled to do it today. “It’s me, Greta.”

“Is the child with you?” he said in a gravelly voice.

“No, Ziggy is not with me. He is in his room. I am alone.”

“All right. You can come in, but don’t come too close to me. I’m afraid I might be very ill, Greta,” he said, his voice broken.

She did as he asked.

“I thought the flu was over,” Herr Lang sighed. “I was wrong. I am feeling quite terrible. I hate to admit this, but I believe I am dying. You must send for Ludwig right away. I need to speak to him before I pass on. It’s important that I have a few minutes with him. And to be honest, I don’t know how much longer I have. So, be sure that you send a telegram to his cousin in Munich tonight explaining that Ludwig must be on the next train home. Can you do this for me?” He asked, but before she could answer, he started coughing. Then he spat into a handkerchief that had his initials embroidered in gold thread on it. She caught a glimpse of the handkerchief before he folded it up and put it under his pillow. What she saw was blood, and she was terrified. Herr Lang had always run the house. Not that he was perfect; he had a temper, and he was demanding. However, she knew what to expect from him. Now, if he passed away, Ludwig would be in charge. And she feared his lack of stability more than anything. Herr Lang cleared his throat, interrupting her thoughts, and she could hear him wheezing; he was winded from the effort.

“Yes, of course I will send a telegram. I’ll do it right away,” she said, turning to leave, but before she was able to go, he spoke.

“Now, this is very important. Listen to me. You must be sure that you keep Ziggy as far away from my room as you can. I know how much he adores me, and he has often come into my room when he has nightmares. My door must be locked. Only you will have a key. That way Ziggy won’t be able to get in.” His voice sounded as if he were drowning. Herr Lang coughed hard, clearing his throat, “Now you will find the address where Ludwig is staying in the top right drawer of my desk.”

“I’ll take care of it right away,” she promised.

“Go now. Get out of this room. This damn flu is very contagious and quite deadly. Ziggy will need you. And...” he hesitated, then shook his head, “so will my wayward halfwit of a son.”

Greta closed the door behind her and ran downstairs to Herr Lang’s study. And she quickly wrote the telegram to Ludwig.

CHAPTER 71

Ludwig did not answer the telegram. Greta fretted each day. Then she sent another one. Again, he didn't answer.

"Have you sent for my son?" Herr Lang asked her.

"I have. I sent two telegrams. I don't know what else to do."

"I would send you to Munich to get him, but I can't risk having you travel. This disease is out there, and it is just waiting like a demon. You and I must protect our little Ziggy. Get in contact with my lawyer. Tell him I must adjust my will. If Ludwig does not return before I die, everything will belong to Ziggy. You, being his mother will have to be in charge of it until Ziggy is old enough to understand."

Greta nodded.

"This," Herr Lang said, "is why I chose you. I needed a responsible girl who answers to God. A girl who will do right by my family name and my family fortune. I have every reason to believe you will do this." He began to cough. This time blood ran down his chin. Then he added, "You've shown me that you can be trusted. You kept your word. You gave me a grandson."

She began to cry. He didn't know why, but the guilt of what she'd done came over her. However, she knew that she must never tell him the truth—that Ziggy was not a Lang.

Ludwig returned home in the middle of the night, almost a full a week later. "I received your letter and came as quickly as I could," he said. "I had things to sort out before I could leave Munich. Anyway, where is my father?"

"He's in his room," Greta said.

Ludwig ran up the stairs and, without knocking on the door, he entered his father's bedroom. Greta could not hear what was said. But when Ludwig came out, his face was swollen and red with tears.

"My mother is dead. Now my father is dying. I am to be an orphan, Greta. All I have left in this world is my son," he said, sobbing. "I promised my father that I would raise Ziggy properly. I told him I would make sure that my son was a shining example of the Lang name. I will do this. I will do whatever I must to ensure that Ziggy grows up to be the man I couldn't be."

She nodded, but she found him so repulsive she couldn't even look at him. *Ludwig treats me like a servant. He says all he has left in the world is Ziggy. He doesn't even think of me as family. I mean nothing to him. I never have. How will he treat me once my father-in-law no longer has any hold on him?* She shivered.

But Ludwig did not even notice. He walked into his bedroom and closed the door.

Greta went to check on Ziggy. Quietly she crept up to the bed where he slept, and she glanced at his little face and thought she could see a small resemblance to Hermann. Her heart swelled with love for her son, and she realized that nothing Ludwig said or did really mattered. He was a weak man, and he would not put her out because he would need her to help him raise Ziggy.

The next morning, when Ella brought Herr Lang his breakfast tray, she found him dead.

CHAPTER 72

After the funeral, Greta spoke to Ella. “Ludwig has no idea of anything that has been going on here while he was gone. So, I plan to tell him that his father employed Wilhelm to help me with Ziggy. I will tell him that Herr Lang felt that Ziggy needed a boy to help him to learn how to get along with other boys.”

“Get along with other boys?”

“Yes. He has been isolated most of his life due to this pandemic. So, as he grows, Wilhelm will be here to teach him to do things like learning to fence. Also to play futbol and whatever else young boys do.”

“I suppose so. But I am afraid Wilhelm doesn’t know any of these things.”

“Wilhelm can read to him. That’s for sure. And he can teach Ziggy to love books. As far as the rest of it, I’ll hire someone to teach them both when Ziggy is old enough. I mean he’s only one year old now, so he won’t require much from Wilhelm. Besides, don’t worry. Ludwig won’t care, as long as Ziggy doesn’t get into trouble. And if he thinks his father hired Wilhelm, he’ll be very agreeable to the situation. Once we’ve established this, Wilhelm won’t need to stay downstairs in your room all day anymore. I’ll pay him a salary, and he’ll be able to come up and live a normal life. He’ll even be able to go outside and play freely without worrying about getting caught on the grounds. What do you think?”

“I think it will be wonderful for Wilhelm, if you think it will work.”

“I know it will,” Greta winked at Ella.

When Ludwig heard that his father had hired Wilhelm, he instantly embraced the idea. Ludwig had little patience for a young child and was

pleased to have someone else who had been hired to play with Ziggy.

The doctor who had treated Herr Lang was a friend of the family. He knew Ludwig very well, and after the funeral he warned Ludwig that the flu was still going around. "Stay in your house," he advised, "Don't you go running around to all the taverns and gambling halls. You have a son now who's health you must consider," the doctor said sternly.

Ludwig nodded, but he was beginning to feel trapped. He longed to get out of the house. He wanted to gamble, and drink, and have women on his arm. But his father's last words haunted him, and because of them, he managed to stay inside.

Then by Summer 1919, the threat of the Spanish flu subsided. Ludwig heard that there were fewer and fewer cases. He couldn't bear another day stuck in the house. The truth was that no one knew if it would return, as it had so many times before. Ludwig began going out a few nights a week. In the morning, each time after he'd spent a night carousing, he would wake up hung over and guilty, swearing to Greta that he would not do it again. But a few days later, he would forget his promise. He began driving the automobile his father left behind. And each night he went out, he took the car.

Then he received a letter from his cousin in Munich.

Dear Ludwig.

I wish you didn't have to leave. I've missed you. We did have some fun, didn't we?

Well, I want you to know that I was sorry to hear about your father's passing. He was a good man. A true Lang. A true German.

I don't know if it's possible, but I want to invite you to return to Munich. You see, I have happened upon a wonderful new political party. I was out one evening and I was in a bier hall where I happened to hear a man speak. Oh, if only you could see him. He is the most incredible man I've ever heard. He shines a bright light on the future of our Fatherland. And because of his words, I have found a purpose. And I would love to share his philosophies with you. Before I heard him, I had begun to feel like my life was futile. I had lots of good times, but I had no purpose. Then everything changed in that bier hall.

I found out that he will be speaking on 24th February 1920 in Hofbrauhaus in Munich. I received an invitation and I plan to go there to hear his speech. Why don't you take a little time away from Berlin and

accompany me? I think you will find it inspiring and enlightening. Let me know if and when you plan to come so I can have the maids put your room in order.

Your cousin and friend, Hans.

Ludwig missed Hans and all the fun they'd had when he was in Munich. The letter had set his heart on fire. He longed to return.

Ludwig had been consumed with guilt at not living up to his father's wishes for him. And so, when on his deathbed, Herr Lang had told him he had been a terrible disappointment and the only way to fix that was to change his ways, he'd tried to do as his father asked. And for a short while he'd succeeded. Herr Lang wanted Ludwig to stay at home and put all his effort into raising his son. But now that time had passed, Ludwig's guilt was overshadowed by his longing to return to his old way of life. So, under the guise of a lofty goal, a new and important political interest, Ludwig made arrangements to go back to Munich for a week.

CHAPTER 73

MUNICH
FEBRUARY 1920

Hans was happy to see Ludwig. He met him at the train station, took him to a tavern and bought him a beer. On the outside, Hans looked the same, but Ludwig could tell that his cousin had somehow changed. As they sat in the tavern sipping the delicious dark beer, Hans wasn't looking around for a woman to spend the night with. This was unusual for Hans. Instead, he was speaking excitedly about the upcoming political rally that he wanted Ludwig to attend with him. "I'm telling you, just give it a chance. I promise this man who will be speaking will change you in ways you won't believe," Hans said, his voice loud with excitement.

Ludwig nodded. He was unconvinced and not happy with the changes in his cousin. *I liked Hans better before*, he thought.

As planned, the following night Hans and Ludwig went to the rally. Before they even arrived, Ludwig was eagerly awaiting the end of it so that he and Hans could go to a local tavern and have a few drinks. Ludwig surveyed the room. There were lots of good-looking women, and Ludwig wondered what it might take to get them to go to bed with him. They were obviously interested in this political party. So, to talk to them and win them over, he thought he should know a little more about it. Nudging Hans with his elbow, Ludwig asked him, "So, what is the name of this political party anyway?"

"It's called The National Socialist German Workers Party. And just wait until you hear all the wonderful ideas they have. This is what we need to

bring Germany back up to her rightful place in the world. The war was terrible. It tried to break us. Do you know why we lost?"

"I don't know. I assume we didn't have enough manpower?" Ludwig had no interest in politics.

"It was because of the Jews. The Jews caused Germany to lose the war. But the Fatherland will rise again. Mark my words," Hans said, his eyes shining.

"The Jews? What did they have to do with it?"

But before Hans could answer, a man about five feet eight inches tall with a comical little mustache walked up onto the stage. The crowd roared and clapped until the man raised his hands. Only then did they grow quiet. The man began to speak, very softly at first. Ludwig glanced over at Hans, who was mesmerized by the speaker. Ludwig shrugged. He was not impressed; he was looking around the room to see if he might find a woman who caught his interest. But then, as the speaker continued and gathered momentum, his voice grew louder and more passionate. The crowd roared with approval. Ludwig began to listen. And it was then that he found himself enthralled. He began to hang onto the speaker's every word.

"Germany will rise up!" the speaker hollered. And the crowd went wild. "You good Germans are superior men and women. It is your birth right! We will rule the world!"

There was an invisible electricity shooting from the speaker through the room, and the entire crowd was ignited by it.

Ludwig was sorry that the speech ended. He could have listened to this man forever. As the little man walked off the podium, Ludwig turned to Hans, both of their faces illuminated by the excitement of the moment. "Who was that man?" Ludwig asked. "He's incredible."

"I know. I told you that you would feel this way once you heard him speak. His name is Adolf Hitler," Hans replied. "Keep your eye on him, because he is the man who is going to save our Fatherland."

A cold gust of wind blew through the beer hall. It was a whistle from the devil calling to his minions on the deadly winds of change.

CHAPTER 74

Spring had finally arrived. But Lily could not see the beauty surrounding her. She was consumed with hatred for Ludwig, and she was still unable to move on after the tragedy of David's death. She awoke one cloudy morning, and instead of meeting her father to go to the jewelry store, Lily wrapped a scarf around her head and made her way down the street and out of the Jewish neighborhood where she had grown up. She walked quickly and cautiously so that none of her neighbors would see her. Until finally, she found herself at a little pfandleihanstalt, a pawnshop, where she knew she could get items that were on the black market.

Lily looked around to make sure no one had followed her, and when she felt as though she was safe, she walked inside. She didn't make eye contact with the man behind the counter, but she could hear his thunderous voice ask her, "Hello little lady, how may I help you?" He seemed to be mocking her.

"I'll take that one." Lily didn't look up, but she pointed down to a gun inside the glass case.

"That's a lot of metal for a girl like you." The voice was intimidating and deep.

"I will take it, and 3 bullets." Lily said, reaching into her purse and pulling out a wad of Marks. *Three bullets, just in case I miss.* She finally looked up and met the man's eyes. They were cold and dark, and she felt like running, but she knew she must complete her task. *If I don't do this, I will never move on. I must make him suffer, the same as he has made me suffer.*

The man took her money and handed her several bullets. “Good luck.” He let out a short laugh.

Lily grabbed the gun and ammunition, shoved them into her purse and ran out of the store and down the street until she felt she was out of sight.

She stopped in a dark alley and opened her purse. When she saw the black gun inside, it made her shudder. But she faced the wall, took it out, and loaded it with the bullets. Then she began walking towards the nice part of town.

After what felt like miles, she arrived at his home. *I must do this. I must do it for David. I must do it for me; Ludwig Lang must die.* The gun felt heavy in her purse, and her shoulder ached. But she crouched down behind a flowering bush that had just begun to bloom. She took the gun out and held it in her hand, her heart beating loudly in her ears as she waited for what felt like hours. *Where is he?* She thought. Finally, the front door creaked as it opened. And Lily gripped the gun in her hand tightly. Her palms were sweaty, and her heart was racing. *This is the moment. This is for you, David.* But as the door opened, a young woman with a small baby in her arms came out. A butterfly flew across the child’s face, and he giggled with joy. *That’s her. That’s Greta, and that must be Ludwig’s son. I could take this gun and kill him. That will surely ruin him. His heir. His boy.* Lily grabbed the gun tighter and pointed it at the small child. Her hand shook as she tried to hold it steady. She rested her finger on the trigger but, try as hard as she might, she could not bring herself to squeeze it. *I can’t.* Tears flowed from her eyes and down her cheeks. *If I kill this child, I am just as bad as he is. Hashem. Guide me. Help me. Please Hashem.*

Suddenly, a cool breeze came across her face, and the sun crept out from behind a cloud and shone down on her head. It was like God was there with her. And Lily had a moment of knowing. *I must use Greta. I must wait, and one day I will turn his wife and his precious son against him. I will make them see Ludwig for what he truly is, and I will make them hate him the way I do.*

A Note From The Author

I always enjoy hearing from my readers, and your thoughts about my work are very important to me. If you enjoyed my novel, please consider telling your friends and posting a short review on [Amazon](#) and/or [Goodreads](#).

Word of mouth is an author's best friend.

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I send blessings to each and every one of you,

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p.s. Keep reading for more information on [My Son's Duty](#) - the second book in the *Duty and Betrayal* series.

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR



I wanted to take a moment to introduce myself. My name is Roberta, and I am an author of Historical Fiction, mainly based on World War 2 and the Holocaust. While I never discount the horrors of the Holocaust and the Nazis, my novels are constantly inspired by love, kindness, and the small special moments that make life worth living.

I always knew I wanted to reach people through art when I was younger. I just always thought I would be an actress. That dream died in my late 20's, after many attempts and failures. For the next several years, I tried so many different professions. I worked as a hairstylist and a wedding coordinator, amongst many other jobs. But I was never satisfied. Finally, in my 50's, I worked for a hospital on the PBX board. Every day I would drive to work, I would dread clocking in. I would count the hours until I clocked out. And, the next day, I would do it all over again. I couldn't see a way out, but I prayed, and I prayed, and then I prayed some more. Until one morning at 4 am, I woke up with a voice in my head, and you might know that voice as Detrick. He told me to write his story, and together we sat at the computer; we wrote the novel that is now known as All My Love, Detrick. I now have over 30 books published, and I have had the honor of being a USA Today Best-Selling Author. I have met such incredible people in this industry, and I am so blessed to be meeting you.

I tell this story a lot. And a lot of people think I am crazy, but it is true. I always found solace in books growing up but didn't start writing until I was in my late 50s. I try to tell this story to as many people as possible to inspire them. No matter where you are in your life, remember there is always a flicker of light no matter how dark it seems.

I send you many blessings, and I hope you enjoy my novels. They are all written with love.

Roberta



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